

THE ART OF FREE COOPERATION

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Edited by
Geert Lovink and Trebor Scholz

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COLLABORATION ON THE FENCE

Geert Lovink and Trebor Scholz

Life kicks off with collaboration. You can run from it but you cannot avoid it. It catches up with you. The chemistry between you sets it into motion. The cycle gets going. And after an intense period of the heart, things return to normal. The newness fades away. There is a breakup, a loss of interest. A friendship emerges. The job is done. You move on and forget the common miscommunication, the fights, the disrespectful ego trips, or worse: the belligerent silences.

In this book we reflect on the dynamics of (online) collaboration. We cannot merely praise it as if it were a product — or deconstruct it as just another ideology (which it is). What we are looking for is nothing less ambitious than laws, underlying mechanisms, common experiences that can be boiled down to strong, everlasting memes, recommendations and sayings that will stay with us for times to come. We propose a laboratory of thought and experimentation for future forms of collaboration! We do not join the gospel of business analysts who seek collaboration as a tool to grow wealth for the already prosperous! We

are keen to support self-organized cultural activities and their use of technologies of cooperation. The problem with this topic is that we seem to learn so little when it comes to advanced social interaction. The knowledge of collaboration is not a passive one that you can acquire and then apply. The question is not: how do I fit in? We are only human once and are destined to fail. Nonetheless, with a taste for self-reflection we can evolve. With the rise of individualization, collaboration becomes increasingly something that we perceive as “voluntary,” almost like a commodity we can purchase. One can witness a growing curiosity, as if it were some old, forgotten ritual, or exotic experience. “Collaboration? Sounds interesting. Can I try it? Please do — we offer a 30-day free trial.”

An aspect that sparked our attention is the partial lack of, and desire for participation. Cooperative projects are increasingly investigated as a way to motivate the online many to contribute. The issue here is to distinguish between top-down teamwork in the labor mill and its management rhetoric. Into this context Christopher Spehr launches his concept of “free cooperation.” “Please empty your tray in the trash — thank you for your cooperation” is not a “free cooperation.” It’s friendly fascism, as Bertram Gross puts it. Between “free and independent” and “forced” there is a growing gray zone of projects, applications and practices that are not aimed at productivity gains. And they are not entirely autonomous and renegade either. There is no complete snow-white innocence. We all have institutional dirt under our fingernails. There is no total autonomy of collaborative projects. Working together does not exempt us from systemic complicity. The greedy, self-aggrandizing enemy is inside us all. The Free Cooperation conference, which we organized in April 2004 in Buffalo,¹ put these contentious matters on the table.

In the growing collaboration hype the “alternative economy” aspect is under-examined thus far. If we know that we can get a piece of software, music or a book for free through our social network, why would we bother to buy it? Why pay for Britannica if Wikipedia has a comparable yet free offer? We are willing to live with (and work on) the many problems of this free encyclopedia. We shed no tears for those waspy

**Notes from the Free
Cooperation Listserv**

From Christoph Spehr,
Sept. 8: I'm not a believer
in simple "non-hierarchical"
or "free" structures,
because there are always
rules, responsibilities, structures
of decision making
and so on — the question
is, which ones.

From Greg Sholette, referring to his text "counting on your collective Silence: Notes on activist art as Collaborative Practice" (Afterimage, 1999), Sept. 7: The text is primarily an attempt to complicate assumptions about collective work including the notion that it is about finding a "unified voice." I argue that disagreement and difference is more often the basis for collective work than unanimity. I also assert that the standard opposition of collective vs. individual is irrelevant today insofar as we are already collectivized by corporate marketing technology even

pipe smoking Britannica editors! They are out-collaborated. To what extent can collectively created content repositories challenge or parallel the content hegemonies of traditional institutions? Howard Rheingold describes how knowledge collectives hunt and gather information. These accumulative collaborations inspire. They also fire up corporate sharks who want to sink their teeth into all these centralized, user-created content silos. They also love all that distributed creativity, all these geeks who leave traces of their ideas on blogs and wikis. The biggest deal about these practices is the fact that massive amounts of knowledge is moved into the "unregulated commons" (Benkler). Here it is free and available to those who have an Internet connection, and the necessary media literacy. Here, these files live on a different turf. For the most part, they can be changed or creatively improved upon. Often this content cannot be commodified. But if these licenses really stick legally remains to be seen. The property issues of collaborative practices in the commons matter a great deal. They are a more complex affair than the traditional scheme of the individual author selling out to the System. We could, for instance, state that it is Google Incorporated that sucks off profit from the thousands of unpaid Wikipedians. Equally the cadres of free software scripters are arguably turned into cash cows for the young Google czars.

Venture capitalist David Hornik, while studying business plans of countless small so-called "Long Tail" firms, concludes that there

as mass media continues to project an image of hardy individuality.

...

Is what I do, what I am, taken all together, more of an affirmative force for what this system does, or is it more of an alternative force, a force that moves it towards change, that works against this system.

...

From Brian Holmes, quoting from the "Diffusion: Collaborative Practice in Contemporary Art" (Tate Modern), Oct 1: Since the early 1990s there has been a major rise in group-based and collective art practice. Artist groups and duos, and collaborative relationships between artists and audiences, have become a familiar part of the artistic landscape. New kinds of practice exploring the idea of art as an expanded form of intellectual activity have emerged.

...

How, within a predominantly individualistic society, to make free coopera-

is no money to be made with Internet content. Give up all hope, all ye who enter here! During the historical gold rush in the American West it was not the rough-headed diggers who made the money. There were few lumps of the precious yellow metal to be found. Cash came to those who served beer and provided food for the gold diggers. In today's Internet it is not the content creators who get the dineros. Financial prospects are in aggregators and filterers. Listen to David Hornik's analysis:

"The aggregators are those web businesses that seek to collect up as much of the Long Tail content as is possible, so as to make their 'stores' a one-stop shop for content no matter how popular or obscure. The value to consumers from these content aggregators is that they need not shop in dozens of places on the web in order to acquire a diverse set of content. As a result, aggregators are able to extract a disproportionate amount of value for the sale of each individual piece of content. And while creators are likely to sell slightly more content as a result of the increased ease of salability, they will not likely emerge from the obscurity of the Tail merely because they are made available for sale on Amazon or iTunes. The filterers are those businesses that make it easier to find the content in which we are interested, despite the increasing proliferation of content creators, hosts, aggregators, etc. The purest form of a filter is the search engine. But the more obscure the content, the less effective the generalized search engine will be. While different filtering technologies may make it slightly

tion more interesting than uncooperative freedom?

From John Hopkins, Sept 28: In the situation where there is open and shared/ “balanced” bi-lateral energy exchange between all nodes (individuals), this is located closer to the network end of the scale.... This also reflects on the phenomenon where there is a condition of dynamic open bi-directional flow between two people, that each may be literally inspired and walk away from the encounter with an excess of energy! If that is the core dynamic of a network — a consequent conglomeration of energy-surplus-producing ‘dialogues’ — then the network becomes the site for enormous potential energy reserves!

From Brian Holmes, Sept. 17: I recently read a great article about the US Army, or is it the Navy Seals (?), that wants to create a kind of wifi network among

more likely that an end user finds his or her way to a piece of obscure content, it will not likely be sufficient to catapult an artist into the mainstream. The beneficiary of the filtering is the end user and the filterer, not the content owner per se.”²

“Mass amateurization,” as promoted by Lawrence Lessig, Joi Ito and countless other cyberlibertarians, is a powerful, empowering ideology that appeals to a broad spectrum. It is a meme that was designed to give a positive spin to the depressive picture that Hornik provides us with. The thousands of volunteer contributors to Wikipedia simply out-collaborated commercial efforts. So what is the problem with “extreme democracy” (Ratcliffe/Lebkowsky) in a time when there is only loss of individual liberties, mass deception and spin? For this we need to transcend good intentions and look at the long-term economic implications of this ideology-of-the-free.³ Sustainable cooperation, of course, aims at “mass professionalization.” People love to make a living with the work that they love and give up their McJobs. There is nothing romantic about the working poor! The question then becomes how, together, can we turn around the cynical logic of the Horniks and Itos who continue to set the rules of Internet work.

This book is not about conference proceedings from the Free Cooperation event. It is also not a marathon essay by a single author (the German theorist Christoph Spehr). After the event in Buffalo we decided that it was crucial for further discussions to get Spehr’s Free

predator drones so that you will have full network capabilities in an air war even if your C3 center in Florida is blown to smithereens by a suicide bomber! This too is cooperation, encouraged by the reticular form of both contemporary society and computer media.

From Charles Green, Oct.

6: I definitely do not think that collaboration in art is particularly radical, not that it arose in the 1960s. But I do think that at this foundational time it occupies a specially instructive place.

...

Collaboration is not the same as friendship, and by friendship connotes cooperation. Friendship is always fragile since its contract is so unenforceable. Demands in and on friendship are always ultimately unsustainable, unless friendship is governed by an economy of civility. Collaboration involves much, much more.

Cooperation essay translated into English. The essay spurred many responses in the German-speaking realm. We added material that we deemed useful for this conversation. The art and technology perspectives on the debate particularly fascinated us. For Spehr's theory it is not essential to dig deep into the differences between "real life" and "virtual" collaborations. Each of them has its merits. It is strategically important not to get stuck in endless debates about the inherent superiority of "real" collaborations compared to those online (or vice versa).

What's so deeply Old-European about the approach here is the passion for negative thinking! We are not depressed! But we are convinced that we can learn from made mistakes! It's not the Germanic "Don't even try!" nor the American "Enthusiastically try everything however nonsensical it may be." We propose to study failed collaborations closely. Let's remember them. Let's reconstruct their social workings, instead of time and again pushing the harmony ideology and only focusing on the exciting beginnings. The feel-good factor of success appeals to all of us. But it also represses the real existing, unresolved conflicts. We know that they will inappropriately explode at any time if we don't address them properly. This is a call for more research into "cooperation studies." The more social online tools become available and are used, on a massive worldwide scale, the more material we can study, and the more urgent the outcomes will be. This work should be done on a

Collaboration involves the articulation of contractual relations.

...

I don't know that there are rules about collaborative longevity, but it seems to me that the collaborations that modeled themselves on family structures, with the collaborative identity rather like a castle wall behind which roles could be swapped and reversed, was an easier model to sustain than this unless civility was the basis of relationship, which it overtly is with Gilbert and George, who are even models of cooperation and generosity to intrusive art critics like myself.

...

The problem lies [...] in confusing collaboration with friendship. Collectives are not the same as collaborations. All of the artists that I researched worked together for long periods of time. It is highly unlikely that Christo and Jean-Claude, or Ann and Patrick Poirrier, or Helen

critical-conceptual level, with additional case studies. We can integrate all our collaborative insights into the study of situations of (online) conflict. This may all sound mundane. But consider this: How many artists collaborate in the making of a work (almost all)? How visible is this togetherness in the artwork (hardly at all)? How much do we know about the process of working together (next to nothing)?

Artists hire programmers and pay them. Does that make it a collaboration? Should the programmer's name appear in the credits? Who stashes away the most social capital by "collaboratively" getting their name onto as many projects as possible? How does this elusive reputation economy translate into solid cash? Let's pull this out from under the carpet! Let's discuss it.

Our attitude toward collaboration, conflicted by World War II references of the term itself (think: collaborating with the occupying Nazis), is a rather cautious one. This text may read to some like a peachy, even communistic praise of collaboration despite all the mentioned downsides. But we are genuinely on the fence about the topic. The problem is, however, that we don't really have a choice in the matter. Collaboration always already happens, forced or not, tense or joyful, stomachaches or hot rushes. Collaboration can refer to romantic discussions around the utopian campfire. Skeptics see failure and self-sacrifice at the core of each and every collaboration. They are blind to the ecology of collaboration. The substance of one "failed" collaborative effort of-

and Newton Harrison, or Gilbert and George, or a host of others, would choose to work outside their collaboration.

...

I don't want anyone to think that I'm valorizing or glamorizing artistic collaboration. It's inherently no more important than anything else. I'm not the least bit impressed by aura surrounding any mode of production.

...

Artist collaborations remain limited in number, not necessarily connected with post-artwork activity.

...

Not everyone is suited for cooperation, but the art world glamorizes narcissism and has an incredibly short attention span.

...

For myself, the bankruptcy of avant-gardist models lies in the use of art as instrumental — as the means to an end in which the end justifies the means — and bohemia, collaboration or collective identities have

ten becomes the foundation for a new project. We witness this in the open-source community, in which source code sometime gets recycled, and of course, forked. In the same context of open-source development the tit-for-tat strategy for sharing was developed. This method of exchange of code is based on reciprocity. Bits of code are traded in for code from your counterpart.

Romantics praise collaboration. They think it must be like a love affair. Ferocious pragmatics on the other hand just chant their to-do lists. They think that they can force a genuine smile onto the “team players’” faces. Such mechanical application of rules does not work! A collaboration can indeed be similar to a flirt or a new friendship. It can be an overwhelming encounter. But there is no recipe for such match-making! It is an event. You cannot schedule such circumstance for 11am followed by a business lunch. The event of true collaboration takes you to a place where you have not been before. It makes you forget about time. At other times collaboration kicks fully into gear when trust is built. This needs time. Professional and personal interests need to be appeased. Those involved need to be willing, and able to put in the hours. This can be a tough call if you are one of the many working poor. It's exhausting if you work three jobs just to keep your head above water. It's also grim if you work on ten million projects at the same time. Collaboration asks for concentration. Online collaboration can have a bitter aftertaste for some who think that is a pure

all to deal with this criticism, which is based on the necessity of ethical action, a notion familiar to Buddhists, for example. This is why I presented a paper on the difference between two models of artistic collaboration. The first is the popularly held view of collaboration as reconciliation, implying both profit and loss. This book-keeping sense of the word sees artistic collaboration as a balance. A deficit in one part of the relationship is compensated by a surplus somewhere else — a partnership or a cooperative to which individuals bring something that can also be taken away.

From Geert Lovink, Dec. 10: Obviously not all collaboration is based on friendship, but the two have an interesting “elective affinity” (*Wahlverwandschaft*)... Are there ways to prevent individuals from highjacking and appropriating collective works? Or is disintegration

waste of time. Endless email exchanges, noisy chats, fatiguing time differences, defunct or incompatible software, and unstable bandwidth are part of this uninviting picture. And it does not stop there. The exploitative, “precarious” character of immaterial, networked labor adds to this horrendous scenario.

There is, no doubt, such thing as the high art of collaboration. We think that it can be taught! It is possible to exchange experiences and reflections and theorize them. However, often these propositions are prescriptive. They end up in a procedure that you are supposed to follow. Collaboration is the science of lists! The do’s and don’ts can be read as normative statements. But we can also interpret them as loose guidelines. A bit like walking through rugged terrain with a compass but without GPS. You approximate the direction. Collaboration is frequently a thorny subject. It’s not the highway to heaven. It is muddled by human desires for recognition. It screams for attention at a time when you’re just too busy with other affairs. It’s like considering having a child — it never seems the right time. The issue of shadow labor matters a great deal in collaboration. All too often all credit is given to the most visible individual in a collaboration. It brings projects to the breaking point. Group dynamics are also part and parcel in this context. Perhaps this is the reason that we increasingly look to sociologists to lead the way. Yet another hot-button topic in collaboration is leadership. We think that there always are hierarchies and rules in collabora-

and betrayal amongst each other inevitable? What is the art of disappearing in those cases? Is there an elegant way out, or do collaborations have to end up in blues?

From Matthias Weiss, Sept. 05: Our main way to work together (“mutuality” is favored instead of “collaboration”) is our web space, www.serverfestival.net.

Christoph Spehr, Oct. 27: How do we construct non-hierarchical forms of cooperation, especially when it comes to global cooperation and to the use of the net?

...

I had the vision of a platform that is not based on individuals but on collectives, which administrate their own space (rooms) there (in a simplified cms way, including also blogging and wikis) and form groups of collectives (streets or neighborhoods or whatever) that are able to take common decisions

tions. They need to be acknowledged and the captains of directorship should be compelled to rotate.

The term *spontaneous* often comes up when talking about online togetherness, even in this text, as we noticed earlier that collaboration can’t be planned. But web-enhanced collaboration is hardly ever spontaneous. It is slow. However, it can be accelerated by meetings in person. Embodied, it is often only a handful of people who get together. Online, mortals come together in the thousands. Internet collaborations become most intensive if collaborators live in proximity and use the web-based communication to add to their regular in-person meetings. Research by University of Toronto communication scholar Barry Wellman showed that more emails are exchanged between people who live in physical proximity. Clay Shirky noticed that today’s media artists create software tools that are geographically specific. He calls such tools situated software. The anywhere and nowhere of the Internet is challenged by site-specific software art that addresses a particular community or location.

On the Internet, no one knows you’re a multitude. Common efforts have to be made visible. So what’s the state of the art concerning “media activism”? One thing is clear: social movements do not emerge out of the Web. Their beginnings lie somewhere else, not in the act of online communication. Technology aids our dispatches. We build social devices and they, in turn, construct us. Our lan-

that usually are made by webmasters or maintainers, using an access management system that is based on these categories (room, street, whole platform). To put it simply: your group can design their space, load up some stuff and make up some blog or whatever, and your group decides itself what is only for them, what is for their neighborhood, which other collectives can join exactly this neighborhood and what happens in your street and what does not. ... network architectures as we know them, the whole logic of computer programming as we know it, is completely hierarchical. (Or at least as I know them, ok.) They are based on Babuschka rules: the higher levels set up the higher rules.

From Brian Holmes, Oct. 26: If we want to regain any chance to turn collective reflection into positive action, then we must make the production of the col-

l- guage changes through the technology that facilitates its transmission. The way we learn changes. What we learn changes by the way it is distributed. Citizen journalism grew in numbers since the emergence of Indymedia during the Seattle WTO demonstrations in 1999. But visualized collectivity such as the February 15, 2003 anti-Iraq-War demonstrations run more on the grammar of the streets than the protocols of the World Wide Web.

There is currently a vertigo of collaboration and social networking. They are hyped to an extent that troubles us. 2004 was declared the year of blogs. The online millions are trying to find out for themselves what they want to ask the web. Are blogs no more than diaristic outlets for the pain of teenagers? Or is it a new public platform for the intellectual that would have Jürgen Habermas and also Alexander Kluge rethink the public sphere? New platforms have different sets of publics watching and contributing. In 2005 collaborative filtering, social bookmarking and the people's taxonomy (folksonomy) came along. But in turn all this socializing software made some people rather autistic. They are just inundated by all that information. All that blogging, reading of RSS feeds and email leaves them no TIME to think (for themselves). We filter and therefore we are!

For business analyst Chris Shipley online collaboration stands for social networking through advanced email systems with shared address books or common access to a database. In her 2006 essay "The Year of Work-

lective imaginary into an open question again. Only in this way can we stop the pollution of our minds, by gaining some kind of control over the means of production.

...

What we really need to do is to spend a lot more time asking each other whether our cultural fictions — our architecture and our ideas, our hierarchies and ambitions and loves — are really any good for us.

And to do that, we need to propose new fictions, to shake up the instituted imaginary with what Castoriadis calls the “instituting imaginary.” We need to engage in desymbolization and resymbolization. [...]

This is the way that artistic practices can affect reality.

...

Artists seem to collaborate for two opposed reasons: either to build momentum for an entry into the museum economy, or to create structures of production and distribution outside of it. The second case, which

ing Together!” she reminds us of relatively recent collaborative settings such as friends of friends networks like Friendsters. Shipley argues that these ways of working together do not really qualify as collaboration. Does the collective throwing in and taking out of data from a box constitute collaboration? Collaboration is a risky, interconnected thing. It is an intensive affair in which individuals who are part of a group share a common goal. They split benefits or losses. Cooperation is a much less-involved affair in which sole, independent participants advance separately. And finally, consultation is the loosest model of working together.

Soon already we will see more genuine collaborations. Today, we create massive amounts of content online. We don’t just customize and use and purchase commodities online. We pitch in our resources and thoughts and feelings. The culture of free sharing blossoms. But still mentalities toward sharing vary widely. Some realize that they benefit from giving everything away. Yet others feel threatened by such openness. They prefer to hold things close to their chest as they fear to lose out in the rumble of exchanges. Creativity is geographically distributed. We are producers. We are authors. We are columnists and instigators. We support others and are aided in turn. People are getting used to social software tools. They make unexpected uses of them. “Bumplist” by the researcher and artist Jonah Brucker Cohen is a good example. Here, only a limited number of participants can be subscribed to a mailing list

is what interests me, would appear to make the entire post-modernist critique of the work's autonomy obsolete, as the whole issue has become the autonomy of the artists. But what the exit from the white cube confronts us with is a generalized (and usually commercialized) communication society, where the Internet supplies the paradigm of all distribution possibilities and the museum is, not anathema, but simply another option. The difficulty is now that of constituting the group's autonomy through both the working process and its products, and then of traversing the communicational screens to achieve the kinds of relations that one seeks with other groups or institutions. Such questions are inherently political: they concern the formations, projects and relays whereby people attempt to shape a wider society, and also the feedback effects that this attempt at social

at any one moment. Once new contributors join, the previous members exceeding the limit for the list are bumped off.

Participatory, creative online tools rule in media art. This holds true at least when it comes to collaboration and cooperation. Artists set up cultural contexts to which others contribute. There is a long history of participation in art, traced in essays by Dieter Daniels and Inke Arns. They point to a trajectory from the early 1960s until today. They include Duchamp, Kaprow, Cage, and Lyotard (Les Immatériaux). We see many such participatory design projects emerge online. The static, closed online art project fell out of favor.

Collaboration in the art world happens often at an early stage in the artists' life, after graduation from college. Here, coalitions are built that make the entry into the art world easier.

The second model of collaboration is that of those who dropped out of the art world and seek alternative platforms for exposure and dialogue. Low-level collaborations in the form of consultation are the day-to-day bread and water of technologists. Artists working with technologies need to work with programmers as no one person can know all that is needed to finish a project. While the number of non-believers in the model of the lone star is on the decline, the idea of the individual artist genius is vividly alive. Collaboration is not for everyone! And it can be abused! Collaborative tricksters frequently inflate their own social capital by not crediting their cohorts.

engagement will have. And all of that bears direct relations to many political experiments now underway, particularly where the drop-outs of the white cube meet the counter-globalization movement.

From Patrick, Dec. 10:

Invariably there are issues relating to hierarchical issues, seniority, ego, work vs. recognition, intellectual property of the constituents, architectonics of social contracts, legitimacy, recognition of the individuals and so on, and I think most of the “problems” have to do with issues of personal gain, legitimation, and status.

Collaborations between artists and scientists are also not a new occurrence. In these working scenarios artists are more often than not in the role of the illustrator. They visualize the results of scientists and thus help to communicate their findings to the public. But different professional languages and maybe even political leanings may run counter to each other. Do artists and scientists need to have the same goal when working together? It takes a long time to establish a true connection between artists and scientists that leads to consequential results.

Also in education collaboration is on the rise. This may sound far-fetched. Students are equal negotiators in the classroom hierarchy. But their bargaining power and ability to walk out of a forced cooperation is limited. Rooms in most art schools barely accommodate group work. Still only the most enlightened universities allow for collaborative MFAs. And the culture of sharing is not well-aligned with the corporatization of the academy. Faculty are still denied tenure because they put their aces on the collaboration card. But sharing grows in the face of resource scarcity. Rice University’s Connexions Project is one example. This project allows groups of faculty and students to jointly create syllabi out of knowledge modules. MIT Open Courseware shares syllabi of courses taught at the university. Researchers worldwide use the bibliography-sharing tool Citeulike. In addition, there is the idea of extreme programming. Here, pairs of two learn programming together. All of these projects

are based on the idea of collaboration and resource-sharing. But sharing comes with the burden of gift-giving. Hierarchies of exchange are established the moment a gift is changed hands: hegemonic “manyness” (Fuller). You have to reciprocate or you are “out-gifted.” The bigger the gift, the stronger the giver. MIT financially benefits from its syllabus sharing. It re-inscribes them as market leaders and thus attracts students and faculty.

The biggest magnitude of participation happens in collaborative online environments that focus on health-related issues. People join health-related virtual communities and electronic support groups to discuss their illness and leave once it is resolved. People can talk to others who are going through the same thing. (Your doctor is likely to never have lived through the disease herself). In these forums people realize that they are not alone with their problem.

Online or in civic life, the default is non-participation and disengagement. Robert Putnam shows this fairly well in his work. Putnam’s examples such as church-going are somewhat old-fashioned. However, his basic argument is to the point and not in contradiction to what we’re focussing on here. Regardless of the growth of blogs and wikis, civic participation offline (and therefore collaboration) is on the decline. In spite of that, ever-greater numbers of people join web-enabled collaborative work situations.

The context of the Internet allows for the highest degrees of social filtering that connect the like-minded. In the safe, anonymous setting of the Internet people do not ever have to argue with opposing opinions. No more face-to-face confrontations. Online you can be selective and racial issues disappear off your radar. Economic inequality vanishes out of your sight. Conflicting political views recede from your view. This leads to isolated consensus islands of special interest. Putnam, for example, reports, that in a chat room about a particular model of BMW, his comments about BMWs in general were held to be “off-topic.”

What makes collaboration online so attractive? Essentially, collaborators can find geographically dispersed team members who have the fitting set of skills that their project demands. On the other hand, critics are quick to sharply condemn the network serfdom of immaterial

labor that turns dispersed workers into laptop-lap-dogs who are ready to work at any hour anywhere. The network society allows capital to sneak into every minute of our everyday. There is no place that could not become a collaborative workplace. Downtime becomes download time. Health insurance and pensions do not need to be paid for what Howard Rheingold calls part-of-the-solution workers. Work and leisure fade into one another. Computers pervade every corner of our existence. The wolf of networked exploitation needs to be recognized when it comes along in the sheepskin of shiny locative gadgets.

Prepare for collaboration. That's all we can do. We cannot predict if it will happen. At best, energizing inspiration grows amidst a group. We do not get up, have coffee, and then collaborate. We have to acquire a set of tools, learn the art of collaboration that we can then apply whenever needed. Rheingold defines the ability to take part in technology-enhanced social networks a key skill for the next decade. We try it over and over again, convinced that the sum of all parts is bigger than one of its pieces. Collaboration flourishes when team members are experienced in such situations. It needs trust. It needs time. Scale also matters. How does a small team branch out successfully?

We hereby declare Darwin dead. History, human interaction, and communication does not only get done through the survival of the fittest! We don't buy that for a second. The topic of collaboration is also related to Adam Smith and the strange historical trajectory that suspects that things get done through competition. We'd rather follow Peter Kropotkin's conception of mutual aid. Kropotkin claimed that Darwin's notions were limited and that evolution relied on mutual backing. We suggest a radical criticism of competitiveness! And despite all the suspect corporate interest in the topic, we ask if we don't progress more richly through free cooperation.

Generation after generation, there are experiences made inside collectives, groups, firms and movements. How do you write an account of collective actions? How do you capture the complexity of collective production? This is rarely captured and theorized, let alone ready to be transferred into other social contexts. The Actor-Network theory only gets us that far. Paolo Virno's *Grammar of the Multitude* goes

a step into the direction of finding a name for new, temporary alliances. Let's put our ear to the ground of collaboration. A surprising majority of collaboration theory is written in support of the amazon.coms of this world. Theorists think through group coordination, and consensus building — all aimed at “getting things done.” The key term is “effective.” We ask if these business conglomerates really need our help. Is social software the contemporary equivalent to Ford's assembly line? Will we need self-help manuals and psycho-pharmaca directed to heal us from the world created by these tools? Show us the revolutionary experience that has a full guarantee of being utterly useless for capitalist appropriation! Not even slackerdom can claim that. The search continues! The struggle continues!

How do new tools like SMS, IM, Voice Over IP, Skype, Opinity, Facebook, or MySpace affect the way we act? Corporate sirens lure the online millions into the net of their interactive enterprises. What can we learn from this? How can we escape the cynical truth that all that's left to do is either appropriate yesterday's knowledge of the consultant class, or be appropriated ourselves? What will the Revolution for Dummies say? Will Che Guevara wear a Homer Simpson t-shirt? What is at stake in your collaboration? We are the other. We are the consultant class. The black and white divide does not get us any further. We have the managerial other in us. It is like the alien that burns in our chest. Our oppositional attitude becomes stronger from this realization.

We hope that this book will not just provide you with a grammar of collaboration. We set out to establish a dictionary of the language of cooperation, a dynamic map of the territory. Free Cooperation was not our last word. To carry on reading this text, embark on a collaboration.

ENDNOTES

1 | <http://www.freecooperation.org>

2 | http://longtail.typepad.com/the_long_tail/

3 | <http://www.waag.org/free/>

EXCERPTS FROM FREE COOPERATION AND AFTER

Brian Holmes, May 2004/October 2005

Both of us basically think that after a quarter-century, the staying power of the long-lived, nasty, dinosaur-toothed political compromise known as neoliberalism is just about over. Wave it goodbye with massive protest and no regrets. Its death throes are burning down cities, an ugly situation which may yet get worse. But the abysmally unequal exchange of finance-driven globalization has unleashed deep conflicts – both those unfolding violently since September 11, and the civic unrest of the worldwide counterglobalization movement that started long before then. In the face of those conflicts, the hegemony originally put together by Reagan and Thatcher is likely to become unglued. It just ain't workin'.

...

And now part of our job as activists, everywhere, for years still to come, is to push these bastards out along with their ideas and their values and their geostrategies and their legal procedures and their organizational models and their modular management and their cynical Gucci ties and their bloodsucking IP ideologies, not to mention their start-up opportuni-

ism and shameless cooptation of practically any art that glitters. Vampires go home! (That could've been the classic toast of Free Cooperation.)

...

The dissolution of free-market teleologies (free trade leads to paradise) opens the door again to neo-Keynesian central prodding, which seeks salvation in the return to full employment, with the familiar vocabulary of stimulating consumption to provoke virtuous circles of industrial growth. This approach can only maintain its illusions within a restrictive national frame, and more fundamentally, within a game of inclusion/exclusion whose all-too-familiar figure is the contrast between privileged union labor and unguaranteed temp services (McJobs, as they say in the late great USA) or mass unemployment and social exclusion. You could think of these Keynesian proposals as the Ghost of Forced Cooperation Past.

...

Everywhere the information economy flickers, the agenda in my view is perfectly clear. Not only education and health care, but the means of production – that is, the machines and the spaces and the networks – for the highly individualized, informational and affective workers have to receive much more social funding. Free time is something to win. The Welfare State can be reinvented by the flexworkers: it's an emergency, Mayday, Mayday! There is one strong possibility to begin reviving democracy: more independent media, and more spaces of debate, in relation to social movements whose transgressive action in society is protected by solidarity and diffuse support. This is what must be put on the political agenda, along with living wages and guaranteed incomes.

...

Not a single one of the ideas connected to Free Cooperation, or to the virtual futures of the multitudes, is receivable in the mainstream US today. At this point, the US is the monster. We have to accept that. Our country is the cancer again, it's pathological, just like when I was growing up during the Vietnam War. We have to find the strength of alienation to undermine this thing till it keels over. Only mass exodus is going to derail the made-in-USA machine of Forced Cooperation.

TECHNOLOGIES OF COOPERATION

Howard Rheingold

INTRODUCTION

When social communication media grow in capability, pace, scope, or scale, people use these media to construct more complex social arrangements—that is, they use communication tools and techniques to increase their capacity to *cooperate* at larger and larger scales. Human history is a story of the co-evolution of tools and social practices to support ever more complex forms of cooperative society.

First Experiments: The Hunter–Gatherers
Humans lived as hunter-gatherers in small, extended family units long before they lived in agricultural settlements. For most of that time, small game and gathered foods constituted the most significant form of wealth—enough food to stay alive. At some point, larger groups figured out how to band together to hunt bigger game. We don't know exactly how they figured this out, but it's a good guess that some form of communication was involved, and however they did it, their banding-together process must have solved collective-action problems in some

way: our mastodon-hunting ancestors must have found ways to suspend mistrust and strict self-interest long enough to cooperate for the benefit of all. It is unlikely that unrelated groups would be able to accomplish huge-game hunting while also fighting with each other.

We do know that humans were successful at hunting down, burning down, or driving herds of large game over cliffs. One immediate effect of this new, more socially complex and more dangerous way of hunting must have been the social dilemma presented by sudden wealth. Suddenly, more protein was available than the hunters' families could eat before it rotted. Did those who ate the rewards of the hunt but did not themselves hunt owe something to the hunters? Did they pay them something in exchange? In any case, social relations must have become more complex. And new modes of cooperation must have emerged. Undoubtedly, new ways of using symbols were enlisted to keep track of these increasingly complex social arrangements.

Extended Reach: The Emergence of Empire

About 10,000 years ago, larger numbers of humans began to settle in rich river valleys and cultivate crops instead of continuing their perpetual nomadic hunting and gathering activities. In these settled flood plains, large-scale irrigation projects must have required—and enabled—an increase in the scale and complexity of social organization. The “big man” form of social organization changed in some places into kingdoms, and in a very few places, the first mega-kingdoms, or empires, began to construct cities out of mud and stone.

The first forms of writing appeared as a means of accounting for the exchange of commodities such as wine, wheat, or sheep—and the taxation of this wealth by the empire. The master practitioners of the new medium of marks on clay or stone were the accountants for the emperors and their priest-administrators. When writing became alphabetic (claims McLuhan), an altogether new kind of empire, the Roman Empire, became possible.

Each time the form of communication media became more powerful, social complexity was amplified and new forms of collective action emerged, from pyramid building to organized warfare. Lewis Mumford

called this “the birth of the megamachine”—the alliance of armed authority with religious hierarchies, who organized people as units in social machines.

Extended Thought: The Power of Literacy

Alphabetic writing was the exclusive tool of the administrators of empires for thousands of years. An elite group of priests and civil administrators were taught the secret of encoding and decoding knowledge and transmitting it across time and space. Then the printing press enabled populations of millions to amplify their thinking by becoming literate.

Again, new forms of collective action emerged from newly literate populations. The Protestant reformation, constitutional revolutions, and the scientific method as a means of collective knowledge creation all stemmed from the ability of complex societies to share their knowledge and their thought processes. A worldwide economy also began to emerge: markets are as old as the crossroads, but capitalism is only about 500 years old, enabled by stock companies that share risk and profit, government-backed currency, shared liability insurance companies, and double-entry bookkeeping, all of which rely on printing.

Extended Tools: Societies of Technologies

What we are witnessing today is thus the acceleration of a trend that has been building for thousands of years. When technologies like alphabets and Internets amplify the right cognitive or social capabilities, old trends take new twists and people build things that never could be built before.

Over time, the number of people engaged in producing new things has grown from an elite group to a significant portion of the population; at the same time, the tools available to these growing populations have grown more powerful. With Moore’s Law dictating technological capacity and the need for constant economic growth driving new technological applications, larger and larger populations are adopting ever more powerful devices.

As these devices become technically networked—as they themselves are organized into increasingly complex societies of cooperating devic-

es—the value of the technical network multiplies by N^2 (Metcalfe's Law). Reed's Law says that the value of the network multiplies far more rapidly, at the exponential rate of 2^N , when human social networks use the technical networks to form social groups. As a consequence, social capital, knowledge capital, and the politically potent ability to organize collective action are growing faster and faster, while social disruption, new forms of power and power shifts, and new kinds of growth and wealth begin to erupt.

Strategy at the Leading Edge: New Cooperative Technologies

Strategy is itself a function of the technologically expanded human capacity to think and act together. It makes sense, then, that the leading edge of strategy found at the leading edge of cooperative tools and techniques—that deliberate use of these technologies can enhance our deliberate plans for working and living together more effectively.

But today's technologies of cooperation (and perhaps all tools throughout history) exist on the border between deliberate design and unpredictable emergence. Sometimes, the complex human-machine constructions are intentional. Often they are the emergent result of aggregating a large number of individual interactions. And occasionally they are both.

For example, the Internet protocols and WWW protocols were technical specifications that were deliberately designed to decentralize innovation, but eBay and virtual communities were emergent social phenomena that grew out of the technological network enabled by those protocols. The architectural freedom was built into the Internet because the protocol designers suspected people would think of uses that they couldn't imagine for an interconnected web of computers. A physicist in Switzerland created the Web by giving it away to a few friends; a few years later, that enabled students who started Yahoo! and Google on their college computers; these platforms, in turn, enabled the creation of complex online marketplaces for goods and services.

Cooperative strategy thus has two faces:

- One seeks to apply the new tools to situations in which we believe increased cooperation will produce better outcomes—for example, to resolve a social dilemma or simply to increase the effectiveness of teams.
- The other seeks to understand the tools as templates for new kinds of social organization and to anticipate the strategic environment these new societal forms will create—and the choices they will impose.

This report, *Technologies of Cooperation* (SR-897), will try to take both perspectives as it explores eight clusters of cooperative technologies that are emerging at this still very early stage of the digital revolution.

A STRATEGIC MAP OF COOPERATIVE TECHNOLOGIES

In *Toward a New Literacy of Cooperation in Business* (IFTF SR-851 A, 2004), we identified seven dimensions of cooperative strategy, along which we can slide a metaphorical lever to increase or decrease cooperative behavior in all kinds of systems, from teams to entire societies. These are:

- Structure: from static to dynamic
- Rules: from external to internal
- Resources: from private to public
- Thresholds: from high to low
- Feedback: from local to systemic
- Memory: from ephemeral to persistent
- Identity: from individual to group

In this report, we want to look at how these tuning levers work in eight clusters of cooperative technology:

- Self-organizing mesh networks that create societies of cognitively cooperating devices
- Community computing grids that support emergent swarms of

supercomputing power

- Peer production networks that build a constantly expanding commons for innovation
- Social mobile networks that foster the collective action of “smart mobs”
- Group-forming networks that integrate social and technical networks
- Social software that enables the management of personal social webs
- Social accounting tools that serve as trustbuilding mechanisms
- Knowledge collectives that extend the nature and reach of knowledge economies

By applying each of the levers to each of the eight technology clusters, we can begin to build a map of the options for cooperative strategy that are emerging as part of the digital revolution (see fold-out chart included with this book). This map includes several features:

- A list of early technologies that are part of each cluster (some of which belong to more than one cluster)
- A characteristic shift that each technology cluster produces for a particular strategic lever (for example, in self-organizing mesh networks, identity tends to shift from “user versus provider” to “user as provider”); these shifts can be used both to understand the tendency of the technology and the strategic intervention the technology can aid
- A range of key concepts and phenomena that define the intersection of strategic levers and technology clusters

Please note that this map represents an early interpretation of the literature of cooperation and the evolution of technology. Think of it as version 1.0 of the strategy map for technologies of cooperation.

THE TECHNOLOGIES OF COOPERATION: FROM EXAMPLES TO PRINCIPLES

Today's technologies of cooperation are practical tools for organizing people and solving problems that we face right now. But they are also harbingers of new forms of social and economic organization — forms that may help resolve some of the complex social dilemmas that confront the world. So each example of a cooperative technology is also a model for thinking about future social forms as well as future tools; each example embodies principles that can help us think more strategically about cooperation.

In this chapter, we examine eight categories or clusters of cooperative technologies—calling out key examples, identifying the distinctive ways in which they are shaping innovative cooperative strategies, and then extracting key principles that seem to derive from these examples.

Like any taxonomy, our eight categories are necessarily a bit arbitrary, and the boundaries between categories are sometimes blurred. And as tools evolve, the categories may shift in the future. In fact, as the “cooperation commons” grows and we apply some of these very tools to our analysis, we expect a much more robust “folksonomy” of cooperative technologies to emerge. For now, however, this analysis provides a way to think systematically about the tools and their strategic implications.

1. SELF-ORGANIZING MESH NETWORKS: SOCIETIES OF COGNITIVELY COOPERATING DEVICES

What they are
Self-organizing mesh networks are constellations of devices that can serve as both transceivers and relays or routers, with built-in intelligence to recognize compatible devices and configure themselves as a node in the network. They thus eliminate the need for any centrally controlled backbone network. Their self-organizing properties may be encoded in either hardware or software.

Examples
Software radio combines the ability of the computer to perform very fast operations with the capabilities of digital signal processing that makes it easier to extract signals from noise—using built-in software that is smart enough to configure the signal to overcome any obstacles and taking advantage of locally available spectrum by adjusting power, frequency, and modulation. They were developed initially for use in

Self-organizing mesh networks define architectural principles for building both tools and processes that grow from the edges without obvious limits. They distribute the burden of maintaining the infrastructure among all participants in the network, and the capacity of the network as a resource grows—rather than shrinks—with each additional participant. In essence, they form societies of intelligently cooperating devices, as David Reed has pointed out. If better ways of using resources remain to be discovered, the architectural principles of mesh networks might furnish an important hint.

From Dumb Radios to Smart Receivers
Wireless receiving devices of the 1920s were unable to distinguish between nearby signals from central broadcasters in similar frequency ranges. As a result, the practice of dividing valuable wireless frequency bands into pieces of property that were controlled by their licensee “owners” was established.

However, in the 21st century, more intelligent receivers can treat spectrum in a less consumptive way. Using more sophisticated forms of signal analysis and signal processing, they can effectively create additional spectrum, eliminating the need to divvy up the spectrum among competing users. This is the basis for the Open Spectrum movement.

emergency and battle-field situations.

Mesh radios act as their own communication routers, sending around packets of data for other radios in the network. The technology has been used to provide broadband wireless access to private LANs, the Internet, and video programming.

Mesh sensor networks are communicating sensors that likewise serve as routers for other sensors in the network, relaying the sensor readings throughout the network and eventually to some other type of network where the data can be put to use. (Dust's SmartMesh motes)

P2P file exchanges apply this principle to a more socially defined practice—participants allow portions of their computers to be used as temporary repositories for files that anyone in the network can access. They may also be required as part of the social protocol to contribute some of their own files to the commons.

From Communications to Energy

Jock Gill, in a blog post, proposes that the notion of intelligent self-organizing could be applied to energy as well as communication:¹

... let's take Internet architecture further and apply it to our electrical power system. This yields an "InterGrid" — every building powering itself as its demands require rather than every "demand" depending on a centralized power station with a many-decades replacement cycle. Just as centralized communications stifles innovation so does centralized power generation.

We need a local grid for mutual security. That is, I and my neighbors need redundancy and back up in case our individual power system conks out. We will therefore connect our "homes" to one another in a mutual assistance grid. Logically it would make sense to then interconnect these edge grids for further security. Thus you organically build from the edges: the new InterGrid starts at the edges and builds in every direction, unlike the old central grid which starts at the center and builds towards the edge.

Social Correlates

The architectural principles of mesh networks can also be applied to all kinds of organizations and processes, including commerce and governance. As Gill states in his blog, "It is time to apply everything we have learned in the last 100 years, including the lessons pro-

vided by the Internet and its new architectural approaches, to the core of the operating system for our democratic and civil society.”

Strategic Principles

- Structure* Intelligent nodes decide which connections to develop, allowing the network to grow from the edges.
- Rules* Mutual assistance improves individual security, if you consume, you also provide.
- Resources* Users share the burden of the infrastructure and resources grow as the number of users grows.
- Thresholds* Redundancy increases the thresholds for disruption and lowers the cost to repair.
- Feedback* Local feedback makes it possible to grow stable largescale systems from the bottom up.
- Memory* Local nodes hold the relevant local knowledge.
- Identity* Users are also providers, creating group-aligned self-interest.

2. COMMUNITY COMPUTING GRIDS: SWARMS OF SUPER COMPUTING POWER

What They Are

Community computing grids are networks of computation created by volunteers who share excess CPU cycles from their own personal devices in order to aggregate massive processing power to solve computation-intensive problems. Each personal computer processes a tiny fragment of a huge problem, creating collective supercomputer capabilities that measure in teraflops.

Examples

Rational drug design uses the collective power of community computing grids to tackle large computational problems associated with designing and developing synthetic drugs. Projects such as Folderol (<http://www.folderol.com>) and Folding@home (<http://www.folding@home.org>) use human genome data and volunteers to conduct medically-crucial protein folding computations.

Community computing grids is a strategy for amassing computing power from resources that would otherwise be wasted, and creating levels of computation and analysis not easily or quickly available. Such computing structures depend on their social networks of participation in creating a common resource and sacrificing immediate individual costs or resources for the provision of a public good.

From Sharing Memory to Sharing Processing Community computation, also known as “distributed processing” or “peer-to-peer” computing, had already been underway for years before Napster awoke the wrath of the recording industry with this new way of using networked computers. But where Napster was a way for people to trade music by sharing their computer memory—their disk space—distributed processing communities share central processing unit (CPU) computation cycles, the fundamental unit of computing power. Sharing disk space does no more than enable people to pool and exchange data, whether it is in the form of music or signals from radiotelescopes. CPU cycles, unlike disk space, have the power to compute, to do things to data—which translates into the power to analyze, simulate, calculate, search, sift, recognize, render, predict, communicate, and control.

Today, millions of people and their PCs are not just trading music, but are tackling cancer

Peer-to-peer analysis collects harness shared processing for solving complex analytical problems. Evolution@home (<http://www.evolutionary-research.org>) searches for genetic causes for extinction of species. Distributed.net (<http://www.distributed.net>) solves cryptographic challenges. SaferMarkets (<http://www.safermarkets.org>) seeks to understand the causes of stock market volatility.

Ensemble forecasting uses “fuzzy prediction” based on multiple models rather than a single “best guess” forecast. For example, climate change forecasts use hundreds of thousands of state-of-the-art climate models, each with slightly different physics to represent uncertainties. Distributed processing is a practical strategy for this kind of forecasting.

research, finding prime numbers, rendering films, forecasting weather, designing synthetic drugs by running simulations on billions of possible molecules—taking on computing problems so massive that scientists have not heretofore considered them.

Aggregating Power into Computing Swarms
Distributed processing takes advantage of a huge and long-overlooked source of power. It isn’t necessary to build more computers to multiply computation power if you know how to harvest a resource that until now had been squandered—the differential between human and electronic processing speeds.

Even if you type two characters per second on your keyboard, you’re using only a fraction of your machine’s power. During that second, most desktop computers can simultaneously perform hundreds of millions of additional operations. Time-sharing computers of the 1960s exploited this ability. Now millions of PCs around the world, each of them thousands of times more powerful than the time-sharing mainframes of the sixties, connect via the Internet. As the individual computers participating in online swarms become more numerous and powerful and the speed of information transfer among them increases, a massive expansion of raw computing power looms, enabling qualitative changes in the way people use computers.

Third parties are beginning to serve as catalysts in aggregating community computing grids and supplying processing power for

profit (such as United Devices) or philanthropically (such as Intel who sponsors a philanthropic peer-to-peer program).

When Social Swarms Meet Computing Swarms

Community computing ultimately amplifies the power of both people and machines. Peer-to-peer swarming, pervasive computing, social networks, and mobile communications multiply each other's effects. Not only can millions of people link their social networks through mobile communication devices, but the computing chips inside those mobile devices will soon be capable of communicating with radio-linked chips embedded in the environment. Expect startling social effects after mobile P2P achieves critical mass—when the 1,500 people who walk across Tokyo's Shibuya Crossing at every light change can become a temporary cloud of distributed computing power.

Strategic Principles

- Structure* Peer-to-peer structures among participants enable social network effects among large numbers of small contributions and aggregate computing power.
- Rules* Social arrangements among voluntary contributors (when your CPU is idle; work on shared problem) enable sharing of excess, distributed processing.
- Resources* Community computing generates new computational resources from those that would have been squandered, creating increasing returns from what appeared to be finite resources.
- Thresholds* Community computing lowers the threshold of computational complexity by amassing analytical power
- Feedback* Swarm computing can efficiently provide quick feedback to complex situations and conditions.

- Memory* Community memory may contribute to group identity and further participation in community computing grids.
- Identity* Group identity is likely to encourage participation in community computing.

3. PEER PRODUCTION NETWORKS: BEYOND THE FIRM AND THE MARKET

What They Are
Peer-to-peer production networks are ad hoc, emergent networks of actors who participate cooperatively in the creation of a common good or resource without hierarchical control. They are structured around the interconnectedness of nodes rather than on a server-client model. Motivation to participate in peer networks includes diverse drivers and social signals rather than market price and command structures.

Examples
Open source software networks use commons-based, peerto-peer production methods to create many kinds of software, including operating systems like Unix and Linux, and Web server software such as Apache (which

Peer production networks aggregate many small, distributed resources to create a larger resource pool, solve problems, and produce goods that no single individual could have done otherwise. They provide an alternative structure for production and value creation beyond the firm and the market. Peer network principles form the structural basis of many new experiments in bottom-up social and economic models of exchange.

Emergence of a Third Alternative
Linux and other open source software are produced by ad hoc networks of individual programmers, linked by the Internet, a form of organizing for production that Yochai Benkler proposes as a third alternative to the classic institutions of the firm and the market.² Benkler points to open source software production as “a broader social-economic phenomenon” and “an emergence of a third mode of production in the digitally networked environment.” In peer production networks like open source, the property and contract models seen in the firm and market are radically changed. Maintaining a vibrant resource commons and

enjoys over 60% market share). Open source software is owned by nobody but produced by various coder volunteers who contribute to larger software objectives by solving small coding tasks.

Open source research and design networks share their knowledge, IP, and creative innovation to solve large, complex problems. P2P networks such as ThinkCycle (from the MIT Media Lab) leverage the collective design expertise, or “think cycles” of many to solve global design problems for developing countries. A recent project designed a compact medical kit to instruct medical teams (including many illiterate trainees) in the use of IV drip-set equipment.

Peer-to-peer media networks allow widespread sharing and creation of music, literature, and other digital art forms to perpetuate creative and cultural innovation rather than enclose it. A notable network is BitTorrent, in which downloaders swap portions of a file with one another instead of all

protecting the right to distribute over the right of ownership are key elements of the model.

Emergent Governance and Complexity at the Core

Eric Raymond saw deep distinctions between his experiences with Unix development and what he was witnessing with the development and spread of Linux and other open source software produced through peer production networks. He characterized the deep innovation of open source production methodology as the difference between the Cathedral and the Bazaar:³ The former is a centralized model with strong individuals or groups guiding a strategy of rapid prototyping and evolutionary programming. The latter is a philosophy of “release early and often, delegate everything you can, be open to the point of promiscuity.” Steven Weber, in *The Success of Open Source*,⁴ suggests four general principles for organizing distributed innovation:

- Empower people to experiment
- Enable bits of information to find each other
- Structure information so it can recombine with other pieces of information
- Create a governance system that sustains this process

Licenses Support the Commons

A key to peer production networks is the creation of resource commons that are open to anyone for use. Mechanisms are needed in order to protect the commons from abuse, depletion, and from others interested in pro-

downloading from a single server. This way, each new downloader not only uses up bandwidth but also contributes bandwidth back to the swarm.

proprietary gain from enclosing them. The “General Public License,” under which open source software is distributed, is itself a legal technology of cooperation that uses the restrictions of the law to ensure the freedom to use and improve the open source commons.⁵ Creative Commons is another licensing tool that protects the distribution of artistic and cultural content. An important part of these licensing schemes is that they make restrictions that forbid anyone to deny or surrender users’ rights to distribute, copy, or alter licensed resources.

Strategic Principles

<i>Structure</i>	Network participants form ad hoc and self-organized systems of exchange.
<i>Rules</i>	Internal codes of conduct, ownership customs, and decision-making norms, such as technical rationality as in “let the code decide,” shape interactions.
<i>Resources</i>	Licensing protects access and distribution by restricting privatization of public goods and thus enables a rich resource commons.
<i>Thresholds</i>	Open participation increases network size and decreases the threshold for repair.
<i>Feedback</i>	Open participation increases network size and increases local feedback.
<i>Memory</i>	The resource commons provides a systemic memory of value created.
<i>Identity</i>	Individual and group identity drive participation in peer production efforts.

4. SOCIAL MOBILE COMPUTING: SMARTMOBS

What They Are

Social mobile computing represents the convergence of three trends: mobile communications and computing technologies, social-networking applications and processes, and aware physical environments that are embedded with communicating sensors, RFID tags and other devices. This convergence represents the emergence of aware, social environments that will serve as a new platform for human cooperative and collective activities.

Examples

Smart mobs have been one of the first pieces of evidence of social mobile computing in action, particularly those with political action as their purpose. Examples from around the world demonstrate how mobile communications and social networks with a shared interest can catalyze effective political action. The Internet's capability of connecting people who share an interest, com-

Social mobile computing combines the richness of social networks with the power of pervasive communications networking. By connecting the dots among people, places, and information, social mobile computing will enable people to act together in new ways and in situations where collective action was not possible before.

Early Indicator: Smart Mobs

Smart mobs will usher in a new form of mobile social computing. We're only seeing the first-order ripple effects of mobile-phone behavior now—the legions of the oblivious, blabbing into their hands or the air as they walk, drive, or sit in a concert, or the electronic tethers that turn everywhere into the workplace and all the time into working time. It is likely that these early instances of collective action are signs of a larger future social and organizational upheaval. Considering the powerful effects of group-forming networks, the second-order effects of mobile telecommunications of all kinds — cellular phones, SMS, location-sensing wireless organizers, electronic wallets, and wireless networks are likely to bring a social resolution. An unanticipated convergence of technologies is suggesting new responses to civilization's founding question — how can competing individuals learn to work cooperatively?

bined with the mobile telephone's ability to access resources from anywhere, helped elect a President in Korea⁷, rocket a U.S. Presidential candidate from obscurity to front-runner status,⁸ and organize demonstrations at the 1999 WTO meetings in Seattle. Elections in Kenya,⁹ Manila, and Spain¹⁰ have been similarly influenced.

Mobile gaming: In the summer of 2003, "flash mobs" broke out all over the world:¹¹ groups of people used e-mail, Web sites, and mobile phones to self-organize urban performance art. Ad hoc groups of young gamers in Scandinavia and Singapore use cellular phones equipped with GPS functionality to play urban adventure and superhero games like Bot Fighter and Street Fighter. Location-based services are on the horizon and will be a form of providing customized experiences, services, and environments for social networks. Mobile Internet services that are designed to suit in-place group and individual

Cooperation Amplified

Social mobile computing is poised to become an important organizational strategy for communities, governments, and businesses alike. A new literacy of cooperation—a skill set for how to leverage the power of socio-technical group-forming networks and catalyze action⁶—will become an important competency in the next decades. From daily activities as mundane as shopping and as important as obtaining health care and participating in civic life, smart-mob skills will play an important role in how people interact on a daily basis. Those who are not equipped to manage this sort of group action will be at a disadvantage — a new class of digital have-nots.

Strategic Principles

<i>Structure</i>	As people connect to each other, information and place, structure grows organically from the edges.
<i>Rules</i>	Rules are simple, few in number, and clearly articulated.
<i>Resources</i>	Social-network effects help grow public resources.
<i>Thresholds</i>	Thresholds in group size shape the type of collective action possible.
<i>Feedback</i>	Local feedback helps provide customized

experiences will further make the physical environment a personal and social space

information and solves coordination problems.

Memory Physical place can become an important trigger of group memory.

Identity Physical place becomes an important extension of individual and group identity.

5. GROUP-FORMING NETWORKS : INTEGRATING THE SOCIAL AND THE TECHNICAL

What They Are
Group-forming networks (GFNs) represent the combination of human social networks and technical networks. GFNs are essential for understanding technologies of cooperation because they multiply the social and economic value from human-computer networks far more effectively and rapidly than other kinds of networks like television, telephone, or cable networks.

Examples
Social transaction networks such as those affinity groups of collectors and hobbyists on eBay reflect

Group-forming networks (GFNs) operate on the basis of Reed's Law, which states that networks grow exponentially by the number of nodes. This rapid growth explains how social networks, enabled by e-mail and other social communications, drove the growth of the Internet beyond communities of engineers to include every kind of interest group. Reed's Law is the link between computer networks and **social networks**.

Exponential Network Growth

In the economics of computer-mediated social networks, four key mathematical laws of growth have been derived by four astute inquirers: Sarnoff's Law, Moore's Law, Metcalfe's Law, and Reed's Law. Each law describes how social and economic value is multiplied by technological leverage.

According to David Reed, GFNs grow

the ability of GFNs to create locally meaningful value. Other such networks include FreeCycle (<http://www.freecycle.org>) that connects people who share an interest in recycling goods and materials and reducing waste; Interra (<http://www.interraproject.org/>), a community development project that uses connective technologies to collectively direct a small percentage of daily merchant transactions to local organizations and nonprofits; and the Media Venture Collective (<http://www.media-venture.org/call.html>), a collective philanthropic venture effort to fund citizens-based media.

Knowledge networks like the Wikipedia, group Web logs, and open source peer communities leverage GFNs to create trusted communities of practice and production. (See Knowledge Collectives for more detail.)

much faster than the networks where Metcalfe's Law holds true. Reed's Law shows that the value of the network grows proportionately not to the square of the users, but exponentially. That means you raise two to the power of the number of nodes instead of squaring the number of nodes. The value of two nodes is four under Metcalfe's Law and Reed's Law. The value of ten nodes is one hundred (ten to the second power) under Metcalfe's Law and 1,024 (two to the tenth power) under Reed's Law — the differential rates of growth climb the hockey stick curve from there.

Reed's insight emerged as he pondered the success of eBay and realized that it doesn't sell merchandise — it provides a market for customers to buy and sell from each other.

"eBay won because it facilitated the formation of social groups around specific interests. Social groups form around people who want to buy or sell teapots, or antique radios ... I realized that the millions of humans who used the millions of computers added another important property — the ability of the people in the network to form groups."

Sources of Network Value

GFNs change the kind of value generated by the network that emerges from the creation of social capital within and among groups. They enable new kinds of affiliations among people that provide the possibility of new kinds of collectively constructed user-value found in media such as online auction markets, multiplayer games, entertainment media sharing,

and other social group media.

Reed describes three categories of value from networks: the linear value of services aimed at individual users, the “square” value from facilitating transactions, and exponential value from facilitating group affiliations.

“In a network dominated by linear connectivity value growth, ‘content is king.’ That is, in such networks, there is a small number of sources (publishers or makers) of content that every user selects from. The sources compete for users based on the value of their content (published stories, published images, standardized consumer goods). Where Metcalfe’s Law dominates, transactions become central. The stuff that is traded in transactions (be it e-mail or voice mail, money, securities, contracted services, or whatnot) are king. And where the GFN law dominates, the central role is filled by jointly constructed value (such as specialized newsgroups, joint responses to RFPs, and gossip).”¹²

His key observation is that scale growth of a network tends to shift value to a new category, despite the driver of growth.

Strategic Principles

<i>Structure</i>	GFN structures grow dynamically from the edge as affiliations form social networks and links across group; social networks have the structure of scale-free “small world” networks.
<i>Rules</i>	Social capital builds and grows from ties that form GFNs.
<i>Resources</i>	The value of GFN emerges from the joint creation of value as compared to pushed content or linear transactions between pairs
<i>Thresholds</i>	Exponential growth shapes thresholds.
<i>Feedback</i>	GFNs provide diverse feedback from their various subgroups.
<i>Memory</i>	GFNs support local community memories.
<i>Identity</i>	GFNs are identity building networks, both individual and group identity.

6. SOCIAL SOFTWARE: THE MEASURE OF SOCIAL CAPITAL

What They Are

Social software is a set of tools that enable group-forming networks to emerge quickly. It includes numerous media, utilities, and applications that empower individual efforts, link individuals together into larger aggregates, interconnect groups, provide meta-data about network dynamics, flows, and traffic, allowing social networks to form, clump, become visible, and be measured, tracked, and interconnected.

Examples

Web logs, or *blogs*, are easy-to-update Web pages with the entries arranged in chronological order, with links and content that is either critical commentary about the links and/or opinion or diary confessions. Web logs can serve as peer-to-peer filters for the constant flow of information online: each blogger can be a maven who collects important links

Social software brings to life the group-forming networks that Reed discusses by helping to make them concrete social resources. It provides a rich connective online environment by providing various applications that allow affinity groups, hobbyists, professionals and communities of practice, and social cliques to find each other, meet, and connect. As social software converges with location-based technologies and embedded communications tools, social software will help integrate social networks across digital and physical spaces.

Catalyzing Social Groups

In the 1990s, virtual communities grew out of the use of synchronous many-to-many media such as chat, instant messaging, and MUDs, as well as asynchronous media such as listservs, message boards, and Usenet.

These media were only the beginning of the branching evolution of many media that enable small and large groups to organize social, political, and economic activity. In the first years of the 21st century, the use of online community media has continued to grow: in 2003, millions of people posted nearly a quarter billion messages to more than 100,000 Usenet newsgroups alone. At the same time, new kinds of social media began to emerge, notably Web logs, wikis, and social-network software. More than 4 million bloggers now run up-to-the-minute mini-guides to their spe-

and passes along important news in a particular field.

Social-networking software provides a way to quickly forge or find new social connections and contacts. Each social networking tool has its own procedures for how to join or link to another network or make new contacts. Examples include including Friendster, Linked-In, Ryze, Tribe, and Flickr. Attempts to create a standard for decentralized, usercontrolled social-network sharing, such as friend-of-a-friend (FOAF) protocol are another effort to integrate social-networking software with other applications in a way that preserves individual control of personal information.

Mobile presence tools transfer online presence media such as instant messaging buddy lists to the realm of mobile devices; they move social-networking systems into a dimension of right here and right now: whom do we know nearby, and which of the people nearby would we want to know?

cial interest, critical filters for Web content, a peer-to-peer news medium, a hybrid of diary confession and gossip.

Meanwhile, friend-of-a-friend software has become part of the daily toolkit for people who want to build their own social capital by extending their networks through their friend's networks. These tools even link to real time and real space: some work has been done with software designed for wirelessly linked wearable computers that use zero-knowledge algorithms to anonymously check each other's address books when users are in proximity, notifying them if they have a certain threshold of friends in common.¹³

The Significance of Metadata

A key component of social software are the tools that help make networks visible and help network members view connections and traffic in and out of their social spaces.

Blogdex (<http://blogdex.media.mit.edu/>) and Technorati (<http://www.technorati.com>) provide ways to order the influence of bloggers—to see who is connecting to whom, from where, and which are the most popular blogs. Technorati now shows on an hourly basis which blog posts link to others, and Blogdex, displays the online items that have been linked to by the most people in recent hours.¹⁴

Syndication is another tool that enhances the connective flows of Web logging and other online publishing media. RSS and Atom create, in effect, an entirely new metamedium for publishing to each other, enabling instant syn-

dication of blog content and other dynamic content to other blogs, Web pages, and mobile devices. At the same time, an increasingly sophisticated means of “trackbacks” that alert a blogger to other blogs that link to a post, of adding comments to post and thus giving birth to a kind of ephemeral message board. Group blogs with reputation systems transform one-to-many publishing nodes into a many-to-many social network of social networks. The blogosphere is only beginning to break out into the mainstream, comparable to the Internet in 1994.

Strategic Principles

<i>Structure</i>	Social software supports scale-free network growth.
<i>Rules</i>	Simplicity of application interfaces help support social norms.
<i>Resources</i>	Social software concretizes personal relationships into social capital.
<i>Thresholds</i>	Social proximity is an important threshold indicator.
<i>Feedback</i>	Social metadata provides useful feedback on group status.
<i>Memory</i>	Social archives provide group memory.
<i>Identity</i>	Social software is a vehicle for establishing multiple personal brands.

7. SOCIAL ACCOUNTING SYSTEMS: MECHANISMS FOR BUILDING TRUST

What They Are
Social accounting systems are mechanisms for building trust among strangers and reducing the risk of transactions. They include formal rating systems, automatic referral systems, and collaborative filtering to establish the reputation of individuals and organizations as well as products and knowledge.

Examples

Transaction rating systems, epitomized by eBay, facilitate billions of dollars' worth of transactions for people who don't know each other and who live in different parts of the world.

Rated reviews, such as Epinions, create "webs of trust" as readers rate reviewers (and other raters) and reviewers get paid on the basis of their reviews.

Self-evaluating online forums, such as Slashdot and Plastic, enable participants to rate the

Reputation is the lubrication that makes cooperation among strangers possible. It's so important that some evolutionary psychologists see it as a possible explanation for the development of speech. Robin Dunbar, for example, points to gossip as a way to extend reputation beyond the small group; speech, then, is little more than a mechanism for gossip.¹⁵ Social accounting systems extend this capacity for gossip with digital technology.

Cooperation on a Larger Scale

The most profoundly transformative potential of social accounting systems is the chance to do new things together — the potential for cooperating on scales and in ways never before possible. Limiting factors in the growth of human social arrangements have always been overcome by the ability to cooperate on larger scales: the emergence of agriculture 10,000 years ago, the origin of the alphabet 5,000 years ago, the development of science, the nation-state, and the growth of telecommunications are all examples of techno-cultural innovations that have enlarged the scale of cooperation, allowing the human population to expand and radically altering the way people live.

More recently, electronic communication networks have transformed the centuries-old institution of banking. Today's global institutionalized trust system of credit cards and

postings of other participants in discussions; the best content rises in prominence and objectionable postings sink.

Automated recommendation systems, such as Amazon's, aggregate customer choices to develop suggestions for products based on similar interests and tastes.

Implicit recommendation systems use statistical analyses to provide "best fit" — for example, Google's search engine lists first those Web sites with the most links pointing to them.

ATMs, backed up by instantaneously available credit databases, authenticates millions of financial transactions every day—enabling a vast expansion of global commerce.

Escape from the Prisoner's Dilemma

Social accounting systems also offer a means to escape from social dilemmas like the traditional Prisoner's Dilemma game. This game pits self-interest against cooperation, and the choice turns on the question of trust: Does Prisoner A trust Prisoner B to keep a mutual silence pact?

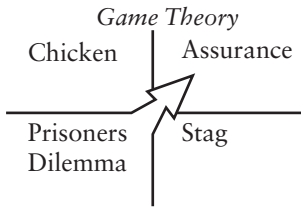
The true solution to the problem is to turn the Prisoner's Dilemma game into an Assurance Game in which players win by building their reputation as trusted partners. Social accounting systems build this reputation in a variety of ways, from formal, centralized rating systems to distributed collaborative-filtering mechanisms.

Risk as a Design Criterion

The choice of system depends on the risk involved. Automated collaborative filtering works best in low-risk situations — for example, the decision to buy a book or a movie ticket. Amazon.com and other e-commerce sites thus use collaborative filtering to make suggestions to regular customers.

When choices involve larger amounts of money or less certainty about the transaction, more explicit and formal rating systems work better. For example, eBay's reputation system answers this need with remarkable success.

Thus, as the currency of social accounting changes from knowledge or social recognition to money, the technology forks into two lineages of systems: those that deal with recommendations or other forms of knowledge and those that deal with markets.



Strategic Principles

- Structure* Multiple sources of information and multiple paths to the sources increase trust.
- Rules* Transparency shifts emphasis from punishment to prevention.
- Resources* Trust increases the value of a market.
- Thresholds* Aggregated statistics of behavior and ratings reduce the noise in an info-rich environment.
- Feedback* Extending the “shadow of the future” reinforces cooperative behavior in the present.
- Memory* Visible histories of interactions create an externalized, sharable memory.
- Identity* Simple, quantitatively-derived icons represent complex historical behaviors.

KNOWLEDGE COLLECTIVES: ONLINE KNOWLEDGE ECONOMIES

What They Are
Knowledge collectives are emergent online communities, structures and processes for information “hunting and gathering.” They extend the capabilities of online communities to support collective knowledge gathering, sharing, and evaluation. They are notable for their scale and their ability to create ad hoc distributed knowledge enterprises.

Examples
Wikis are easy-to-edit group Web pages. They enable groups to create large, self-correcting knowledge repositories like Wikipedia. Anyone can edit any article; a complete archive of previous versions makes it easy to restore old versions, so it’s easy to repair errors and vandalism.

Social bookmarking allows people to share their Web bookmarks with others. Pioneered by del.icio.us, the software creates shared lists of bookmarks,

Knowledge collectives offer an alternative way to organize a knowledge economy. Rather than treating knowledge as private intellectual property, they treat it as a common-pool resource, with mechanisms for mutual monitoring, quality assurance, and protection against vandalism and overconsumption. Using some of the same tools as social accounting, they fundamentally transform knowledge sharing by drastically lowering the transaction costs of matching questions and answers. They draw on informal social processes to build collective knowledge and know-how.

Knowledge as a Common-Pool Resource
Informal online aggregation of useful knowledge goes back to the lists of “frequently asked questions” (FAQs) posted to some Usenet newsgroups, starting the 1980s. These lists of questions and answers, accumulated through years of archived online conversations, represent an early attempt to both create a common-pool resource from the informal social interactions of individual knowledge holders, and to protect this commons from over consumption. Experts contribute knowledge as long as the conversation retains their interest, but they stop contributing if newcomers’ questions dominate the conversation. FAQs discourage newbies from besieging more knowledgeable posters with questions that have already been answered.

grouped by keywords that users create — called “folksonomies” to distinguish them from more formal taxonomies.

Gaming communities are online communities that swarm to solve immersive games or puzzles, using online tools to win prizes. Collective Detective and Cloudmakers are examples.

Collective online publishing is a fusion of online conversations, online publishing, and online reputations systems form an alternative model for refereed publication. Slashdot and Kuro5hin are early examples. OhmyNews, with 26,000 citizen-reporters, tipped the Korean Presidential election.

Beyond their defensive function, FAQs constitute a new kind of encyclopedia, collectively gathered and verified, and webs of knowledge about hundreds of topics.¹⁶ In recent years, experiments in collective knowledge gathering have grown explosively, yielding several new forms of knowledge economies—Web logs, wikis, online collective publishing sites, and social bookmarking systems—all of which treat knowledge as a common-pool resource. In some cases, these resources far outdistance privately managed compilations.

Mutual Monitoring in Knowledge Economies

Elinor Ostrom has pointed to mutual-monitoring mechanisms as one of the fundamental requirements for successful institutions of collective action. In the world of knowledge collectives, mutual monitoring is achieved in several ways. Wikipedia, a project started on January 15, 2001, grew to over 1 million articles in more than 100 languages by September 2004.¹⁷ To assure quality and protect against vandalism on such a large scale, Wikipedia uses the notion of “soft security.” The integrity of the system is maintained by making a complete revision history accessible to all.

In online collective publishing systems, the quality of the content is also assured by mutual monitoring. In the publishing community Kuro5hin, all content is generated and selected by registered users who submit articles to a submissions queue and vote on whether submissions are published on the front page, in a

less prominent section, or not at all. (In addition, the Scoop software that founder Rusty Foster developed is open source and freely available, spawning a next generation of publishing communities.)

Small-World Knowledge Networks

Knowledge collectives build on the age-old social game of accruing social status by distributing high-quality recommendations. Social bookmarking extends this practice in a way that can help build small-world knowledge networks (with the advantages of fewer degrees of separation). For example, del.cio.us is not only a knowledge-sharing tool but also a social software system: it matches users who bookmark the same pages or use the same keywords. Combining these two functions could be the key to growing organizations that take full cognitive and social advantage of knowledge collectives.

Strategic Principles

<i>Structure</i>	Personal knowledge structures aggregate to form broad-based knowledge communities.
<i>Rules</i>	Mutual-monitoring mechanisms assure quality and protection of resources.
<i>Resources</i>	Individual contributions and the collective value of the knowledge community are mutually reinforcing.
<i>Thresholds</i>	The cost of repair is less than the cost of damage.
<i>Feedback</i>	Ad hoc taxonomies reveal and reinforce emergent knowledge networks.
<i>Memory</i>	A complete history of revisions allows quick, cost-effective recovery from abuse of the resource.
<i>Identity</i>	Personal reputation requires both personal contributions and peer review of others.

LEARNING FROM COOPERATIVE TECHNOLOGIES: SEVEN GUIDELINES

Every technology of cooperation holds a lesson for those who would like to experiment with cooperative strategies. Taken together, they suggest some basic guidelines for these experiments:

1 | Shift Focus from Designing Systems to Providing Platforms

Technologies of cooperation each reflect an important shift in the structural qualities of cooperative organizations—a shift from explicit design of systems to providing platforms for tool creation and system emergence. Wikipedia, eBay, FreeCycle, Open Source, synchronous swarms, and smart mobs were not designed, but rather they emerged from the intentional creation of tools and platforms for interaction and value exchange. This is an important distinction because it also shifts the role of leadership and management from an authority who explicitly shapes direction to a catalyst and periodic intervener who sets conditions and frameworks for interactions. Two key structural issues are scalability and modularity. Cooperative technologies tend to create modules (discrete pieces/kernels of code, sub-group social networks, geospatial focal points, and multiple identities) that can be combined to create larger scale social, transactional, and networked systems.

2 | Engage the Community in Designing Rules to Match Their Culture, Objectives, and Tools

Rules are an important way of framing the interactions and scope of behaviors in a cooperative system, and the community should be engaged in this kind of rule making. Rules originate from the community's own context, and should serve a specific purpose. In open source, the value of technical rationality, for example, frames the rule “let the code decide” in matters of forking and code design. This is in keeping with the objectives of the open source community, whose goal is to create the best and most elegant software possible. If rules are not contextually meaningful they are bound to create friction, erode trust, and lead to possible defections. As Elinor Ostrom suggests, rules need to be

flexible and adaptable, allowing the possibility of the creation of new rules if necessary—and local communities are more likely to observe peer-agreed contracts than coercive laws enforced by distant authorities. When individuals are able to engage in the creation and enforcement of rules, such as mutual monitoring, peer-level security mechanisms, and contribution to FAQs and other visible documentation of rules, the system of rules become more internalized within a group.

3 | Learn How to Recognize Untapped or Invisible Resources

A key attribute of cooperative systems is how they manage and value resources. Often assets may seem too small to be worth anything or too distributed to be harnessed, yet cooperative practices are quite effective at aggregating small contributions into larger, highly valuable resources. They also are capable of converting or translating private resources into public ones that provide broader wealth. Sometimes resources may not be visible or may not appear to have clearly measurable value. Through group-forming social networks and social-accounting systems, such resources are able to find measurable value in meaningful group contexts.

4 | Identify Key Thresholds for Achieving “Phase Shifts” in Behavior or Performance

Developing a competency for identifying, tracking, and monitoring various threshold points will be particularly important for managing cooperative systems. The technologies of cooperation exhibit specific kinds of thresholds that seem to be important in creating qualitative shifts in performance or behavior: ease of participation; scale of participation and reach of networks; degrees of separation within networks; costs of disruption and repair; signal-to-noise ratios; granularity of analysis and sense making, and the range of risk and uncertainty. Often standard thresholds — such as system capacity and bandwidth — are transformed by technologies of cooperation into something else. These are particularly important threshold shifts to track because they point to the emergence of new value and wealth in the system.

5 | Track and Foster Diverse and Emergent Feedback Loops

Feedback loops help create the deep memory needed for adaptive learning. Regular communication allows for actors to share information and adjust behaviors. Cooperative technologies tend to be open and peerto-peer, allowing for feedback loops from all types of actors and layers in an organizational system. Feedback loops can be as simple as establishing frequent e-mail communications or setting up team or enterprise wikis and blogs. They can be more complex and involve setting up automated, real-time data gathering across organizational systems like work flows and production processes. As with thresholds, developing a competency in detecting diverse feedback loops and their relative value to the system will help increase the level of cooperation. Together with thresholds, feedback loops can provide important triggers to help moderate conditions in an organizational system, reducing defection or increasing the likelihood of cooperation. Often individuals themselves are an important source of feedback, as in the user producers of peer production systems. Metadata created by social software tools or tags and taxonomies created by users of knowledge collectives are other examples of feedback that provides a picture of the status and quality of cooperation in an organization and the resources being created.

6 | Look for Ways to Convert Present Knowledge into Deep Memory

Historical record and memory help to create a foundation for learning and future action. Memory is really at the core of becoming adaptive and flexible to the external environment, even as it rapidly changes. Cooperative tools such as auto archiving of the Wikipedia, social records symbolized in power seller icons in eBay, and visible histories of interactions all help create deep memory that members of an organization or system can rely on to guide future actions (establishing the “shadow of the future,” as Robert Axelrod suggests) and to increase the opportunities for cooperation and the likelihood of a positive outcome.

7 | Support Participatory Identity

A key word related to identity in cooperative systems is participatory. The various technologies of cooperation all leverage and support dif-

ferent ways for individuals to express themselves through participation and contribution. As Steven Weber remarked (in a personal interview November 2004) about diverse motivations for participating in open source style efforts, “People actually want to be productive in the Freudian sense, in the erotic sense that Freud understood. Human beings like to leave their impression on the world and create things.” Cooperative endeavors provide individuals that opportunity to satisfy their deep human need for productivity through participation and the creation of resources, artifacts, and value. Tools that help assess, track, make visible, and manage multiple identities related to production and participation will help stimulate cooperative systems.

A FINAL NOTE

Throughout this report we have been discussing how a range of technologies can shape cooperative strategy and lead to new social forms that will introduce a new set of strategic choices. A key point that shouldn’t be omitted here is the role of competition. One clear lesson from this research is that cooperative strategy does not replace competitive strategy; the two are inter-related and co-evolve. A key challenge is learning to understand the dance between the two strategies, their respective range of choices, and the conditions that urge an organization to follow one or the other at a particular time period and environmental context.

For example, we’ve learned that a common strategy is to compete under conditions of scarce resources, but what are the conditions that would compel an organization to cooperate to multiply resources? We’ve also learned from symbiogenesis that species engage in symbiotic relationships to avoid competition and to develop new ecological niches that offer new relationships to other species and to new kinds of resources. Thus new social forms present new choices. Sometimes organizations may develop symbiotic relationships to carve out a new market niche and compete over a new resource. Sometimes competition on a local level spurs cooperation on a larger level, and vice versa. The point is that the goals and contexts that drive desires to compete and cooperate are always in flux, and thus competition and cooperation will likely become a pair of evolutionary strategies for organizations.

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FREE COOPERATION: An overview

The dimensions of domination

1. Direct (physical) violence (“military” dimensions)
2. Structural violence (the “economic” dimension)
3. Discrimination (the “social” dimension)
4. Control of the public (the “institutional” dimension)
5. Dependency (the “existential” dimension)

Doing free cooperation: the five “politics”

1. Winding down means of domination: challenging the powers that be
 - Preventing intervention
 - Dismantling disposability
 - De-privileging formal labor
 - Appropriation of spaces and connectivity
 - Immediate strategies of survival
2. Politics of relationship: alternative socialization
 - Negotiation principle
 - Realistic cooperation
 - Recognition
 - Enabling
 - Disloyalty to what exists
3. Unfolding social capacities: subjective appropriation
 - Self-reflection
 - Collective leadership
 - Consciousness
 - Agency
 - Independence
4. Active critique of democracy: emancipatory democratization
 - Egalitarian corporatism
 - Autonomous decentralization
 - Affirmative action
 - Political correctness
 - Free basic income
5. Getting organized
 - Solidarity
 - Coalition
 - Loyalty
 - Critical articulation
 - Individuation

FREE COOPERATION

Christoph Spehr

INTRODUCTION: THE THREE BEARS

And what would the chains of dependency be like between people that don't own anything? If they chase me away from one tree, I'm free to go to another. If they mistreat me in one place, who's going to stop me from going elsewhere? — Jean-Jacques Rousseau, "Treatise on the Origin and the Foundations of Inequality Among Men"¹

There were three bears living in a hut, two big ones and a little one. The big bears have everything under control and know how it's done. But the little bear is stubborn and has a mind of its own. The big bears call him "the prince." When the big bears call him he says "no" and comes only when he feels like it. He doesn't want to eat soup; although it is healthy and tastes good, he'd rather go for the ham. Later, if the soup has long grown cold, all of a sudden he eats it. When he goes to bed he doesn't want to put on his pyjamas and wishes a light to be left on.

The big bears let the little bear have his way, but they are not satisfied. They don't

think this is right. The big bears seek advice from a bear therapist. (The little bear being absent, of course.) The bear therapist says: “No wonder! I’ll paint you a picture.” He paints a picture showing the little bear wearing a crown and the big bears bending on their knees in front of him. “That’s what you are,” the therapist bear says. “Hang the picture in your house, and it will help you.”

The big bears hang the picture in their house. Next time the little bear says “I don’t want to come to eat now” one of the big bears looks at the picture and says firmly:

“Come here now, prince, or you’ll have to go to bed!” This shocks the little bear. The other big bear is just on the edge of asking the little bear if he would like to eat something else when he sees the picture at the wall and says: “*Basta*. If you don’t like this — off you go!” In bed, the little bear cries because he wishes a light to be left on.

But nobody cares. After a while the little bear begs for a good-night kiss at least, nothing more. He gets it. The big bears are now very loving and friendly again. The big bears look at the picture at the wall and they see how the therapist bear’s magical painting is slowly changing. The little bear’s crown disappears, and the big bears straighten up. It almost looks as if the little bear is smiling.

This is how it should be!

This story, taken from the children’s magazine *Hoppla*,² is a typical demonstration of democratic propaganda. It shows all the patterns and horrors of this propaganda, which today is quite normal in all fields.

What’s typical is, first, the questions that are not asked. What entitles the big bears to tell the little bear at which time he has to go to bed, and whether or not he needs a light on when he does? Why does the fact that he has a personal taste in eating make them his subordinates?

What harm is done by him not eating his soup, and why aren’t they happy if he does eat it later? Who makes more impositions on the other: the little bear whose impositions always stand out, or the old bears and their world, encompassing endless rules, claims, norms and articulating one huge polyp-like imposition on the little bear: to adapt and to accept

it as it is? Why is there a distinction made between these impositions according to who imposes them, and how is this distinction explained or justified? Who really has power: the little bear, following later into a world that is dished up to him by others, or the old bears who own this world, are in charge of it, who are able to cook for themselves and are not afraid in the dark? What does this mean for the situation of conflict?

Second, it's typical that social cooperation can only be imagined in a form where someone is in charge. Somebody has to be in charge and somebody else not. This is considered "straight" and creates "order" and "orientation" for all. There's always somebody wearing the crown, either the little bear, where it is seen, or the big bears, where it is invisible because the big bears are just right. Conflict is bad. Disputing is bad. Indecision is bad: it is taken as evidence that there's something wrong.³ Of course, according to democratic propaganda, people are not in charge, but principles are. Rules. Discourses. Forms of decision-making. And he or she who does not want such decisions to be "made" for him or her is the enemy.

Third, the forms of denunciation are typical: the enemy, the rebel, the one kicking against the rules, the stubborn one who has to be called to order by force, is represented as a monarch. His lack of submission is portrayed as the tyranny of an absolutist prince. His refusal to work, to perform, to function according to the norms that are planned for him, is branded as parasitism, decadence, luxury, being a sissy — all kinds of accusations that we associate with the lifestyle of aristocrats and princes. This is the normal way of denunciation in the democratic age, no matter if it is against the claims of children, welfare mothers, poor nations or whomever. The underdogs of the social hierarchy are portrayed as snooty idlers wearing ermine fur, as the real oppressors, the hidden princes.

Fourth, what is taken for granted is typical: that power used in conformity with the dominant ideas of the social order is legitimate and that it is, at the same time, no power at all. This sounds absurd but is quite normal, and the core of democratic propaganda. Ownership, control, brute or structural force, access to the levels where norms are set

and rules negotiated, everything that makes the difference between an old, fat bear and a little bear is so natural that it becomes invisible.

Why does the house belong to the old bears? Because they were born in it? Because they built or bought it at a time when the little bear didn't have any chance yet to build or buy a house? Why is it up to them at which time the food is eaten? Because they cooked it? If that's true, shouldn't it be up to those who grew it? Or to those from whom they bought the seeds? Or to those who dragged the seed sacks to them? Or to those who cooked food for the sack-draggers? What is the difference between these ones and the others in the chain? Why are the old bears allowed to force the little bear to do something? What entitles them to know what is good for the little bear? Ain't it a scandal that they have such an advantage over him?

If someone questions it they say there are forms of democratic decision-making and that these determine who's allowed to do what. If someone questions further they say, well, of course not everything is subject to this kind of decision-making, and not any decision may come out of it. There's also reason, the law, protection, necessity, tradition, common sense, and so on; and behind each of these notions you could add in brackets, "(of those having power)." If someone complains about it, about this power, they say: this isn't power. We don't waste time musing about the absurdity of this attitude. We've got our therapist bears who do the dirty business of ideological whitewashing for us: philosophy professors, political scientists, teachers, neighbors, alehouse politicians, all-male friendships, glossies. All kinds of therapist bears that we pay and hire or who feel a mission to do it. The therapist bears help us to cut ourselves off emotionally against the claims of others and to overcome feeling mean if we use force to make hungry bears sleep in the dark.

Democratic propaganda means the propaganda of domination in the democratic age. In the democratic age, our age — beginning around the revolutionary shocks of the early 20th century and enduring until today — domination of a pre-democratic type loses acceptance. In earlier times it was just the difference, the inequality between dominants

and subordinates with which ruling groups underpinned their claim of command. The ruling groups stated they were appointed to rule by nature. They were qualified for it by nature, nearer to God, nearer to reason, nearer to civilization, nearer to whatever. They'd be the head, the others the organs. It was with such arguments that in pre-democratic times kings and aristocracy justified their rule over the people, men their rule over women, whites their rules over non-whites, rich over poor, economic elites over those who owned nothing but their labor power.

In the democratic age this all changed. Justifications of this type are, in the long run, not accepted. This doesn't mean that domination disappears, but it changes, and it is presented differently. In the democratic age the dominant and privileged tirelessly emphasize how equal they are to the others: no god-like over-bear, just another bear among bears. They brag no more about their rule. They claim there is no more rule. And when the big, old bears cut the little ones down to size, they do not rule, they only assert the rules that are valid for everybody. Strictly speaking they act in self-defense; they are the ones who have to defend themselves against the breakers of rules.

We are living in a world that is made and ruled by old bears. The story about the three bears could have been told the same way in West and East, in democratic capitalism and in "really-existing" socialism. It is told in schools and parliaments, in factories and offices, in families and relationships; it justifies dominance between sexes, ethnic groups, social and economic groups, and between nations. It is told before one attacks a country with military force, before one makes cuts in the social welfare system, before one hits somebody in the face.

Today a vast repertoire of bear variations is available. Self-satisfied bears, frustrated bears, lecturing bears, easy-going bears. Hot and cold ones. But the pattern remains the same. No, we do not arrogate something to ourselves, for heaven's sake! We just enforce the rules that are valid for anybody.

Future archeologists excavating our civilization will wonder about the incredible number of artifacts produced by this civilization of the

democratic age: Space centers and final disposal sites, power plants and manufacturing plants, stock exchanges and concert halls, business centres and palaces of private luxury. The archeologists of the future could draw the same conclusion as we do looking at the pyramids of Giza, the temples of Angkor Wat or the Great Wall of China: that these artifacts must have been the result of slave work, very likely done by prisoners of war or people deported by force, and their children and grandchildren.

They wouldn't be far from the truth with this. The artifacts of the democratic age are actually slave work. They are the work of male and female slaves of today's world order: prisoners of war in a general economic war of the rich against the poor, people deported by the force of plight or lack of alternatives. Turn the objects on the table around, see where they have been made, ask why they are made there: because work is cheap and available there. Think about which kind of work everything comes down to in the end, or with which kind of work it starts; ask about the rank, prestige, conditions of that work: you will very probably find housework and child care done by women; low-wage work done by migrants and migrant workers at building sites and the lines of waste-separation; often illegal, unprotected work of those who cannot exist without this additional income at all kinds of serving, cleaning, transport; extreme low-wage work in countries of the global South mining raw materials, cultivating food plants, manufacturing in tax-free production areas, doing sexual work.

Ask which of the artifacts would come about if those who produce them would have to agree of their own free will to build them or to contribute to them, if they had to provide time and strength for it out of their own motivation and not driven by the necessity to sell their work-force in this or that way. Few of the artifacts would be left.

The old bears claim we are equal and free. There's nothing true about it. We are neither equal nor free. We lock our children in rooms they are not allowed to leave, handing them over to the command of people they cannot choose and cannot refuse to cooperate with. We call it school, and it continues with apprenticeships, universities, companies. We tell

people who lack sufficient income exactly what they need for a living, determined by calculating the price of a standard set of goods (including, for decades, a special sort of ice cream whose price never rises). We decide where they may live, at which point their washing machine is really broken, and whom they have to sue. We explain to those fleeing from other places that unfortunately the world is already distributed, by chance to our advantage. We tell them what they legitimately have to suffer elsewhere, and which standard of living is normal for them. If we kill them in the course of a deportation by plane, because they suffocate from the gag, it's not seen as a big issue. They weren't our kind, they only wanted to be. We tell those who consider the rules of our society horrible that, sorry, for people that sensitive, there is no place in real life. Many take this literally. We don't feel responsible for those cases; we think about where they may have shown signs of weakness and susceptibility earlier.

It is not only slave work that creates the artifacts of our civilization. It is also slave attitude: to let happen what happens. To follow the rules made by others. To accept that maybe you could change the rules in complicated ways, but meanwhile to follow them at any cost. We train for that. We make everybody learn it and ostracize those who don't get it. We do not protect those who break rules. We protect the rules.

We enforce slave attitude as we enforce slave work. It is not only by the work of those sweating for him that the rich person lives; it is also their inability to steal from him. He lives by the structure, too, that throws land, capital, knowledge on him and not on others. His command extends not only to making people do something for him, but also to making people not do something against him.

Ask what might be left over from the artifacts if those whose share of the world and of history is used up could demand their share back, or if they could decide which portion of their contribution they would prefer to leave in it because of their approval of the project and which they would prefer to make into firewood or to trade for something they consider more useful for themselves. Not all artifacts would disappear. But many would. Their production would slow down, their planning would become more careful. Their use would become more clear and

direct. They would shrink to what, not without reason, is called an acceptable level — in contrast to the distribution and accumulation of artifacts that archeologists rightly identify as the sign of a slave-owning society.

We shall hardly find in today's world a society where freedom or equality are achieved, nor even one where they are considered as basic political or social values — unless we accept the miserable definitions of freedom and equality that are dished up to us. Today's order is one of domination like most of its predecessors were, only of a different or differently-constructed domination. The violence that society or actual individuals and groups inject into the lives and fates of other groups and individuals may be complicated in some parts, simple and primitive in others, but far-reaching anyway.

It is the original sin of the democratic modern age not to have fought this violence on principle, but to be primarily concerned with how it should be legitimized and codified and who should have influence on that. "Domination that is democratically legitimized and executed is no domination" is the creed (whereby definitions differ as to what "democratically legitimized and executed" means). This is the main historical tendency of the democratic modern age, by which it inherits the earlier forms of domination, although in a changed way.

There was (and is) another tendency inherent in this modern age, a tendency to try and limit power, to criticize domination and to try and contain it. In this tendency, there is still a sense of the enormous violence that society turns against individuals and groups, and of the extreme illegitimacy of this violence.

But the democratic modern age isn't so much a conflict between forces that could be clearly identified with these two tendencies as it is the history of a mutual penetration of both tendencies found in the practice of movements and organizations, in the ideas and utopias of individuals and groups. The works of Rousseau are determined by the clash of these two tendencies, but also literally torn apart between them. If the Rosa Luxemburg Foundation takes up the trail of the Academy of Dijon and seeks for answers in the tradition of Rousseau's *Treatise On the Origin and the Foundations of Inequality Among Men*, it is seeking those rare

moments where the veil tears and violence and its illegitimacy are made visible.⁴ Rousseau's treatise is an unsparing critique of this violence, of the impositions of the democratic modern age just as they began to fully take power. Today these impositions go much further than Rousseau could ever imagine — they inscribe themselves politically, socially, psychologically, technically, even biologically into humans. Also the veiling of these impositions, their naturalization, their apparent voluntary acceptance, even demand by the people themselves, goes much further than was conceivable in 1755.

Rousseau, however, dealt with both hands, played on both sides.⁵ Later, writing the *Social Contract*, he advocated devoting oneself completely to the first main tendency of the modern age, to its original sin, driven by the idea that when domination is correctly formally codified and democratically legitimized it is no longer domination and therefore would be infinite in the range of its violence and perfectly justified.

Rousseau did what many others did after him: he made the “jump” from the aporias and frustrations of the second tendency into the safety and apparent agency power of the first tendency. He devoted himself, as “Star Wars” puts it, to “the dark side” of power. However, it is only apparently power you get from it because there is no agency in it. You imagine that going along with this tendency you finally could intervene and change something; but all in all you just sign up.

This “jump” is comparable to the “jump” that Camus (in *The Myth of Sisyphus*) analyzed in the life and works of many literary figures who start as atheists and end as Catholics.⁶ Between their original conviction that in the modern age there are no more generally justifiable values and orientations, and their later conviction that these binding values and orientations can be taken from Christianity, there is no logical transition, no deduction. They just “jump.” The only connection is the radicality of their respective belief, their fixation on the question to which they change the answer. When you can't take it anymore where you used to be, you “jump.” (All converting writers Camus reports on became Catholics.)

It is of course no secret to the Foundation that Rousseau “dealt with both hands,” although it does not speak about it in the call. (To be

clear: In *The Social Contract* Rousseau enjoined the members of the new society to kill each other for rulebreaking, just like that, and he didn't see any contradiction between this and his claim that under the social contract man should stay "as free and equal as before."⁷) And there is no doubt that there are parallels to the fate of the socialist movement and Marxist theory that played on both sides in the 20th century: agreeing with the critique of violence and the impositions of the democratic modern age, and agreeing with the justification of this violence and the submission under these impositions. If the Foundation calls for essays discussing "under which conditions freedom and equality can be compatible," it implies that this task is still unsolved. It seeks an alternative future for the critique of Rousseau's Second Treatise, as it seeks, going back to Rosa Luxemburg, an alternative future of the socialist critique.

The Rosa Luxemburg Foundation's question aims at the heart of the order under which we live. It is a cold heart, ready for violence, the heart of an enlightened slave-owner society and the heart of old bears; in many cases, of "jumped" bears. However, there are some false trails radiating from the question. The Foundation takes up a question of our time and turns it into a theme; being a question of our time it must be accompanied by imagined propositions that have to be identified and questioned themselves.

To put it another way, the question in its given form may suggest certain ideas that are not helpful if you want to find a liberating answer. The most important of these suggestions are:

- the idea that freedom and equality can be separated at all or at least defined separately;
- the idea that in democratic capitalism, freedom is realized at the expense of equality ("political freedom"), whereas in really-existing socialism, equality is realized at the expense of freedom ("social equality");
- the idea that there could be a blueprint for a social order, an institutionalized system of rules, that would unerringly produce freedom and equality;
- the idea that there is a hierarchy between the general socio-politi-

cal form that a society chooses (their institutional and economic “main order”) and the actual social conditions and interactions (the real life of the involved individuals and groups) — a hierarchy conceived as causality and the “main order” as the only determining force;

— the idea that political theory as “science” has a logic in itself (an immanent logic, an inherent logic, a logic independent from its object), and the quality of the theory largely depends on the precision of its definitions and the conclusiveness of its argumentation.

These ideas — which at least could be read into the call — are at any rate not agreed to in this essay. Here the statement is that freedom and equality coincide in the concept of free cooperation:

— that the models of “cynical freedom” and “disempowered equality” (as they were propagated and practiced in democratic capitalism and really-existing socialism) had little in common either with freedom or with equality;

— that the answer to the question is not to be found in a social order system but in a policy;

— that the different spaces and cooperations of society are connected by self-similarity, and that a critical utopia and a policy devoted to it do not have the structure of an external framework but have to unfold a self-similar program for the most disparate spheres and cooperations;

— that the quality of political theory stems from the fact that it clings tightly to the actual practice of emancipatory efforts (like the dress that Büchner demands constitution to be: fitting to the body of the people instead of re-shaping it⁸) and that it is usable for these and other efforts, while the quality of political theory and of science in general definitely does not result from being given a pat on the back by the trivial norms of the academic system.

The question must therefore be reconstructed by its answer. It has to be, because an answer daring something new, as the Rosa Luxemburg Foundation explicitly demands, cannot be already included in the logical form of the question so that it only has to be deduced from it.

The answer has to poach in reality, make the question’s rug dirty. Otherwise it wouldn’t be an answer.

The answer that is given here is: People are free and equal within the framework of free cooperation.

Free cooperation has three definitions: It is based on the acknowledgment that given rules and given distributions of control and possession are a changeable fact, and do not deserve any higher objectifiable right. In free cooperation, all members of the cooperation are free to quit, to give limits or conditions for their cooperative activity in order to influence the rules according to their interests; they can do this at a price that is similar and bearable for all members; and the members really practice it, individually and collectively.

Free cooperation needs a policy that materializes itself again and again anew, challenging in practice the limits of freedom and the reality of equality, getting through the external and internal preconditions of a “similar and bearable price.” (Such a policy, by the way, defines “left” politics in contrast to “right” politics.) For this, as a “middle-range” politics, the main elements or criteria can be given that may be applied to all spheres of social cooperation.

The answer takes Rousseau’s “chains of dependency,” cited above, as a starting point. We are used to certain discussions about the order “under the trees”: how it could become as free and equal as possible, what has to be considered mistreatment, and how that can be prevented. What eludes us is that these theoretical reflections and the practical politics of the democratic age tie the people to the tree. They cannot leave. They are the theoretical and practical object of the respective social order.

But in this position we can never become free and equal. If someone wants to leave one tree and walk to another it doesn’t make sense to say: He or she is wrong. We can only realize the fact that someone is not satisfied with the existing cooperation under this tree, be it a private relationship, a group, a project, or a social system. If someone continues to consider a cooperation desirable for him- or herself, it is a fact that we cannot look behind, not by theorizing nor by a prescriptive practice. It is the really-existing cynicism of democratic domination to force people under a tree and to try and prove to them: you’re fine!

But turned upside down it becomes a concept. If people strive for freedom and equality, they usually do it by leaving their tree, or by gaining influence on the order under their tree, because they will leave it otherwise, or won't play the game anymore that is played under their respective trees.

This is the general form of emancipatory practice. Left politics — a politics that rejects domination and promotes real freedom and equality — can neither theoretically anticipate this concrete emancipatory practice nor practically render it superfluous. The content of left politics is to affirm that this emancipatory practice can happen — in fact for everybody and at a similar and bearable price. There is no “big success,” no “social order” in the traditional sense that would render concrete emancipation and left politics superfluous.

In contrast to Rousseau's suggestion in the cited passage, there are no social conditions where people “don't own anything.” There are always forms of control, of possession, varying of course, and they are always open to result in domination. And even getting rid of dominant intervention, the abolition of coercion, does not by itself tell us how we want to live.

The German title of this essay, *Gleicher als Andere*, is ambiguous. “More equal than others” is from Orwell. In *Animal Farm*, one day the animals discover that the first law “All animals are equal” has been supplemented by the pigs’ “but some animals are more equal than others.” It shows how the orders of domination in the democratic age proclaim freedom and equality while distorting its meaning, so that behind the people's back they create and legitimize unfreedom and inequality.

In democratic capitalism there have always been some animals freer than others, and in really-existing socialism some animals are more equal than others — a situation that has little in common with freedom and equality.

In this essay, however, it is also stated that freedom and equality cannot be given or fulfilled by a new dominant, top-down framework. Freedom and equality, summed up as free cooperation, is the achieve-

ment of people, the result of a policy in its broadest sense, and it is a feature of collectives — of cooperatives, be they societies, groups, relationships, economic collectives or collectives of societies. In that sense there are indeed cooperations that are more free and more equal than others.

The self-confidence of a future left politics won't be based on "having solved the problems" and "having realized freedom and equality," because in the end this cannot be achieved. It won't be based on bowing to would-be necessities, or to changing currencies of freedom and equality as they are branded and traded in markets.

It will be based on being more free and equal than others, and willing to work for it on every level.

PART ONE FREEDOM AND EQUALITY

1. ON SLAVERY (THE DOMESTIC SERVANT PRINCIPLE)

Morpheus: What is the Matrix? It is the world that has been pulled over your eyes to blind you from the truth.

Neo: What truth?

Morpheus: That you are a slave, Neo. Like everybody else, you were born into bondage... kept inside a prison that you cannot smell, taste, or touch. A prison for your mind.

— Andy and Larry Wachowski, “The Matrix”

Today’s middle class is well acquainted with a problem that is known as “the domestic servant dilemma.” It goes like this: When the first child is old enough, the mother returns to her job. Being responsible, according to patriarchal conventions, for the sphere of family reproduction, she buys external services so that she has the time she needs to go to work. She employs a domestic servant. The domestic servant costs money. The woman who employs the domestic servant, however, usually works part-time herself. Having been “out” on baby leave, having “lost her qualifications” as well as being the object of general patriarchal wage-injustice, she is paid relatively little. In addition, state tax laws may disadvantage her (because they support most strongly the single-income male “bread-winner”).

It turns out not to pay off. The wage advantage goes down the drain, at best exchanged for what the domestic servant earns (and you may even lose out if there should be health-insurance for the domestic servant). The woman can’t go back to her job without a domestic servant, but with a domestic servant, she can’t go either. This is the domestic servant dilemma.

The domestic servant dilemma applies to the most various services and ways of life. Its economy can be articulated in terms of money or of time. What does the day-care mother cost? How much time does it cost to bring the children to the kindergarten, to pick them up afterwards,

to take part in parents' meetings, maybe to cook for the whole group every few days, etc.? How much trouble does a domestic servant make who's constantly messing up the whole thing?

The deep sigh, that "it doesn't pay off," is produced by traditional patriarchal nuclear families as well as by homosexual partnerships or alternative flat-shares that all want to have a cleaner. It is produced by career-oriented singles discovering that their momentary relationship costs so much involvement or so much money that the emotional, temporal and financial costs outweigh the gain in reproduction of own's own workforce.

Entrepreneurial moaning about too-high non-wage labor costs — that work is "too expensive" — reproduces the pattern of the domestic servant dilemma. It doesn't work "without," but "with" it doesn't pay off either.

Of course everybody has their domestic servant. Of course it does pay off. What's the issue, then? It's about ideology. It's about the defense of a claim, about a politics to push this claim through. The claim is: You gotta cost less than me. And: You have to accept that I make the price so that you cost less than me. In fact, significantly less.

This is the domestic servant principle. Wherever there is moaning about the domestic servant dilemma, the core is the pushing-through of the domestic servant principle: the claim that someone else has to cost less than us, and that we dictate the conditions of cooperation as lopsidedly as possible.

This is a rather strange claim. Among people who consider themselves more or less equal, it is not stated. Take my kids, I'll take yours; lend me your ear for an hour, I'll lend you mine; carry my relocation cardboards, I'll carry yours; if I contribute my share to our cooperation, you'll contribute something else. All these are considered profitable cooperations (not in every case, but in general); we do not expect to get something for free. We would find it discriminatory if someone says "Listen, you really should take my kids a little more often than I take yours, because my working time is higher paid than yours, after all!" (Which doesn't mean that this doesn't actually happen every now and then.)

This is exactly the point: Between people who consider themselves equal we are extremely sensitive to the notion that one's own time, strength, performance, personality are worth significantly less than those of the other. And we are extremely sensitive if we get the impression that the actual cooperation does pay off significantly *better* for the other than it does for ourselves. We do *not* expect, however (at least, not consciously) that it has to pay off significantly better for us than for the other. Among equals we define "it pays off" as "Having this cooperation is better for me than not having it," not as "This cooperation pays off because I give you less than you give me."

The moaning about the domestic servant dilemma draws its emotional power and apparent plausibility from the fact that we are rightly sensitive to any cooperation that pays off more for others than for ourselves, and that those who are moaning often have the suspicion that they get fleeced in other cooperations anyway (which, for example, in the case of the patriarchal nuclear family is really the case for the woman's cooperation with the male "main worker").

An argument and an attitude that may be appropriate among (at least ostensible) equals are used to justify and demand a structure of inequality. We can feel this already from the fact that we wouldn't really try to negotiate this position. At least you will rarely hear anything like:

— "Listen, if I go back to work I'll earn, all charges and taxations deducted, \$750 for 100 hours of work a month. If I pay you \$12 for the hour and employ you 8 hours a week, that is \$384 a month. That means you get more from me going back to work than I do, and your hourly wage is almost twice as high as mine. If I subtract the costs for the kindergarten, I literally work for nothing."

— "Well, but it's not only for the money if you do. You need it because you want to work again, because you want to restore your own value on the labor market, or because you want to stand your ground against your husband. Anyway, you trade away work you don't like and that is not much help for you (cleaning), for work you like to do and that gives you a perspective. It may come as a surprise for you but cleaning isn't much help for me, either, and I can certainly imagine work that is more interesting and comfortable. And that in your mind's

eye you subtract the kindergarten from your wage and not from the wage of your bloke is not my problem; are you gonna pile up your children at home till they're 18? Now that I think about it, \$30 might be more appropriate."

We don't want to listen to stuff like that. Moaning about the domestic servant dilemma, we don't want to negotiate. We cling to the vision that we could dictate the conditions, would not have to negotiate, could simply order.

This is the vision of domination. We complain that in a certain sphere, in a certain relation, we do not rule enough.

What is domination? Domination consists in the disposition of others: their work, their bodies, their personalities.[†] It doesn't matter if it is done with good intention, or unwillingly, or if it may be on this or that score "useful" for the dominated. It doesn't matter what entitled us to it, if this domination is given to us, if we worked hard for it or if we just claimed it. Nor does it matter if someone assigned it to us by democratic procedure, if it came about by contracts, if we bought it, if the dominated gave it to us of their own free will.

All these are relevant distinctions; it really makes a difference in what happens. But all this doesn't alter the fact that there *is* domination.

Theorists coming from different social movements accentuate different aspects of domination. More precisely, the reflection on domination is formed by different "archetypes." Marxist theory starts from the archetype of the worker, whose life is consumed for the entrepreneur's surplus value. Feminist theory starts from the archetype of the woman, doing unpaid reproductive work in the family and being exposed to sexual violence. Theorists of black emancipation start from the archetype of the slave, who is traded as a thing, lacking any social protection and freighted by force from his or her world into another. Queer theory starts from the archetype of the person who is turned in-

[†] Editor's note: The German *Verfügung* has been translated throughout this essay as "disposition" or "disposal," in the sense of "management," "regulation," "administration," etc. Neutral in itself, it implies a sense of potential domination.

to a monster for his or her sexuality, in order to generally enforce the dominant form of family reproduction and sexual socialization. Theories of anti-colonial liberation start from the archetype of a society that is attacked and destroyed from outside and whose own development is stalled.

The list is neither complete, nor are the archetypes binding. Depending on the respective archetype, some aspects and forms of domination are more focused and others less. The more focused a theory of liberation on this or that archetype, the more powerfully its argumentation expresses the respective form of oppression and the corresponding need for liberation, and the more blurred are the other forms of oppression.

This may not only lead into conflicts between and among other liberation struggles. It may also alienate one from the next generation whose experience is already changed by the emancipatory efforts so far: its experience of domination as well as its needs for liberation are different and are no longer adequately expressed by the archetype.

A further stage of the theory, away from the archetype, becomes unavoidable. Leaving the archetype, however, involves dangers as well. A general theory of domination that is no longer bound to the historical archetypes becomes a passionless abstraction, and has no more eye for the fact that the issue is domination and not some subjectless system failure. This kind of attitude is rather trendy today. It is lightly stated that “capitalism really can’t solve today’s global problems” as if capitalism were just some kind of miscalculation and not a joined activity of people violating others. Perspectives on how that situation might be changed fall correspondingly short.

The quest for a generalized notion of domination is justified by the need for theoretical evolution and by the necessity of cross-movement coalitions. It has to be aware of the danger of falling short.

At first glance, domination seems to divide into two aspects: the aspect of exploitation — the appropriation of others’ work and nature for one’s own profit, and the aspect of dominance — of disposal of others. But we ask, “Is there an objective criterion for the profit that is drawn from others’ work and nature, a quantifiable criterion for ex-

ploitation?” And if we deny this question, then both aspects come together again as one. Domination is a way of shaping the world. It creates a world as the dominant dreams it: by disposing the dominated.

What is on stage here is therefore a generalized concept of domination that is derived from the conflict of concrete experiences, not a general notion that is abstractly deduced. Striving for a generalized concept, we can not abandon the archetypes, as descriptions or just as overtones, because general notions of domination are always abstractions that have to prove their use for concrete states of oppression.

If we want to operate on the thin ice of a generalized concept of domination, we may say: domination is forced cooperation. The cooperation is forced because one side cannot break away from it, cannot quit, cannot control what to contribute and under which conditions, has little or no influence on the rules of cooperation.

The contemporary slave-owner society tries to remove domination from the vicinity of the aforementioned archetypes. “Matrix” introduces another archetype in order to make the post-modern reality of domination visible. We are shown a society where all the ugly traditional archetypes are pushed to the fringes, and we apparently act free and equal. Only this is not reality, just a virtual stage.

In reality the structure of disposal and forced cooperation is total. But usually we don’t see it, although there is circumstantial evidence and a vague feeling.⁹ We are victims of the “matrix,” of the world that has been pulled over our eyes: the self-made stage of a democratic society, putting itself into the limelight of fighting against the traditional archetypes, insisting that it is not dominantly structured itself.

This virtual stage blinds us from reality: that we are slaves. Disposable. Subject to rules and means of controls that we cannot elude and on which we have no influence. All day, with all our sensitivity and capability; to the end of our days and to the seventh generation.

It becomes visible when we apply the definition of domination mentioned above. Almost everything is forced cooperation. To the question “What is the matrix?” the answer is: the matrix is the stage of the social void of the idea of free cooperation. It ensures that we cannot smell, nor taste, nor touch the bars of our prison. We take our prison with us, eve-

rywhere, wherever we go, into each concrete relation. And the extent to which we are enslaved in reality is far more total than it was in any ancient or bourgeois slave-owner society before.

We'd love to pull a "matrix" over our domestic servant's eyes, too, a point of view that clouds the fact that we are on the dominant side in this relationship. What would we hide? Everything that prevents our domestic servant from free negotiation or from doing something else. If we investigate the case "Why do domestic servants do it?" we get an understanding of how forced cooperation is enforced.

There are, as Tucholsky puts it, many ways to enslave a person (or a group of people).¹⁰ There are none that would not be applied in our contemporary society or in today's world order. It is not possible to give a final description of the methods and means by which domination is exercised: that is, how exploitation and dominance are perpetrated. For a pragmatic survey that will be referred to later, we can make the following divisions:

1. The exercise or threat of direct, physical violence — the "military" dimension of domination.

2. Structural violence — the introduction or maintenance of rules and distributional structures within a social cooperation that lead to a systematically unequal allocation of power: the "economic" dimension of domination.

3. Discrimination — organized exclusivity of one group against the "others": the "social" dimension of domination.

4. Control of the public — decisive influence on how people speak and think in a given cooperation, which interpretations and norms prevail: the "institutional" dimension of domination.

5. Dependency — the elimination of alternatives for the other part of the cooperation, making this cooperation the only possible choice: the "existential" dimension of domination.

The selectivity of this division is limited. Its main purpose is to give an impression of the many means of domination that are or may be used in forced cooperation. It happens easily that we forget about whole dimensions. The diversity of means is huge. The "military" dimension, that of brute force, stretches from the fists of the neighborhood boy

who beats you up on a regular basis in order to snatch your breaktime snack to the high-tech weapons with which we assault foreign countries. Structural violence is usually about the division of labor, but may also be about terms of trade. Dependency may be effected by material circumstances but also technological, psychological or emotional. The means for this reach from modern tools like the envisioned biotechnological revolution in agriculture to extremely traditional ones like the social isolation of women in patriarchal society.

Relations of domination “speak” in all dimensions. It is important for domination to be able to “translate” one dimension into another — to create economic dominance from military superiority and vice versa, to convert dependency into control of the public and vice versa, etc. We tend to underestimate the complexity and range of the means that are employed in very concrete relations. As a single individual, one usually does not exercise direct violence against one’s domestic servant, forcing her or him to work. But it is of great importance for our relationship that she or he is a refugee from Bosnia, fleeing from military force, or a migrant from Eastern Europe, running from the effects of structural violence. It influences the alternatives she or he has. We collectively discriminate against migrant domestic servants by not approving their education and grades, thereby decreasing the price of their labor or directing it to the cleaning sector. That domestic servants are usually poorly organized, and therefore have little control of the public sphere, is an advantage we accept thankfully.

On account of the complexity of the means of domination, a monopoly of force for higher structures is no solution; it serves those who have and exercise advantages in the other dimensions of domination (except the “military”). Similar strategies for the other dimensions fail, too; as we already know, the nationalization of productive wealth and economic disposal itself does not ensure at all that structural violence would disappear.

Consequently, there is a problem with the policy of “civilizing conflict,” a policy quite typical in the democratic age. It may contain positive elements of winding down means of domination. Mostly, however, its effects are negative: disarming the dominated to make them

even more vulnerable to the other tools and dimensions of domination. Winding down the means of domination is therefore a substantial field of left politics, of a politics that strives for freedom and equality, or rather, free cooperation. We should remember this, even if winding down is anything but sufficient.¹¹

2. CYNICAL FREEDOM, DISEMPOWERED EQUALITY

Freedom creates inequality. If you give two persons freedom, there will always be one of them more inventive and productive than the other.

— Themba Sono, South African economist¹²

Investigating the appearance that democratic capitalism and real-existing socialism are two systems in which one realizes political freedom at the cost of social equality, and the other realizes social equality at the cost of political freedom, we inspect the ruins of a political claim. We visit the miserable remnants. Don't touch them: they'll crumble to dust.

It is worth remembering that initially both systems were based on the political claim to realize both freedom and equality. The American Declaration of Independence quite deliberately starts with the passage that all men were born free and equal, therefore having unswerving and inalienable rights.¹³ (This prevented neither the wars of extermination against the natives nor the enslavement of Blacks in the American South.)

The society of really-existing socialism in the beginning interpreted itself as a form of liberation, as a step on the way “to overthrow all conditions where man is a humiliated, a subjugated, a forsaken, a despicable being,” as Marx put it.¹⁴ (This prevented neither mass executions nor the forced labor camps that prevailed under Stalin and during the first years of the Soviet Union.)

Compared with these claims, what we are looking at today is a world of double failure. Since the era of neoliberalism and parallel to the Breshnev era — that is, since the early 1970s — the self-projection

of both systems narrowed. Democratic capitalism stuck more and more openly to social inequality and prided itself on being politically “freer,” at least. Really-existing socialism tried less to cover up political unfreedom but defended itself as socially “more equal” at least. This meant, in the first case, a system of juridically codified “liberal rights” (freedom of speech, freedom of assembly, freedom of association, etc.), and in the second case, a smaller disparity of income.

To call such a concept of freedom and equality “reduced” would be undeserved leniency. What’s “free” about an individual who is allowed to be freely active in politics but is constantly exposed to structural subordination and to the control of the public by capital and big social power blocs? What’s “equal” about an individual whose income is within the same range of others but whose personal agency and political influence, compared to that of the top brass and the economic elite, tend towards zero?

At best, we may certify democratic capitalism as a model of *cynical freedom*. Within it, the individual suffers fewer restrictions if he/she succeeds in reaching a privileged position; through the commodified disposability of labor and nature, he/she has at least a real chance to achieve such an economically privileged position at the expense of others; and he/she can consider himself/herself politically free as long as he/she doesn’t mind that with all his/her codified rights he/she actually cannot change anything.

Accordingly, we may certify really-existing socialism as a model of *disempowered equality*. Within that, the individual is to a lesser extent threatened by absolute poverty, as long as he/she acts according to the social conventions; through the possibility of affirmative political activity, he/she has a real chance for upward social mobility at the expense of others; and he/she can consider himself/herself socially equal to others as long as he/she ignores the fact that his/her influence on society’s decisions (political, economic, social decisions) is minimal. That ain’t much.

In really-existing late socialism, as in contemporary democratic capitalism, there was and is a tendency to tear down even the last remnants, to see off social equality or the inalienability of certain liberal rights. In a way this is consistent.

What good is a front garden where freedom and equality may graze a little but must remain inside this special area, like pieces in a museum? Or what do you call it if individuals can buy whole foundations, build themselves all-automatic houses and spend several thousand bucks a month just for phone calls, while someone on social security can't even take a week's R&R? What is this, a lack of freedom? Of equality?

If workers who allegedly own their state get no wages paid for months while the managers of the military-industrial complexes that employ them go shopping on every international high-tech market but the strike is prohibited as enemy-of-the-state work? Lack of freedom? Lack of equality? Call it what you will, freedom and equality it is not. East or West, at best it is the freedom to obey and the equality of optimized commercialization. It is absolutely, purely and simply, domination.

Let's ask simple, concrete questions: How large is the share of social life and social wealth that I can shape? What old bears can interfere in my life without my being able to stop them? Which people — higher in the hierarchy and with my having no chance to stand my ground against them — make fateful decisions on my life? How many assholes do I have to convince before I can realize a good idea? How is the daily worktime distributed between men and women? What is the price of the luxury of having children; how much is it for a woman, how much for a man? Is there a group of people who usually do the hard, physical or unhealthy labor? Who are they? Is the unpleasant, monotonous or dirty work paid best and most honored? If not, why is it done by those who do it? How is it effected? Are there *schmürzes*?¹⁵ If there are, who are they? What real recognition and grade of equal rights do people coming from other countries get, or coming from the periphery of the country? What is the probability of being locked up in jail or in a psychiatric ward? What does it cost me not to be in accordance with the values and ideals of my society? What kind of life can I be forced into by my society in the worst case? Can I join whoever I want? Can I go where I want, and what does it cost me? Are the central social decisions and long-term agenda in any way reachable for me, and subject to my influence?

If we ask questions like these, we see that there are differences be-

tween the practice of the two main political systems of the democratic age, but a lot of similarities, too. The answers entirely depend more on the position someone holds in the social hierarchy than on the question of where he or she lives, East or West.

There is no reason why Liberal or Marxist tradition should not be able to imagine and strive for a radical concept of freedom and equality. They just don't do it, apart from some exceptions. Thoughts can be expressed in any theoretical language, if only with different ease. No theoretical language is doomed to stay prisoner of certain basic propositions and axioms. It is a choice. But it is a choice that was made by the dominant mainstream and is made again today. It is the choice to conceptually enclose freedom and equality, to declaw and de-fang them, to domesticate them to a concept for old bears.

The Marxist mainstream defines freedom solely from the relation of man to objective necessity; freedom is the expression of the degree of understanding and practical control of the external (and internal) nature. Engels' notorious notion in the *Anti-Dühring* that keeps being used affirmatively was: "Freedom of will is therefore nothing else but the capability to decide with expert knowledge. The more free a person's opinion is in relation to a certain question, the more necessarily the content of this opinion will be determined.... Thus freedom consists in the domination, based on recognition of natural necessities, of ourselves and of the external nature."¹⁶ Marx located in *Kapital* the "realm of necessity... only where work that is determined by need and external suitability has ended; it lies, by nature of the thing itself, outside the sphere of actual material production."¹⁷

It is one of the weak points of mainstream Marxism that it does not have a theory of conflict.¹⁸ It is not designed for conflicts and how to deal with them. Conflicts are objectively resolvable, always, and in future communism, they will just disappear. Therefore they can not be part of a politics of the social that relates to freedom and equality.

For the Liberal mainstream, too, freedom is not located in the field of social interaction. Here freedom means the maximal absence possible of state intervention. For all actual cooperations the Liberal concept of freedom aims precisely at the liberation from any limitations

that might result from social interaction and negotiation. Basically the leading notion is that of the French Declaration of Human and Citizen Rights from 1791: “Freedom consists in being able to do anything that does not harm any other.”¹⁹

People, however, have to put up pressure against others and sometimes hurt each other in order to change the way things go between them, to transform relations of domination, to free themselves. Freedom that does not bother anybody, that does not hurt any other, is a “freedom” that only mummifies the actual state of society, preserves things as they are — which is the contrary of freedom. The subtle difference between this and a radical concept of freedom and equality is the domestic servant principle, as it is described by Themba Sono in the passage cited above: that the others “deliver,” their work and nature namely, goes without saying. Any attempt to give conditions for this appears as a restriction of freedom then, because “the one more inventive and productive” (more usually, the “one more rich and privileged”) is somehow not given a free hand to the extent he or she would like. Thus the Liberal concept of freedom becomes a concept that sanctions, even demands, unfreedom.

The relation of both lines of tradition to equality is basically quite similar. To John Rawls, as a representative of modern, enlightened Liberalism, social inequality is justified anytime if it is economically useful — at least useful in that it may improve the position of the disadvantaged, too.²⁰ The whole idea of equality is thrown away for a vague bill of exchange on the future.

The same ideological mechanism we find in the Marxist tradition, where it defends the “achievement principle” and imagines real equality only in a distant future of communist abundance.²¹ Here the whole systemic difference dwindles to the point that today under democratic capitalism we tell young people who ask how they might become free and equal to “Get rich!”, while the classical answer under really-existing socialism used to be “Wait and see!”

How do we achieve a real concept of freedom and equality? One that is not locked up in a narrowly defined sphere of “acceptable political activity” or of “moderate income inequality within a greater

social group?”

There is only one reality we know, that of the social. From it we get all our standards; it makes up our lives. All human life is interaction, relation, cooperation. This is where freedom and equality take place. They do not happen later on, but here and now.

Every human activity is based on the collectivity and historicity of labor and nature. Whatever we do, we do it using the work and nature of others. If freedom should mean that we should do this as an uninhibited and unrestricted a way as possible, then freedom would only be possible at the price of the unfreedom of others. A freedom, however, whose boundaries would be “recognized” and set by some higher authority would be total unfreedom vis-a-vis this authority. In addition, both would be blind, monadic concepts of freedom that would assign no space and no value to the lively confrontation with others; I would be thrown back to myself, the boundaries of my view would be the boundaries of my world, which is nothing more than another form of imprisonment.

A radical concept of freedom, therefore, can only be one that deals with freedom in cooperation: I am free if I am free in my negotiation with others, i.e., uninhibited by any higher authority and not restricted by anybody through force. But this simply means that I am equal to others in cooperation: that my cooperation is not a forced one but that I can negotiate it with others at eye level and that there is nobody above me to whose rules and control I am subjugated. In a radical concept of freedom and of equality both coincide in one.²²

Free cooperation, as it is defined here, has three conditions. Cooperation is free when:

- the traditional distribution of disposal, possession, work and the traditional rules are not sacrosanct, do not have “higher authority,” but can be negotiated anew by the members of the cooperation at any time;

- all members are free to quit the cooperation, to give limits or conditions for their cooperative activity, and to influence the rules of the cooperation by that;

— all members are equal insofar as they can do this at a price that is similar and bearable; i.e., the price of leaving the cooperation, or to give limits or conditions for one's cooperative activity, has to be similarly high (or low) for all members but in any case reasonable.

To put it more simply: In free cooperation *anything* can be negotiated; *anybody* can negotiate; and anybody *can* negotiate because everybody can *afford* to call his or her stakes into question.

Freedom of negotiation includes the freedom to sink negotiations and to quit the cooperation — “to change trees,” as Rousseau puts it. The equality of the members includes being able to take a share of the fruits of their cooperation if one leaves, and put it to his or her own disposal. This share, too, is not measured mathematically but by a principle of equality: leaving or sinking the cooperation shouldn't be substantially worse for one group of members than for another.

This definition prescribes no formalized procedures of negotiation or decision-making. Such procedures are dealt with like any other rules: They have no higher authority, they are not beyond negotiation. Negotiation means the real process which everything comes down to again and again: “No, if not...”

Let's make clear the difference between such a concept of freedom and equality and the Liberal and Marxist mainstreams. The Liberal concept of freedom implies free disposal of others' work and nature. It defines liberal rights that consist mainly in the absence of restrictions; at the same time these liberal rights contain rights of ownership that are unimpeachable and can not be negotiated.

This is definitely not the freedom that is meant by free cooperation. According to free cooperation, the individuals are free to call any distribution into question, and they are free to give conditions for their cooperative activity, be it individually or collectively. There is no freedom of exception from this claim, and there is no protection against it either. On the other hand, anybody is free to deny the cooperation's conditions and “do his own thing” or “her own thing.” The individual is welcome to be “more inventive and productive” than others, as Sono calls it, but this does not imply any form of privileged access to the work and nature of others. It doesn't touch the others' freedom to negotiate the

rules and conditions of any cooperation.

The Marxist concept of freedom implies that the world is objectively cognizable, and it binds itself to the “optimized unfolding” of the general forces of productivity that are the final source of freedom for the individual, as for all. This concept of freedom, too, implies free disposal of others’ work and nature. It is not individual disposal in the traditional Liberal sense of “economic liberty,” it is collective disposal, the legitimate access of society to the work and nature of the individuals, in order to reach the aims of development.

This is definitely not the freedom that is meant by free cooperation. The right of individuals (and groups) to influence the rules, to give conditions for their work, or to sink cooperations they don’t like cannot be overruled at any time by scientific objectivity or alleged necessity of development. A mechanism of “we can’t negotiate now, but later on you’ll be free” is exactly the opposite of the idea of free cooperation.

While the notion of equality is weak and rather negatively connoted in the Liberal and Marxist traditions, within the concept of free cooperation it is of central importance.

The Liberal concept of equality is that of formal equality, i.e., the abstractly equal treatment of individuals notwithstanding their real social situation or, at best, a notion of “equal opportunities.” The equality lies in the possibility of being lucky — monopoly plus lottery, so to speak. An actual equality of the individuals regarding social power, disposal, property that has to be restored anew, again and again, is considered unfreedom, because the clever individual is not “free” to keep the alleged fruits of his/her work.

This objection is not shared by the concept of free cooperation. Free cooperation does not claim to make individuals (or groups) entirely “equal” according to any parameters or to adjust their relations in a “fair” way. For free cooperation, the criterion of equality is equal bargaining power. The rest is to be regulated by the individuals (or groups) themselves for their cooperation. If they put up pressure and fight for redistributions, it is an expression of their freedom and not a lack of freedom.

The Marxist concept of equality is even more negative. It regards equal-

ity to be a *petit bourgeois* idea of egalitarianism, a false claim of immediacy that does not accept the allegedly necessary way through proletarian revolution and socialist society. Actually “equal” people are, at best, in communist society where the general abundance makes questions of distribution and negotiation literally superfluous.

The concept of free cooperation, on the contrary, insists that individuals must be equal in their power to influence the rules, to quit the cooperation, or to give conditions to their cooperative activity, and this at any time. Free cooperation does not imply that the members of a cooperation are homogenous or identical. It implies, however, that the members face each other in a social position of equality. Cooperation is only free if it is equal; and the individuals can only be free in a cooperation where they are equal. Both notions signify the same fact.

In spite of this difference between free cooperation and today’s mainstream Liberalism and Marxism, the concept of free cooperation indeed shows some affinity to certain ideas in the beginnings of those traditions that were used to constitute a more radical concept of freedom and equality. There is an affinity to the Liberal vision that no one should be able to make prescriptions about your ideals and your pursuit of happiness (only that within the concept of free cooperation this is valid for all and not only for an elite of the economically “free”); that the individual needs to be protected against state access and social coercion (not only the white male property-owner, but everybody); that there are no transcendent foundations of state and society that could bind all; that people are, therefore, free to give themselves any social order they want, without any restriction. The theory of free cooperation only states what the preconditions of freedom and equality are, defending everybody’s right to take their stand for *their* freedom and equality and to defend themselves against forced cooperation, if necessary by violence.

Free cooperation agrees with the Liberal vision that people are free to regulate their relations entirely of their own; only that this is not done in the way of contracts that can be sued for but in the way of agreements that can be challenged any time.

Free cooperation has an affinity, too, to the Marxist conviction that

there is really only one single, inseparable freedom that goes beyond any codifiable liberal rights. The definition, however, of this basic inseparable freedom is different according to the theory of free cooperation. It is not the freedom to maximally unfold the historically possible grade of control over nature and of social rationality, but the freedom to choose one's social cooperation and design it oneself — the freedom not to live in forced cooperations.

Quite obviously there is an affinity to the Marxist view that there is nothing sacred about the distributions of property that were historically handed down and that are usually based on robbery by rules (often on open robbery, too). The theory of free cooperation denies, however, that this view should be abandoned at any point or under any social order because things are now allegedly all right and disposal and rules serve a good purpose.

Finally, there is an affinity to the Marxist perspective that individual and society are not self-sufficient units (as in Liberal perspective). Society is nothing else than the social practice of social individuals. Liberation is not about making blueprints, it is about changing this social practice.

Why is there no alternative to this concept of freedom and equality in cooperation, the concept of the coincidence of freedom and equality into free cooperation? Because the Big Five, the five big revisions in our consideration of emancipation that were demanded and exercised by the social movements during the last thirty years, leave us no other choice. These revisions concern the notion of power/state, progress/development, objectivity/homogeneity, democracy, and socialization/rational meeting of needs.

What was criticized and rejected was:

— The idea that one could rearrange society top-down after taking over central state power, thereby stripping all individuals and social cooperations of all powers (which is exactly what happened).

— The idea that there was a linear development through human history that would be inevitable and binding for all societies (according to this idea, everybody living a life different from that of a white-collar employee in Toronto or Stockholm is simply a backward being, that he

or she is “not yet ready”).

— The idea that one could “objectively” judge others: what they need, what they want, whether their cooperations are good or fair (which is to play off their alleged “objective interests” against their actual claims, and to adjust everybody to a fixed model, forcing people into social homogeneity).

The idea of democracy and democratization was subject to critical revision, too. If five people beat up the sixth one, things don’t improve because they voted on it (the results being 5:1 for beating). Democratization usually means that the social range of dominant strategies is enlarged, or deepened — in these cases, participation does not limit power but becomes its top-down transmission belt, down to the individuals, to everyday life, to concrete “micro-politics.”

Democracy, therefore, does not necessarily guarantee emancipation, and emancipation in the democratic age always implies protection against “democratization,” i.e., against other people’s claim to tamper with one’s life. Also subject to critical revision was the vision of socialization, social rationality and rational meeting of needs. A thorough socialization (of reproduction, for example) is neither possible nor desirable. Like socially planned meeting of needs, it would be a massive stripping of powers for the individuals (or for concrete cooperations). The critique goes far beyond the point that sole nationalization of the means of production doesn’t mean socialization yet. It challenges the very basic vision of a rationally planned society, cleaned of all particularist interest: a marvellously functioning social mega-machine.

No surrender, no “fairness”; no adjournments, no rectification of “development-caused” violence; no objectivity, no coerced homogeneity; no “democratic” subjugation and control; no prescribed liberation according to white-male examples: these are the criteria that a contemporary emancipatory utopia, a contemporary concept of freedom and equality, has to match. Sono’s quotation is, for all of these criteria, a perfect example of how *not* to do it.

3. FREE COOPERATION, OR, TO BE SOMEONE

And I got a feeling that I belonged, I got a feeling that I could be someone, be someone.

– Tracy Chapman, “Fast Car”²³

Freedom and equality are realized (and are consistent, even identical) in free cooperation. In a free cooperation, no traditional rights and rules are acknowledged (only as a preliminary starting point). In a free cooperation, the members are free to deny cooperation, i.e., to quit; they are free to give limits or conditions to their cooperative activity in order to influence the rules. In a free cooperation, as a precondition, all members are able to actually practice this means of influence (or of denial), and at a similar and bearable price. This precondition has to be restored and pushed through always anew; this is the content of left politics.

This definition is not a product of theoretical imagination. It follows the real practice of emancipation; it grows from the social practice and the discussions of social movements. The feminist movement, for example, profoundly changed the reality of mixed-gender partnership relations. It did not effect this by laying down a list of rules for partnership cooperation or by trying to describe how this cooperation should look — how it is “right.” It changed the reality of partnership by pushing through the necessary conditions for women to be able to leave these relationships, at a similar and bearable price, or to give limits to their cooperative activity. It was done by changing laws of divorce; by fighting for better social security; by making intramarriage violence a crime; by a complex practice to enable a “no, if not...” not only juridically and economically but also emotionally, psychologically and socially; by everything that encouraged and supported independent self-definition of women, collective self-socializing of women, autonomous organization of women.

“Feminist movement” means political organizations as well as collective social practice as well as the actual activity of individuals in their cooperations. It is clear that conditions haven’t changed so much that heterosexual partnerships really could be free cooperations today. And

of course changing heterosexual relationships was not the main interest of the feminist movement, not even a generally accepted claim inside the movement.

But change has happened. And this demonstrates the mechanism; it gives an idea of what, on the road from forced cooperation to free cooperation, might be called a step.

The list of examples is long. Left politics happens. Emancipation happens. The utopia of free cooperation exists.

What it is always about is the mechanism of not defining for others how their cooperations should look, how they would be “right,” but of creating the condition for others to freely negotiate their cooperations: the similar and bearable price. The most progressive shifts in the quality of working places and the decency of work do not come about in times where there are the most laws on it but in those times when workers have better bargaining power — when there is little unemployment, when unemployment social security is good, and when it is actually possible and personally bearable to quit one’s working cooperation if one dislikes it.

All the big emancipation movements of the last thirty to forty years — the feminist, the Black, the Third World movement— reached a point of discussion where the position that prescriptive politics is outdated at least grew stronger. That they cannot and must not define how you have to live if you follow them: how you have to be, what you have to look like, what kinds of cooperations you should prefer for your life, and what kinds of cooperations you must give up because they contradict certain basic principles of the respective movement.

What the individuals (or groups) want, what they need for their actual emancipation, what compromises they make: well, you may talk and argue about that, but you can’t prescribe it. What you can do, however, is to create in solidarity better conditions for people to become free and equal in their various cooperations.²⁴ To improve these conditions means, again and again, to change the price that it has if you leave or hold back.

It is the meaning of emancipation to free oneself from forced cooperations and to build free cooperations. Both are necessary. The abolition

of what was does not automatically guarantee something new. Fights for emancipation take place in a situation where the price is not similar. Fighting means to drive a hard bargain, to leave cooperations or limit your cooperative activity although the price you pay for this may be considerable higher than the price your opposite has to pay. Because you are more determined to change precisely this situation.

Left politics means to recognize and acknowledge other fights for emancipation and to mutually support one another, in order to strengthen the principle of free cooperation and to increase its power.

The opposite is possible, too. Strategies of domination may be developed out of a situation of free cooperation. Free cooperation is always a state of approximation, a dynamic process, not a stable equilibrium that could be preserved for all time. So there will always be fights for emancipation, and there will never be a point where left politics would no longer be necessary.

But what is a politics that is dedicated to free cooperation? What are its components, its elements? Is there a common pattern at all?

To describe this politics it is useful to take up the scheme that was used in the first chapter (of this Part One) to sketch the various dimensions of the means of domination. A schematic of a “politics of free cooperation” is more a means of illustration to visualize patterns of social practice than a logical deduction, but somehow things have to be structured — although there are always more connections and intertwining.

“Politics,” as a matter of principle, is understood here as an extended concept, including cultural forms as well as more traditionally “political” ones, the micropolitics of everyday life as well as activities within the spaces of a more traditionally “political” public.

The subjects of this politics may be individuals as well as social or cultural movements, groups and collectives; institutions or parties may actually be subjects of such a politics, too (albeit not in isolation).

In the first chapter we differentiated five dimensions of domination: direct violence (the military dimension); structural violence (the economic dimension); discrimination (the social dimension); control of the public (the institutional dimension); dependency (the existential dimen-

sion). A politics of free cooperation consists of five different politics. Each of them relates to all five dimensions of means of domination; at the same time the division into five single politics in a way corresponds to the five dimensions of domination.

If forced cooperation is maintained by various *means of domination*, it is necessary for a politics of free cooperation to *wind down* these instruments. “Winding down” means that you cannot use these instruments for “a better purpose” but that you have to reduce them; that this is a process and not a one-time action; that it is not possible and in many cases not even desirable to “switch them off” overnight, but the aim has to be clear.

This can only mean challenging the powers that be today: to make domination visible and to practically reject its means, everywhere, in all social spaces and in every cooperation. This in no way tells us, however, how cooperation *should* be shaped. Beyond the abstract definition given by the principle of free cooperation there has to be a concrete politics based on the learning experiences of certain emancipation movements and that makes alternatives to domination-structured cooperation practically conceivable. The most detailed considerations on this issue were achieved in Italian feminism where it was called *politics of relationship*.²⁵

Extended to all forms of cooperation, this boils down to what we can call *alternative socialization*.

The advantage of domination is that it is easy and that it works. A politics of free cooperation therefore has to *unfold social capacities*, it has to support individuals (and groups) in taking back the decisionary power over themselves. The eradication that domination has done in this field very often makes us unable to regulate our cooperation ourselves — which is true, too, for all social spaces and all social cooperations. Social experiences and abilities must be made available, individually and collectively: the collective intellectual heritage and social wealth must be reappropriated from capital in acts of *subjective appropriation*. Fordism, for example, tried to organize the whole society from the top down, preventing people from organizing their affairs and their lives themselves. Neoliberalism, quite differently, put a permanent pres-

sure on the individual to be highly motivated in some directions but to deliberately ignore any other options. So if people today are to be free, they really have to re-learn a lot of things, both that which everyone used to do, and the untested possibilities of subjectivity, globality, and the new technologies.

A politics of free cooperation has to practically address the ambivalence of democracy and democratization in the democratic age: that the real-existing forms of institutional democratic systems can serve the exercise and extension of domination, but that it would be no progress for freedom and equality to abolish these for pre-democratic forms. As there is no model of institutional democracy that would not be ambiguous in this way, the solution cannot be to suggest another concrete model that is allegedly free from these problems. There is no “domination-proof” form of institutionalized democracy.

A politics of *active critique of democracy* — or, to put it another way, a politics of *emancipatory democratization* — is therefore not bound to any institutionalized form of democracy. It is a sample of strategies that were developed in the practice of social movements and cross traditional concepts of democracy, like decentralization, affirmative action, etc.

Finally, a politics of free cooperation has to encompass a politics of *getting organized*. Getting organized means to strive for certain aims together with like-minded others and at the same time unfold an alternative practice. This is a very broad notion that is not necessarily bound to regular organizations but means also cultural movements, social organizing and processes of ideological rapprochement and practical cooperation between different emancipatory movements. You do not have to become a member anywhere to get organized (but you may), and there will be no umbrella organization and no monopoly party for a politics of free cooperation. Basically it is the same as with the ambiguity of democracy: getting organized can serve the exercise and extension of dominance, but there is no alternative to getting organized.

A politics of getting organized as part of a politics of free cooperation, therefore, does not propose any formal models of organizing, but provides practical strategies drawn from historical experiences of coun-

tering the tendencies for domination inherent to organizing.

Part Three will give a detailed description of a politics of free cooperation, with examples from different fields of practice and various spaces of social cooperation — from flat-sharing to the global cooperation of national societies. Each of the five “politics” will be described corresponding to the five dimensions of domination (what does “winding down” mean with regard to direct violence, to structural violence, to discrimination, etc.), giving the main practical answers to these, so what is sketched will be a programmatic conception with 5 x 5 main elements.

This is the inner architecture of a politics of free cooperation. It may be worth noting once more that this is a means of demonstration and handiness; the world is not necessarily grouped into five. In this weak sense of demonstration and handiness it may also be stated that each of the five “politics” as a whole is especially related to one of the five dimensions of domination.

In this perspective, winding down is the answer to direct violence; politics of relationship is the answer (and the alternative) to structural violence; unfolding social capacities is the answer to discrimination; active critique of democracy is the answer to control of the public; getting organized is the answer to dependency.

How is the question reconstructed now, at the end of Part One? To the question: “Under which model of social order are freedom and equality consistent?” the immediate answer is: under every model; it all depends on what is understood by freedom and equality. If we go on and ask: “What, then, should be understood by freedom and equality?” the answer is: We are free and equal in free cooperation. To the question: “Which social order (as an institutionalized system of rules or as a constitution) guarantees freedom and equality?” the immediate answer is: none. If we go on and ask: “How, then, shall we become free and equal?” the answer is: by a politics of free cooperation, that we may apply to every given social order, to transform this order — without model, open-ended.

This answer is described in more detail in Part Three. Before this, Part Two will clarify the methodological character of free cooperation,

discussing some objections that can be raised against it.

One objection, however, may be taken up here now: Isn't free cooperation a rather abstract promise? Nothing but conflicts again, no solid ground of a domination-proof order, no happy unity without oppositions and painful misunderstandings? No "...and you're done" formula?

This, of course, is a matter of taste. But free cooperation is what Tracy Chapman's lines are all about. In forced cooperation, we are nothing. In free cooperation, we can "be someone." Only there. Only this way. Nowhere else. And that's nothing abstract.

PART TWO

POLITICS AND ANTI-POLITICS

1. POLITICAL UTOPIA BEYOND UTOPIAS

You met me in a strange phase of my life.

— David Fincher, “Fight Club”

Vivien, a friend of mine, tells the story that her worst horror when visiting the family at home is watching the evening news together. Already as a young girl still living with her parents she tried to evade this, mostly without success. The evening news (on a traditional, big channel of course) was a main rite with her folks, a rite celebrating what to be interested in, what to have an opinion on, what the world is made of and what is important in it. First the interview with the Secretary of Finance, then the clash in Burundi, and just before the end the waste problems at the Love Parade. Nothing else. And in this order.

Political utopia will never be like the evening news again. It used to claim this, but that’s over. It won’t ever again work like this. And that should be fine with everyone.

Surveying the last century we can’t sue political utopia for everything that happened, but a primary skepticism against it is not only justified but imperative. The subjugation of the world — to concepts and visions, the rites of importance, of precedence and of the priesthood of those in the know — has consequences. Not only bloody, but also bloodless consequences. Not only the violence that tries to be rectified by the right plan for a better world, but also the social quiet of a world where one is a cog but doesn’t mean anything oneself, where others know everything and you don’t count — where you’re nobody.

This doesn’t mean we’re through with political utopia, but it has to be anti-utopia at the same time; not only politics but also anti-politics.

Instead of legitimizing dominant interventions and incapacitating individuals, its core has to be the rejection of dominant interventions and insisting on the right of one’s own decision. For this, political utopia is more necessary today than ever.

We are living in a world that is boldly passed off as the ultimate utopia, as the best of all possible worlds, if only with small clauses and “in the making.” Everything will turn out well, it is said, even better, if we only go on following like this.

Unscrupulousness finds favor with those free of any value judgement today, with the pragmatists who claim to be free of any ideology. But that anybody could be “free of ideology,” free of utopia, is just a fairy tale. We’re never free of ideology because our actions are always based on interpretations of the world, to some degree standardized to certain models, in which hierarchies of meaning and general claims of validity are raised.

We’re never free of utopia, also, because our actions are always based on future expectations, on visions of what should be. So “freedom from ideology” is an ideology itself, and “freedom from utopia” is utopian itself, even if it is not called that. Today the utopia of those “free of ideology” is a world where everything works, where they are allowed to do anything and where no one can imagine something else.

If we ask, “Is free cooperation something that affects people in an evening-news-like way?” then we have to break this objection down into its single components. What is the core of this aversion? A political utopia that is not of an evening-news type has to fulfill the following four criteria:

- it is not prescriptive
- it is not elitist
- it is not hierarchical
- it is not politically disguised escapism.

These criteria are met by the theory of free cooperation:

1. The theory of free cooperation does not set up any fixed models of how “the right society,” “the good life,” the “correct relationship,” the “healthy way of life,” etc., should look. It does not try to create a better world but to back the people. It categorically rejects any solution of the domestic servant problem that forbids people to work as domestic servants (or as a prostitute, as illegal migrant worker etc.).

The theory of free cooperation does not make any prescriptions. It acknowledges that individuals and groups may deny, reject, restrict co-

operations if they are not satisfied with them, without being hindered by any higher authority. It also acknowledges, however, that individuals and collectives may declare certain behaviors and regulations a condition of cooperation, but that they can not force or dictate them. The actual design of cooperations is up to their members. From outside you may have your opinion about it, and you may articulate this, but that's it.

The politics of free cooperation restricts itself to pushing through conditions under which the failure of the cooperation (its end, or its limitation) is a possible perspective for all members, at a similar and bearable price. It does not know what comes out of the negotiations that will take place under these conditions. It does not dictate anything to anybody. It only tells those who are not satisfied with their cooperations, "Don't let them walk all over you!"

2. The theory of free cooperation does not pretend to have privileged access to truth. It does not claim to know anything that would not be accessible for everybody from one's own experience. It does not introduce a licence for emancipation. There's no qualification or test needed to be allowed to negotiate. There's no fixed form of articulation or regulation that serves as an entry ticket. It just advises individuals and groups on the question: "How shall we become free and equal?" by handing them structured historical experience in a handy conception and system. It strictly advises not to give up the right to negotiate to any structures of formalized decision-making, to any higher authorities, to anybody who is supposed to think instead for you. It advises putting up pressure and actually restricting cooperative activity in the case of conflict, and principally suspicion against all discursive procedures that try to talk individuals and groups into what they really want or what they allegedly have implicitly accepted.²⁶

3. In the theory of free cooperation there are no privileged social spaces or kinds of cooperation that would be more important than others. It follows the concept of self-similarity where political utopia is focused on promoting and pushing through another logic of social relations, for any kind of social relationship.

Changing society is a complex process that has no priorities or sub-

ordinate issues (like: first you have to change the state, then the private relationships; first you change the relations of property, then the forms of organization, etc.). This is why Cosmo's plan to "free" society by electronically deleting all bank balances and documents of property doesn't work,²⁷ and why a situation where one group drops out of dominant control does not necessarily mean liberation if, for example, urban riots create no-go areas that for women are rape areas.²⁸

Free cooperation does not promote clash. It considers it rational if people are afraid of fast organizational social changes because they do not know what consequences this will have for the whole of their cooperations. It does consider it irrational, however, if people are not afraid of things just going on as they are.

Free cooperation principally supports resistance against planned "Big Changes" because "afterwards" everybody will be happy. The only resistance that it rejects, if necessary by violence, is denying somebody either negotiation or a fair leave.

4. The change in perspective (not to create the good society, but to push through the possibility of free and equal bargaining) implies a changed conception of radicalism. From the perspective of free cooperation, being radical means not to exempt any social space or any social cooperation from the claim for free cooperation; it means not to sell out this claim; it means determination to really push it through and not to be satisfied with symbolic gestures. This is to reject any concept of would-be radicalism based on the separation of "political subject" and everyday subject.

For this would-be radicalism, there are no steps in between, no compromises, no objections to what acting "most radically" imposes on the people. Taking as a basis that blowing everything up first in order to make it fundamentally right afterwards, though, has little suitability for everyday life.

This kind of false radicalism is always patriarchal and elitist because you have to be able to afford it. "Women are not in a position to ignore this necessity (that under any given circumstances, there has to be reproduction) if only because they feel more responsible for children, but also because most men are making politics under circumstances that

most women can neither live nor work under. The politics of ‘radical separation’ legitimizes the internal dominance of those who can ‘most radically’ let everything go, and these are at any rate men.”²⁹

David Fincher’s *Fight Club* ends with a scene that ironically caricatures escapist “radicalism.” The unnamed protagonist who finally realizes that Tylor Durden is a schizophrenic split-off of his own personality is standing with Marla in front of a huge windowpane. Although he is very seriously hurt by a shot that he fired at himself, he assures Marla that everything will turn out well now. At this moment the bombs he has planted while being Tylor Durden explode and the skyscrapers on the opposite side collapse. Marla is looking at him irritated and he answers apologetically: “You met me in a strange phase of my life.”³⁰

We pass, individually as well as collectively, a lot of strange phases in our lives where the quest for radical change desperately tries to split off from the concrete cooperations of our everyday life as if change could be faster or “more radical” that way. The striving for “radical action,” for absolute non-participation in the dominant system, the misleading idea that there must be a “short cut” in the laborious changing of social conditions, are part of these phases, as are the magical practices that deem “correct” language more important than the real tendencies of everyday cooperations.³¹

Not all of this can be reliably avoided; we have to be a little strange sometimes. But with regard to political utopia, free cooperation aims at ending this strange phase.³²

Is the objection invalidated that way? Of course not. It is only said that free cooperation is not necessarily evening-news-like. Designing and presenting free cooperation so that Vivien does not take it as a reincarnation of her traumatic-political primordial scene, requires concrete negotiation. There is no other way of becoming less strange.

2. THE METHODOLOGICAL CHARACTER OF FREE COOPERATION, OR, “HEY, THIS DOESN’T WORK OUT RIGHT!”

Bear: Tutter, only because Treelo does it another way than you, it doesn’t need to be wrong.

Tutter: Maybe it’s not wrong, Bear. But the problem with it is — the problem with it is, Bear: IT AIN’T RIGHT!!!

– Bear in the Big Blue House, “Magic in the Kitchen”

A group of further objections that might be made against the theory of free cooperation are that it be contradictory, apodictic or circular.

Contradictory means that parts of the concept generate contradicting conclusions. *Apodictic* means what in logic is called “tautological”: the argument is based on the very definitions that were made at the beginning, on axioms. *Circular* mean that the theory doesn’t really solve the basic problem that it deals with, but only shifts it to another level.

Regarding the theory of free cooperation, this objection might say that no one can decide objectively for others if a cooperation is good or just.

But what a similar and bearable price is for cancelling or restricting the cooperation has to be accessible by objective procedures, or it would be completely random.³³

These objections cannot be swept aside or refuted. The point is that there is no theory that they would not apply to. To consider these objections we first have to put on trial our very ideas of what a theory is and can be.

It is said in Mathematics that every theory contains at least one statement or assumption that itself cannot be proved by the theory. Postmodern critique gives similar considerations to the concepts we use to describe and structure the world.³⁴

Contradictions and tautological elements are normal for every theory. The more deductively we act, deriving our conclusions from the definitions we give at the beginning, the more apodictic and tautological our theoretical conception will be. The more practical we act, tak-

ing more and more elements of our theory from various forms of direct perception or practical experience, the more contradictory the theory will be. (Positively speaking, contradictions make a theory fit to cope with a complex reality and to foster productive conflict within this theory.) The idea that then we might abandon any theory does not work, however. Contradictions and tautologies do not apply only to explicit theoretical edifices but to every form of conceptualization; and without a “concept” we don’t even get out of bed in the morning, not to speak of a cup of coffee.³⁵

The demand for a new theoretical perception is the demand for a paradigm change. It is not based on the assertion that we “solved” the problems as we would solve a mathematical problem. It is based on the assertion that the new theory performs better in practice.

We do not derive our perception directly from reality; we rather design an edifice that leans against reality. Our ideas about reality, which is to say, our practice, are “a harmony paralleling nature” as Cezanne used to say about modern painting. Postmodern philosophy points out that this idea still contains a sound intellectual distinction between perception and reality that is untenable. We have no access to reality that is not mediated by ideas of reality, be it articulated opinions or conceptions that are expressed in our practice. Thought out this means that conceptions are everything we ever deal with, and the idea of a reality that lies around somewhere being “real” vanishes. Everything is “text” or, in more Marxist parlance, everything is social practice.³⁶

The philosophy of social science accordingly changed our idea of scientific progress, or rather, of the historical succession of our conceptions. What in mathematics is the unprovable assertion or assumption, the axiom, is here the paradigm: a basic idea that is a central, organizing factor in our perception and our practice, and that serves as a starting point for various arguments but is not argumentatively deducted itself. At some point we put the old paradigm aside and use a new one — because the old one has become too uncomfortable or too complicated, because we like the new one better, because we expect gains from it, or because some of us expect gains from it and are powerful enough to push it through. The new paradigm is not derived from

the old one, and the old paradigm is not really refuted; what's between them is a break.³⁷

You have to imagine this like eating with a knife and fork. We are used to it, it has certain advantages and disadvantages, it has certain social consequences and it doesn't affect everybody the same way — for children, it becomes a rite of initiation; for special food, using knife and fork in spite of a certain clumsiness becomes a form of social distinction; and so on. If our practice changes, eating with knife and fork may become more complicated or seem less practical — because we eat more wobbly mollusk, or sticky rice or seaweed; because metal runs short; because it comes into fashion to cut up the food right in the kitchen; because chopsticks become hip; because the Chinese or the Japanese become culturally and economically leading; because a mighty cooperation has bought a 20-year-monopoly of national chopstick production. That eating with knife and fork was becoming more and more complicated and inconvenient, however, only appears to us in retrospect, after we have completed the paradigmatic change and now eat with chopsticks. Before, we considered it sophistication and progress that we developed special wobbly-mollusk-knives or learned special cut-up-techniques or used reusable plastic knives. You can't say it couldn't be done any more.

But at some point, we stop it. This is where Tutter comes into play, the blue mouse from “Bear in the Big Blue House.” Tutter is arguing with Treelo (the lemur) on how the napkins have to be folded for the pancake dinner. Treelo just scatters them on the table, Tutter thinks that they should be folded and set on the plates, looking “like a swan on a lake.” The Bear tries to calm down Tutter and says that only because Treelo does it “completely different” it must not be wrong. To which Tutter replies that, well, maybe it isn't wrong. “But the problem with it is, Bear — it ain't right!” This is precisely how we struggle over our theoretical perceptions of reality and the practice-leading conceptions of our actions. None can really be proved right, proved that it has to be exactly like that, or that all other concepts are wrong. This doesn't prevent us, however, from choosing a conception because we think that the others just ain't right.

Tutter plays the “conservative” here, balking at a paradigmatic change in napkin-folding. In the end, however, the solution is found in a paradigmatic change after all: both together invent a “completely new way of folding napkins.” This is a good illustration of the fact that paradigmatic change is often based on new coalitions in practice. If we want to overcome the so-far juxta- or counterposition of different emancipation movements or social groups, we have to learn folding napkins in a new way.

Conceiving utopia as *paradigmatic change* clarifies that its call for a changed social practice and a respective politics does not depend on being more or less contradictory, apodictic or circular than the momentarily dominant theory. It leads us to think of utopia as a suggestion: a suggested *translation* between various, differing experiences and approaches to make them recognize one another at least as partially related and comparable; and a suggested conception that may serve as a rough consensus that a social *coalition* can be based on, or, speaking a bit less soberly, as the idea of a new historical promise that binds this coalition together. Based on this, it is possible to acknowledge that other possibilities may not be wrong, but they just ain’t right. There’s magic in the kitchen.³⁸

The theory of free cooperation is the call for a paradigmatic change; it calls for a new conceptual reconstruction of practical problems. It is a narrative, a “story” like all others; but it makes a difference which story you use.³⁹ Since it is conscious of this and does not plead that it has “the better representation of reality” but that it just supports one distinct “magic in the kitchen,” it is a postmodern utopia.

If we examine some of the objections given above against this background it looks like:

1. The theory of free cooperation is as apodictic/tautological as any other theory that uses a central definition. It does not claim, however, to be a freely invented thesis, but to work with a central definition of freedom and equality that comes closer to the discussions of recent emancipation movements, and is more suitable to systematize their problems and make them mutually recognizable and comparable than any other conception.

2. In the theory of free cooperation, contradictions appear between single elements of the five “politics” that are described in the outline of a politics of free cooperation.

There is, however, a point of reference, a main line. The definition of free cooperation is the core one has to return to in case of doubt, whereas the “politics” and their elements form a scheme of applied politics which, in that case, has to be judged against it and to be developed further. The basic idea of free cooperation is, so to speak, the battery of the whole theoretical conception (like the blues, as everybody knows, is the battery one has to return to every now and then to recharge).

3. Circular or paradoxical aspects are something all theories have to grapple with if they allow their critique of objectivism to be applied to themselves, too. (Theories that base political legitimization on the grace of God, for example, are exempt from this, because they are not self-referential but totally transcendental.) The objection that the theory of free cooperation is circular stems from a general overrating and absolute-making of what a theory is and can do. As soon as we accept that theories do not exist outside of human beings, that there is no elevated tower with an automatically right view of the world, that a theory can not itself contain its interpretation and application, etc., our heads start to swim. This is typical postmodern swimming. In the postmodern age, all theories have to be swimmers. What matters is if they cut a relatively fine figure at it.⁴⁰

The theory of free cooperation is, by nature, political advice. It recommends itself to people asking how they could become free and equal, first, as a tool to analyze their cooperation — a tool to be used, not a machine that you feed data into on top and which throws out a ticker tape at the bottom. It recommends itself to these people, secondly, as a concept they might use to try and make themselves understood by others or to unite with them. It recommends itself, thirdly, to those wanting to design their mutual cooperation as a free and equal one as a guideline, as a compression of experiences made with experiments in “free cooperation.” It recommends itself, fourthly, to people and groups under the impression that their cooperations are forced as a structured model for the quest for transformation. And it recommends itself, fifth-

ly, as a method to remember certain basic principles in conflicts with people viewing things differently and wanting different things.

If we ask now: Who, then, does decide what is a similar and bearable price for all members if some are leaving the cooperation or restricting their cooperative activities?

Then the answer is: The people themselves, and they may be wrong. No one can relieve them of this decision. There is no authority that could, with binding force and certainty, supercede them in this decision. There is no monopoly, neither of the theory nor of the concrete conclusions from it. Judging if a cooperation is forced or free is, however, *less arbitrary* than judging if distribution and rules are “just,” or if they appeal to the one judging. The theory of free cooperation is actually circular, as circular as every other postmodern utopia. It shifts the problem to another level, *because it has the opinion that it might be practically dealt with better on this level than on the original one*. Don’t buy any theory that claims to be able to do more than this.

Is it possible, then, to use the theory of free cooperation to veil and legitimize strategies of domination? Definitely. There is no theory, no conceptualization that would be safe from it. Is it that it doesn’t matter, then, which theory we use, which paradigm is pushed through? Definitely not. The theory of free cooperation makes it less easy for people, groups and authorities who want to claim a “solution sovereignty” for themselves. It provides weapons and tools that can be used more effectively against such misuse than other theories. Nothing more. But nothing less.

3. UTOPIA AND VALIDITY

And from the nature of the contract one could see that it could not be irrevocable: Because if there would be no higher force that could vouch for the loyalty of those making a contract or that could coerce them to fulfill their mutual obligations, the parties alone would be judges in their own matter, and each party at every time had the right to cancel the contract as soon as it discovers that the other is infringing the conditions, or as soon as it comes to dislike them.

— Jean-Jacques Rousseau,
*Treatise on the Origins and the Foundations
of Inequality Among Men*

The revolutionary women's law of the EZLN (the Zapatista Liberation Army) from 3/8/1993, almost a year before the armed revolt in Chiapas, emerged from the women's meetings in various villages in the rebellious area. The women declared their participation in the revolt to be dependent on the condition that their social position would change — not only as a demand “for later,” but now, at this very moment, within their own community and within the revolutionary movement itself.

They used the formula “No, if not....” They couldn't force anybody. The men of the EZLN could have tried the revolt without explicit cooperation of the women. They could have let it be, too. Or delay it. But they themselves couldn't force the women.

They couldn't ignore them, either. They knew the revolt would have little chance without the women's cooperation. And based on the disputes and the changes of the recent years, they had a vague idea that the women's claims might not be comfortable but part of a potential common cause. Finally, an agreement was reached. “Okay, then...”⁴¹

This is how social process works between free and equals. In free negotiation, based on a comparatively high, but payable price of failure; without a judging third party, no other authority involved than the ones concerned; no other lever available than that of cooperation or non-cooperation, which would hit all those concerned similarly hard. That's

it. There's nothing more.

That people treat each other as free and equals does not depend on having reached a certain "stage" in history. It does not depend on being in a completely domination-free environment, that there are no "forces of circumstance" or that we as humans had to be free from our respective history and the special characteristics resulting from it. You can do it, i.e., you can do it together in cooperation. You can do without forcing cooperation and cooperative activity; you can change the mutual situation in a way that such coercion is actually less possible because means of enforcement get mutually blocked and dissolved; you can expose yourself to the situation of no rules, only the fact of cooperate or not.

This alone doesn't make people happy. It does not guarantee good decisions, either. It is not a harmonious process. You actually can call it a violent process, at times, because the ones concerned insist in changing each other. They do not stand, however, with their back to a wall that prevents them from leaving or withdrawing. There are only the bonds of cooperation — bonds they may create, maintain, stretch or tear apart.

Free cooperation means to apply this social logic to all kinds and spheres of cooperation and to change whatever blocks it. It is real-time utopia. It expands and becomes more and more radical — in the sense of getting broader, more comprehensive, more thorough. We don't need a utopian society to get started with it. In a way it doesn't matter where we start. What matters is how far we take it.

It is a utopia with many roots. In all recent emancipation movements there are forms of practice and considerations to be found that work towards it. Or, more precisely, that work towards something that is similar and comparable to that point — the utopia of free cooperation. Or, even more precisely, that work towards something that can, in the light of utopias of free cooperation, be deemed comparable to them and that they can acknowledge as similar. The politics of recognition and of negotiation, as they were articulated in Italian feminism, tend in this direction, as do the ideas and practice of the Zapatistas in Chiapas. And a lot of others, too. Our "closer" relations — flat-shares and partner-

ships; self-organized projects in economic, political or cultural fields; work cooperations; family structures and “elective affinities” — are of main importance as experimental situations for social cooperation and its logic. They are, however, not privileged spaces for the development of free cooperation. It is possible that transformations in society as a whole and the movements connected to that change play an avantgarde role, that the “more remote” relations inspire the “closer” ones in their search for a new logic of social cooperation.⁴²

There are notorious objections to the project to design the general logic of society after such a logic of the social. Free cooperation is a nice idea, it is said, but not feasible, especially not for larger social units and complex societies.⁴³

It is true: the theory of free cooperation denies that there are such things as “complex societies” — if that implies that there are, on the opposite, small-scale forms of social cooperation that are “simple” somehow. According to the self-similarity of social relations, there are no “simple” cooperations. An idea like that can only occur to economists — or to anyone who thinks that modern state and international intertwinings are so incredibly complex, and who never happen to drop in on a kitchen. Otherwise they would know how complex things are in the kitchen. Since there are no “simple” forms of social cooperation, however, there is no reason why we should not transfer the experience we get from experimenting with free cooperation in smaller cooperation to bigger and eventually all cooperations.

Within the social, nothing is simple at all. Each social cooperation, every situation in it and every action, are infinitely complex. Apart from being the contrary of forced cooperation and of domination and the only way “to be someone,” free cooperation is a means of dealing with this complexity of the social. Its logic corresponds exactly with the way we get along with complex systems. They cannot be controlled in detail; we influence them, observe how they change, and influence them anew. To a certain degree, we treat them as a black box: even when we understand the mechanisms we cannot predict the outcome; we try to influence them purposefully, and often it works, but we have no guarantee that a certain input will cause the expected result.

Free cooperation starts from the fact that we ourselves and our relationships are no less complex.⁴⁴ Opinion research is able to predict months ahead which party we'll choose at the elections. But if we are going to abruptly end a relationship, drop out of a group or join a party it is often unpredictable even for our closest friends. Since social cooperations are complex systems we cannot steer them at will. And it doesn't make a difference if it is the relationship to our children or a new regulation of economic distribution and disposal in society. We're fishing in troubled waters. Not that everything would be completely at random and beyond control; but we don't have certainty about the effects this or that change will have on the whole of the cooperation. This is why social contracts cannot be ultimately binding, but have to be dissolvable. This is why an utopian society that we had a splendid vision of may be absolute crap in practice. This is why personal ads ("Lion, likes walking, wants to meet female Capricorn who shares his hobbies") are always a bit kinky, because relationships don't work like that.

Since social cooperations are complex systems — and this is exactly what we express if we call them "a practice" — our analysis, our articulation and our attempts at influencing them stay necessarily superficial. This "weak relation" between practice and formalization is one of the reasons why generalized claims of validity — be it by procedure or by analysis — are extremely problematic. Neither Habermas' "ideal speech situation" nor Rawls' fictional reconstruction of what we objectively have to want can relieve us of the decision if we accept or reject a cooperation in its actual reality.

Free cooperation draws certain consequences from the complexity of social systems and the dubiousness of validity claims. It doesn't start from a utopian point of departure but takes the actual situation as a starting point, just like it is. It doesn't speculate on if we should start with a democratic-capitalist model or rather with a really-existing socialist one or if the first thing to do would be to introduce one of them.

It starts with the concrete initial situation, asking: Which forced cooperations do we have here? By which means of domination is free cooperation prevented? What are the steps to put them out of action or to

put an end to them? The theory of free cooperation does not overrate the single instrument of change but thinks in criteria as they are reflected in the five “politics”: What does “winding down” mean here? How can a “politics of relationship” be brought to bear here? It gives leeway for controversy on the efficiency of this or that instrument and for dispute on the feasible rate of change. Only the direction is clear, the logic that is to be pushed through and unfolded.

The envisioned social order that enables freedom and equality is one where the elements of the five “politics,” as they are described in Part Three, are constantly processed. Change is operated through real people, cooperations and movements that refer to the three conditions of free cooperation, supported and protected by a growing general movement whose members at least collectively relate on the principle of free cooperation.

Free cooperation, therefore, is implementable. It doesn’t need a clean slate of a society. It can start from an actual, highly differentiated society with given institutions, traditional structures of organized political power, and systems of regulation that are currently running. It cannot evade the necessary tension between utopia and concrete politics, between the various forms of “expertise” trying to prove why it can’t be done any other way, and the demand for change expressed by a generalized movement that, from a somewhat abstract distance, is convinced that things can be changed easily. Here, again, there’s no principal difference if we’re arguing about parliamentary realpolitik and general economic frameworks or if we’re disputing if one “has to” leave a concrete relationship, which “force of circumstance” a self-organized project has or does not have to take into account, etc. The tension is not the problem; we have a problem when it collapses. This may happen due to various reasons. What a utopian method can contribute to maintaining this tension is a thinking and negotiating based on criteria, rather than on efficiency and readymade solutions.

Before we now enter the description of these criteria, the elements of the five “politics,” a last objection may be noted. It’s the objection that all this is far too complicated and therefore elitist in the end. Well, the outline of free cooperation given here is not substantially longer or

more complicated than the user instruction for my cell phone, not to mention the Windows ME manual. Today no one will try to say that cell phones are elitist. You can use them without having read any user instruction, too.

The nature of this outline of free cooperation, however, is more that of a grammar, the grammar of an emergent contemporary language of liberation. There are good grammars and bad grammars. You don't necessarily need a grammar to speak a language. On the other hand, we should have left behind the time where certain theoretical or practical approaches and traditions bluntly call themselves the native speakers of emancipation — and that the claims of all others should, please, just be translated into that language.

PART THREE

DOING FREE COOPERATION — AN OUTLINE OF ITS POLITICS

One rule: no rules!

— Janet Jackson, “FreeXone”

Words ain’t cheap; usually they were fought for. They are expressions of historical processes of finding and self-assurance, so we can’t change them at will.

Since we have a part in many different stories, we use different conceptualizations. The conceptualizations used here are not what really matter. Some might call what is described here as “an outline of the politics of free cooperation” post-modern socialism; they’re welcome to do so.⁴⁵ Others might not want to give the concept assembled here an explicit high-pitched name at all, seeing it just as a stopgap to communicate the more far-reaching utopias of their own movement (e.g., feminist) with other movements, in order to form a complementary common practice. Or, as an ambiguous tool to be tested with certain problems of one’s own movement. The politics of free cooperation may be read as an answer to the question “What is anti-capitalist politics today?” or “What is radical reformism?” You may read them, too, as an answer to the question “Is there a collective story?”⁴⁶ That is, how can we, although criticizing objectivism and respecting the autonomy of different movements, articulate more generalized concepts, at least as the negotiated working basis of a generalized emancipation movement? Accordingly, most of the five “politics” described are given dual names; it may make things easier.

1. WINDING DOWN MEANS OF DOMINATION: CHALLENGING THE POWERS THAT BE

You know as well as we do that the law prevails in human interaction only where there is an equilibrium of powers, whereas the more powerful push through whatever they have the power to, and the weak submit.

— Thucydides, *The Peloponnesian War* (V 89)

It is a precondition of free cooperation that cooperation and cooperative activity are not forced. For this, it's okay if the respective means of domination are banned and not used; it is better if there are actual hurdles and dams that prevent them from being used; it is best if the potential of violence itself that support these means is brought down. The politics of winding down the means of domination conceives this as a step-by-step process that is never really finished. On one hand, the list of possible instruments is never exhaustive, and domination is quite creative in diversifying old instruments and inventing new ones. On the other hand, a sudden abolition "in one piece" is usually neither possible, nor even desirable. What matters is the process, and the criterion for what is "ahead" and what's not. The criterion is not if superior force is used for "something good," but if the ability to force cooperation and cooperative activity is effectively diminished. To name and take down the means of domination that are active in reality is to challenge the powers that be in a concrete cooperation: Who is in power, what is it based on, how can it be practically contained and overcome. Given the many relations of oppression and the fact that almost everybody stands in some way on both sides, is dominant and dominated, this challenge has to be conceived as a plural.

Preventing Intervention

Regarding direct physical (or psychological) violence, what matters is preventing a more powerful actor's violent intervention against a comparatively powerless one.

This sounds simple, but it is an idea that does not prevail today in

any sense. After the fall of the Soviet power bloc, NATO regularly engages in “good” and “just” wars of intervention (based on whatever juridical construct) and is acclaimed for it even by parts of the classical left. But there’s nothing but No that can be said to this.

Preventing and disabling intervention is not pacifism. There are possibilities for an actually defensive structure of defense (this is not talking about SDI, obviously) that is incapable of waging wars of aggression, least of all thousands of miles away.

Structural inability for aggression (“defensive defense”) is a term that may be transferred to non-military fields, too.⁴⁷ Armed anti-colonial liberation wars, too, are not interventions to be principally prevented in this sense; after all, the Vietnamese didn’t invade the US.

There are various forms of violent, one-sided superior interventions (and they often pass more smoothly by appealing to democratic processes of decision-making). Take the criminalization of “illegal” immigrants and the extreme rearmament of the borders. Take male violence against women and racist violence, designed to force cooperative activity and to dictate its price. It’s an absurdity that you may be dragged by policemen, forcefully, to school if you don’t go there voluntarily. It’s an absurdity that you may be interned, forcefully, and subjugated to psychiatric treatment only if your closer environment deems your behavior “crazy.” Regarding all this, what is needed is a politics that prevents and structurally disables violent intervention — this is the criterion, not the alleged “good purpose.” In most cases the methods of acting against it are well-known, as are many possibilities of alternative regulations that better fulfill the criterion of structural inability of intervention.

Direct, violent intervention is often defended with the argument that immediate danger for those concerned has to be averted, or that conditions don’t allow them to speak for themselves at the moment. This has to be interpreted quite narrowly.

Methodologically, this anticipates expected later approval, and we take the risk of not getting this approval. If we physically prevent someone from jumping in front of a train we hope that we get this later approval in near future; but we may be wrong. Regarding revolutionary uprisings against authoritarian or fascist regimes it has become a stand-

ard today, rightly, that the approval that cannot be clarified during the uprising is made up for within two years at the latest — by elections, but above all by the abolition of any repressive special laws. However, you can't take this argument much further. It must never be used to render people unable to negotiate and articulate and then deliver them to the decisions of others. All humans can negotiate and articulate; it only differs a lot what that means. There are ways of collective articulation and representation that we have to take seriously, more seriously than our own discretion.⁴⁸ We can not evade the risk of interpretation by incapacitation.

If the issue is direct force, the question arises: Can we, do we want to live without police and jails? There's no way for the theory to give the answer. Clear is the framework of interpretation: failed cooperation. That is, we refuse to live in social cooperation with a murderer, and as there is no similar and bearable alternative to society as a whole we have to cope with this situation and split up as much as it is possible. The person concerned can refer to his or her share of the society's historical collective wealth; it is not a question of being nice that we care for the conditions of separation being as good as possible. The framework of interpretation is not punishment or retaliation, also not resocialization or education. This is not for us to do.

We may make offers on how we could imagine cooperation again, under what conditions, or we may look for concrete cooperations that might admit the one concerned under certain conditions. We are urged to make such offers because there is no similar and bearable alternative to society as a whole.⁴⁹ And it is clear that in the case of shoplifting it can't be more than the cooperation with one actual supermarket that has failed (at least from the supermarket's perspective).

The crime example shows also: Where the price is not equivalent, even without an alternative, the limitation of cooperative activity may, as simple blackmail, be described as direct violence. That's why society as a whole may not give conditions for its basic social benefits and services. That's why conditionalizing development politics as a "human rights politics" of the powerful countries is a quite dubious tool. That's why in a competitive society giving grades is a crime. That's why we

can't simply give even the most horrible tenant his or her notice if there are no other flats available.

What matters is not the surface or the symbolic but what really happens. There's no problem with boxing matches if they are freely negotiated. And the camera theft on holiday, even if done with threat of violence, may just be a spontaneous levy of a special "poor area" tax, and from the perspective of free cooperation, harmless.

Dismantling Disposability

As was explained in Part One, structural violence (the second dimension of the means of domination) consists of adjusting the rules of cooperation in such a way that there is a systematic accumulation of unequal social power. Capitalist surplus value is a classical example of this, but there are many others. Not all are measurable in the same way.

There are two typical failures that can be made in this dimension. One is to ask how cooperations may be most efficient, instead of how we may be most free and equal in the cooperation. The other is to try to make it just for all from an external perspective.

Instead we should limit ourselves to the approach of free cooperation: What is needed that the people concerned can freely negotiate the rest among themselves? How can they avoid being disposable objects?⁵⁰

From the perspective of free cooperation a company is basically a cooperation. In the case of a self-organized economic project this is relatively clear to us, but there is no difference in the case of a big company or state enterprise.⁵¹

What does it mean to adjust a company to the logic of free cooperation? The rules can be changed by the members; the members are free to leave or to limit their cooperative activity, thereby influencing the rule. Their position in it is equal because the price they have to accept for a restriction of their cooperation is similar and bearable. What does this look like? Someone sets up a company, together with others; rules are negotiated concerning division of work, decision-making, sharing of profits, working contracts and, possibly, aim and purpose of the whole thing. The company may grow and hire additional employees. Socie-

ty does not interfere with these rules; social control limits itself to demanding the rules of a fair divorce for the withdrawal of members — and to *not* protecting the existing rules inside the company.

It works like this: In the case of a member leaving there is no speculation on who's to blame (principle of matrimonial breakdown); there is no penalty for quitting instead of being fired, i.e., by freezing social security benefits.⁵² The company, as every economic cooperation, is considered a community of accrued gain. Who leaves can take out his or her share (total net to capital minus initial contributions divided by members) and take it with him or her. He or she may also lend it to the company, if it has external shareholders. If the company didn't have a growth of capital there's nothing to take, of course.

That society does *not* protect the specific, existing rules of the company becomes important if the members summon a company assembly and declare that they want to change the rules: the division of labor, the decision-making, the sharing of profits, the working contracts and, possibly, the aim and purpose of the whole enterprise. In this case the members either reach an agreement or they don't. If they don't agree there are several options: No one wants to continue the project; some want to continue the project and some don't; several groups want to continue the project but not together. In the first case the firm ends, the remaining total net to capital is divided among the members as in the case of individuals withdrawing. In the second case those wanting to continue the firm do it and the others leave and take their share. In the third case the firm divides, like an amoeba, into parts proportional to the size of the different groups.

This approach protects the property of those who set up a company (or join in). It does not protect, however, their specific position. If they don't like the development they can leave, take their share (contribution plus possible shares of accrued gain) and start something new again.

Would all companies become employee-ruled under these conditions? Probably not. Various models would exist. The "capitalists" of the company may, by the possibility of leaving, influence the rules as well. If they are provided with abilities and expertise that are other-

wise not so well represented in the cooperation, it would make some impression.

There is some indication that very large and long-existing companies would, with increased probability, transform into more or less employee-ruled models. But this is not necessarily the result; a specific culture of work, industrial sector, market situation, etc., may make a difference. No one has to change the rules. But all may.

Treating companies in this way, as free cooperations, has the additional precondition that there exist social security systems which guarantee at least a qualitatively sufficient minimum for everybody, with appropriate consideration of one's personal situation and the general social standard of living. In full consequence this may result in a unification of the different social security systems into one single basic income system that provides completely independent benefits, so to speak, a per capita distribution of a basic share of social value added and social wealth. In that case, wages are comparatively low, and instead of several systems of insurance and non-wage labor costs there would be a single duty or tax, based on capital and not on employment. Intermediate stages would be possible and surely necessary.

Within such a structure people would cooperate freely and equally *in working*. It is not limited, as a common objection claims, to highly-developed industrial countries. Where monetary systems are unstable and insecure, or where only a small portion of added social value goes through state and company budgets, basic income consists in access to land, and will eventually have a collective character (the attribution of land to families and groups) rather than an individualized character.⁵³

What follows from this approach to the field of capital markets? A cooperation as a whole cannot be bought. You can lend it money, and you may expect a share of potential profits from it. But what you do not achieve is control of the cooperation, no matter if the money comes from the state or from the private sector. This is the point. Only in this way can labor avoid being seen as something disposable, that it turns from being an active cooperation into being slave work. You may also invest money in foreign countries. A politics of dismantling disposability does not rule that out. Developing countries may let global capital

in, but can require that in such a case the structure is interpreted and treated as free cooperation (which is exactly the opposite of what the MAI was designed for).⁵⁴ As pure foreign investment of capital, it includes a share of profits but not control. As a foreign branch firm, it is a cooperation where home employees have the same status — you may leave, but you can't take the firm with you when leaving. A structure like that does not cancel the dilemma of attracting capital without becoming completely dependent, but it makes this dilemma something the countries concerned can deal with, and corresponds to the course that many countries of the South try to push through here.

Although such forms of companies as cooperations are diametrically opposed to the logic of stock corporations and shareholder value, they are nevertheless juridically easily possible. You can encourage them. You can run them. You can reform the existing structures of work in a way that takes the dismantling of disposability as a criterion. This is true for all actors: workers, unions, social movements, state, consumers, communities. It is also true for the entrepreneurs of the “new economy” that are so proud of their *soft skills* and cooperative style and may read here what it would mean to really take these claims seriously.

A politics that, in dismantling disposability, takes the existing structures as a starting point and transforms them in the spirit of free cooperation does not imply that existing relations of property and control have to be taken as sacrosanct. Not even “really-existing” capitalism would do that, only that it systematically nationalizes *small* property (through taxation, inflation, cutting of claims) while systematically subsidizing large property (through tax exemption, subvention, “state debt,” payment of genuine production costs etc.). A politics that re-distributes property and disposal or transforms them into other forms of ownership, even to the point of formal nationalization, diversion, socialization etc., is principally legitimate, because of the collective and historical character of all work.

Only this doesn't solve the problem of freedom and equality yet. The politics of winding down transforms the *character* of capital and property. As described, its aim is to dismantle their character as means of domination, wherever this property may be allocated.

Considering the economic creativity of *real-life economics* or *economy from below* we have to judge, too, if it is a new logic of work as cooperation that emerges, or just structures of self-organized disposability. The criteria are the same: dismantling disposability in labor; confronting all structures where some “deliver” and others decide; interpreting economic entities of all kinds principally as cooperations and adjusting them according to the vision of free cooperation. If there is anything we may imagine as “economic liberty,” it is that.

De-Privileging Formal Work

Discrimination is the excluding solidarity of privileged subjects against “the rest” in order to maintain their privileges and to make “the others” disposable to them. Today, discrimination is getting de-formalized; we’ve become quite modern and flexible with it. Open, juridically codified apartheid is replaced by the privileges ascribed to a distinct model of “work” and “workers” that is called “formal work” here (and its subjects “formal workers”) and which merges qualified, privileged paid labor and entrepreneurial work. Formal work is done at “workplaces,” it is based on official, juridically guaranteed contracts, is comparatively well-paid and to a great degree includes “entrepreneurial” aspects of work, i.e., it commands and disposes of other work and demands/allows more subjectivity (motivation, engagement, creativity) of the worker in his or her work. It is work that is neither precarious nor illegal, neither monotonous nor low-paid, not contributing to a fragmentary career, and whose subjects are largely able to ward off the “impositions” of life and all other forms of work.

As this list indicates, formal work is the experience of a sociological minority. It is, at the same time, the main instrument of modern discrimination, because this minority enjoys far-reaching privileges and massively dominates the symbolic order of society, i.e., its self-perception and self-interpretation. Formal workers think of themselves as feeding all the others and doing the really productive work that all others live from. Although this self-perception — creating with one’s own hands what all others live from — is really cute if we compare it to the actual activity of teachers, lawyers, dentists, tax advisers, politicians, board mem-

bers and commercial artists, it is unbroken and socially dominant. It dubs all other work parasitic. Only he or she who is a formal worker enjoys full freedom of movement, a realistic expectation of pension, can write off his or her expenses against taxes and is largely safe from police raids and investigation. He or she can sue for payment and conditions of work and change his or her place of work reasonably freely. They have paid vacation, fixed limits of their working day and well-functioning pressure groups. They don't have to "ask for permission if they want to pee."⁵⁵

The privileges of formal work secure the disposal of all other work (and all other workers) which is named "informal work," "reproductive work," "social capital," "plain work," or "unskilled work," or is not seen at all because it is pushed to the edge of social perception as illegal work or as low-wage work in foreign countries.

A politics of free cooperation has to de-privilege formal work. Within the framework of today's nation society, an independent basic income again is a central tool to meet this criterion. De-privileging formal work, however, goes far beyond that, deep into the ideological machines, and may mean different things for different cooperations.

More generally, you may say that in every cooperation the formal work is the work that is deemed the "real" work, fulfills distinct formal criteria and enjoys certain privileges, while it renders other work invisible and subjugates it. In a hospital, for example, the formal work is that which is done by doctors. This is the work that seemingly "matters" and which everything revolves around (quite literally, such as the schedules of the other personnel), while in reality it makes up only for a small part of the work that has to be done in a hospital.

Appropriation of Spaces and Connectivity

In forced cooperation, spaces and connectivity are assigned to individuals and groups according to how well they serve the prescribed aims of the cooperation, to the benefit of those who play along. That's how the aims reproduce themselves automatically. In democratic capitalism, assignation is made according to affirmative participation in the process of realization of capital.

Think of spaces within forced cooperations. Usually you'll find splendid conference rooms but no reasonable youth centres; you have masses of communal spaces for men but hardly any for women; the whole disposability and accessibility of space is structured and stratified by every relation of power and oppression, by class, sex, age, color, income, etc. To re-distribute spaces, to appropriate them autonomously "from below," is a substantial criterion of a politics of free cooperation — not because of any "just" distribution but to counter the creation, designing and control of public space as a means of domination.

Connectivity is no less important than space. This somewhat clumsy term is meant to describe all the possibilities for communicating with others, staying in touch, keeping informed and qualified, and individually using social potentials in the widest sense. Today, many of these possibilities are part of a formal work place. That's why the loss of a formal work place is also experienced as social exclusion. This is not a matter of the thing itself: it is an intentional effect of the conditional assigning of spaces and connectivity, and increases the pressure for one to work this way again. Accordingly, structures of assignment of spaces and connectivity can be seen as a means of domination in every cooperation.

You'll find the same patterns in the spatial structure of our downtowns, in the working groups and "platforms" of a party, in the global structure of science and culture, in which people take which space at the family dinner and what they discuss. These are not just expressions of relations of domination but instruments of defending, establishing, and expanding these relations as well, and therefore a target for a politics of winding down. In all these cooperations you can start to appropriate spaces and to establish and self-organize your own connectivity; at the same time, you'll have to put the existing monopolies under pressure, to undermine and to break them.

All this is common practice in social movements and alternative projects. In practice, however, the deciding criterion often becomes blurred: to recruit spaces and connectivity for one's own purposes and to one's own rules, and not as a form of *outsourcing* that in the end supports the existing monopoly structures and their instructions.

Immediate Strategies of Survival

To reduce existential dependencies is another criterion of a politics of winding down means of domination — or, put in a positive way: to establish immediate strategies of survival that counter these existential dependencies. This includes “material” and “immaterial” aspects, and can be found in every field of social cooperation.

An example of such a politics is that of *short circuits* as described by Richard Douthwaite.⁵⁶ The integration in global structures of economic exchange and economic division of work is, according to Douthwaite, only reasonable if for each aspect there is at least one local or regional alternative, a second structure, as an emergency system and as a guarantor of a certain independence. This is about food security, local availability of technological knowledge, regional exchange systems that can function independently of the national or global system of trade and financial exchange. But forms of community building and consciousness raising, and the empowerment of direct, complex structures in “social neighborhoods” also meet this criterion. The existential dependency — on external interpretation and esteem, on connectivity and integration through others — is broken by it, and one’s own blackmailability is decreased. Immediate strategies of survival are compromised by externally imposed austerity measures which endanger this survival in order to “increase it later.” The majority of classical “development projects” can be subsumed under this philosophy of “delay,” and on the individual level as “I’ll have time for living as soon as I’m on pension.”

According to this criterion, all big technological projects are to be rejected when: their effects can definitely not be recalled (nuclear energy); they result in the subjugation of existing survival structures to centralized technological dependencies (genetically engineered agriculture); or they try to “improve” the environment by the invention of high-tech “cures” (most projects of genetic engineering in medicine and of centralized global planning in nature conservation).

The criterion of immediate strategies of survival is, again and again: Are we still able to say No? Will we be able to in the future? It requires, in case of doubt, immediate, more direct strategies instead of complicated promises to be made good sometime in the future. It rejects, too,

every attempt to make one's own suffering a politics, to fully demonstrate one's own dependency in the hope that someone might react. That "the state is to blame for it" is no reason not to repair the school roof; that "someone should care for me" is no reason not to have fun yourself.

2. POLITICS OF RELATIONSHIP — ALTERNATIVE SOCIALIZATION

Each time we repeated anew that our suggestion to them was simply to translate their spontaneous behavior against other women into social forms.

— *Libreria delle donne di Milano,*
Non credere di avere dei diritti

The politics of winding down is concerned with dissolving and removing means of domination, with challenging the powers that be. It does not, however, tell us how we should regulate our relations, our cooperations. Even if there can be no fixed models for it, there are experiences and criteria that indicate which forms may replace dominant forms of cooperation and how they can be protected from turning into new relations of domination.

This is what a politics of relationship is about — or a politics of alternative socialization. The relation to winding down — as to any other of the five "politics" — is not to be conceived as a succession in time but as a simultaneity. One is not possible without the others.

Negotiation Principle

The thing we fear most is the situation where we cannot negotiate anything any more.

It does not matter for us if the unshakable, strange decision that we are subjugated to is a result of democratic decision-making, the law, iron principles or personal arbitrariness. What matters is that we can-

not do anything about it anymore, and there is nothing left between us and violence, be that violence death sentence, rape, torture or total isolation — or, in our early years, putting on that horrible sweater that’s so scratchy we definitely can’t take it. Our idea of protection, as of freedom, is substantially based on the capacity to avoid these situations. It is more important to us than almost anything else. To be able to negotiate is more important to us than happiness.⁵⁷

When we can negotiate, however, we are in our element. Negotiating is the wild jungle of cooperation. Negotiating ends only in death; and we always quarrel a bit with the laws of nature because we can’t negotiate with them.

Negotiating is an exciting, treacherous, disorderly process. First, we can lump everything together in it. The women’s plenum *can* make its approval of a political appeal depend on the fact that the men of the group clean the toilet, too. The women of the Chiapas communities *could* make their participation in the uprising dependent on the men’s acceptance of revolutionary changes inside the community. Secondly, there are no rules for negotiating. If a question can be decided by majority or not is itself a matter of negotiation; likewise, if it is to be decided with regard to earlier decisions or not, if it has to be decided within a fixed time period, etc. Thirdly, in contrast to democratic decision-making or “rational dialogue,” negotiating does not require that the ones concerned are to a great degree similar or consciously share distinct basic opinions and values. It does not depend on certain linguistic forms; negotiating is done by practice. Who negotiates needs no theoretical beginners’ course first. What he or she needs is nothing more — and nothing less — than the ability and readiness for a (however articulated) “No, if not.”

With regard to negotiating, free cooperation is mostly anti-politics. It rejects all attempts to restrict negotiating or to regulate in a law and order style: “that’s not the issue here,” “we’ll talk about that later,” “we already cleared that up,” “you don’t know the first thing about that issue,” “we don’t negotiate with them.” In the perspective of free cooperation all these are illegitimate and rejectable attempts to gain one-sided power of definition over the process of negotiating, and by no means

harmless ones. “Political strike,” “wildcat strike,” “constraint,” “disloyalty in organization,” “luddism”: these are law-and-order terms anticipating interventions against the freedom of the ones negotiating. Modern definitions of “the political” or “the economy” are designed to deliberately separate the spheres of negotiation, and who they are negotiated with. It is the core of the separation of “political” and “private” that there are no “mixed” negotiations allowed and that large fields are therefore removed from collective negotiating. It is the core of the modern concept of economy that it allows certain forms of negotiation and excludes others, that it accepts certain actors as subjects in negotiation and not others.

A special form of rationality is created which produces “economic laws” that are based only on the fact that the whole territory and issue is pre-defined, pre-structured, and secured by correspondent means of domination.⁵⁸

Free cooperation does not take the regulation of negotiating as its starting point, but the actors. Whether a negotiation is free and equal does not depend on the rules but on the actors: whether they are able — and if necessary ready — for a “no, if not,” and whether this is possible at a similar and bearable price.

On that basis the actor can negotiate the rules of negotiation, too. They can set up rules and change them; they can act along these rules or break them. Free cooperation does not set up the rules. It empowers actors in the sense of establishing equal bargaining position. Aspects like “scientific findings,” “democratic majorities,” or “social necessities,” on the contrary, are cut down to size.

The problem of uncomfortable and unpopular work within cooperation regulates itself either by being equally distributed or especially well-paid, or it’s not done at all. Who doesn’t want the latter has to negotiate anew and to bring his or her weight to bear on the free and equal cooperation.

What cannot be derive from the general approval of negotiating is an unconditional Yes to markets. In the perspective of free cooperation, markets are ambiguous. Markets are a classical place of negotiation. Markets, however, are an instrument to withdraw from negotiations

and to break out from concrete cooperations, too. The utopia of modern economy, the “invisible hand of the market,” is precisely aimed at establishing an abstract mechanism that is removed from the sphere of influence of concrete negotiations and of concrete actors.⁵⁹ As an abstract force of price-making and as the single economic regulator for all goods and services, the market contradicts every substantial aspect of negotiating. Under such circumstances, we can no more lump everything together; we have no concrete opposite any more that we can negotiate with; we cannot influence the rules of cooperation any more because we can no longer reject the cooperation as a whole at a bearable price.

On the other hand, markets may also contribute positively to free cooperation. Markets can make us independent of single partners in cooperation. They can make it easier to deny a concrete cooperation because they allow us to change to another cooperation at a literally comparable price — that is, to buy or sell somewhere else, to work in another cooperation, or to seek someone else for our own cooperation. The latter doesn’t have to be a bad thing: the weight of a person who has specific skills and knowledge that we don’t have might become too strong in a cooperation if we don’t have the option of finding another expert if necessary.

The paradox dissolves if we consider markets as cooperations. They are, however, specific cooperations. A market is an umbrella cooperation in which basically three groups of members cooperate: producers, consumers and market operators. The latter provide infrastructure and exercise a certain supervision of rules without which a market doesn’t work. Within this umbrella cooperation, a lot of individual cooperation takes place, namely buying processes. Specific to these market-mediated single cooperations is that their members largely don’t ensure the conditions of cooperation themselves, or negotiate them; they expect the umbrella cooperation to do this. This makes it possible for many (single) cooperations to take place within a very short time.

In capitalist cooperation, the conditions of cooperation are that the commodities meet certain standards and are really delivered, that they are paid for, and that there is compensation if one of these points is not fulfilled. In free cooperation, conditions are different, and are already

known: that existing rights and rules may be changed (in this case, the rules of the buying/selling relationship); that the members can leave the cooperation or restrict their cooperative activity in order to influence the rules (thus, not to buy, not to sell, or to buy/sell only limited quantities); that this is possible for all at a similar and bearable price. This has to be ensured by the market because the individuals can't (otherwise it wouldn't be a market).

These precise conditions can be recognized as strategies in reality. Developing countries build organizations for common supply or demand; they ask for long-term contracts, guaranteed sales or deficiency guarantees; they subsidize home production of goods where they don't want to become totally dependent on imports. In producer-consumer associations, producers and consumers negotiate collectively to adjust the rules of their common market in a way that both sides can live with. In alternative trade with producers from countries of the South, structures are built where the specific bargaining position of the supply side is strengthened.

Again, a politics of free cooperation does not set up the rules but empowers the actors in the sense of equal bargaining power. It aims at a pluralistic competition of market operators and supports those who can realize the conditions of free cooperation to a higher degree for producers and consumers. This is the decisive criterion — not if the market is especially “organic,” or completely local, or especially lucrative.

Realistic Cooperation

A free cooperation is no primitive-communist society where everything is brotherly shared and shared alike and everybody is sisterly self-sacrificing oneself for the others. It is a cooperation where we are free to leave, to restrict, to influence the rules, and where we are equal because we can do this in the same way and at a similar price. A political group, a self-organized project or a social movement may demand that all members throw together their complete fortune and income into one common budget; place all of their time at the common cooperation's disposal; or subjugate every other relationship to the values and aims of this cooperation. In the long run it won't find anybody who goes

along with that. It will attract people who have nothing to lose from such principles (because they don't possess anything; because they don't have anything else to do; because they don't have any other important relationships). It may be able to tie single individuals for some time by high moralist pressure, people who feel obliged to such total altruism, but sooner or later they will be "burned," rejecting forms of alternative socialization for some time. This is a form of negotiation, too: not like that.

A society which is organized according to the logic of free cooperation to a quite high degree will not be completely level. Social differences will be smaller but they will exist; people will have different abilities and different performances; they will participate in different cooperations at the same time and engage differently in them; and they will still have reasons to hold historically developed privileges, advantages, leads against each other. Nevertheless they will cooperate. If they guide themselves not by a morality of bearing, correcting, and compensating, but by a fundamentalist morality of total surrender, they will fail. This is more true of a situation where free cooperation is not a socially powerful logic but a concrete utopia standing in contradiction to the dominant logic.

The general rule of realistic cooperation is: For each individual it has to be better to participate in this cooperation than to let it go; and for the cooperation it has to be better if this individual takes part than if not. Otherwise the cooperation is either exploitative and forced, or morally overdrawn and not sustainable. There are, of course, a lot of possibilities in which it can be "better" for the cooperation and for the individual — something the cooperation must offer each and every individual, and every individual to the cooperation, more than just an opportunity to feel morally justified.

A social movement cannot expect that the young join it out of sheer admiration for its historical achievements. The individual cannot expect that a project puts up with him or her no matter how he/she behaves. He or she cannot even expect that a concrete cooperation is obliged to admit him/her anyway. It is not.

There is one exception to this rule: If there is no similar and bear-

able alternative to this cooperation for the one concerned, then both sides have to deal with the fact that “sending on” — in the perspective of free cooperation — is not possible. We can choose whom we admit into our project or our company, but we cannot choose which refugees we admit into our society.

Recognition

Difference is the leading topic in postmodern political reflection: differences between groups, between historically emerged identities, between the subjects of different emancipation movements, but also differences inside these groups, crossings over the borders of those identities, differences between those comparatively privileged and those relatively excluded within the respective emancipation movements, between those close to the norm and those more remote from it. Every liberation process will sooner or later trigger a second and a third wave of liberation, and the reliable subject of this liberation crumbles, gets pluralized.⁶⁰

A politics of recognition differs from the liberal idea of tolerance, according to which everybody may pursue happiness after his own fashion as long as he stays inside certain limits which themselves are in no way subject to tolerance. Recognition needs conflict and arguing. Difference can be accepted and recognized as a productive practice if we have come to know the other and have at least understood some of the outlines of what it is.

This is no matter of altruism; we do it because we want to cooperate. And we do it because we may change ourselves by doing it. The problem with difference is not that something is strange and unknown to us; the problem is that it shows some submerged relationships to parts and aspects of ourselves that we use to suppress, to oppress, to control, to deny. Much of it is projection, some of it is real. And we have to pass through this bewildering territory of difference and hidden similarity, of dreamed difference and real difference, of repulsion and attraction, if we want to cooperate as subjects.⁶¹ There is no easy way if our cooperation is not deemed to be shaky and superficial.

Recognition starts with accepting something/someone as other, not as deviant. The Libreria-group talks about the necessary recognition

between “socially elder” and “socially younger” women within groups and within the movement. The ones have more than enough experience, the others of intact claims; only if both sides understand this can they make the difference productive in their cooperation. We are only capable of recognition if we perceive ourselves not as homogeneous and “conclusive” but as the conflicting and sometimes difficult integration of very different aspects, components and possibilities.

Enabling

Every cooperation disposes of a distinct capital. This may be money or possessions, or a certain number of working hours the individuals place at the cooperation’s disposal; certain experiences, connections, knowledge; or certain access options to the material and immaterial capacities of the individuals. The cooperation uses its capital to achieve its aims. If a cooperation always wants to decide on the use of the collective capital together, if each single use is fully and collectively negotiated, this will inevitably lead to rigidity and conservatism.

Therefore every cooperation — be they groups or society, relationships or companies — also has to invent and practice structures of *enabling*. Enabling means that the cooperation uses collective capital for projects that not everybody is convinced of, whose details are not debated by all at length, or that are not even understandable to the majority of the members for the time being.

Well-functioning forms of enabling ensure what is called *Freundlichkeit* (friendliness) by Brecht: We get something that we are not 100% entitled to but which our cooperation is able and willing to give us.

An art exhibition some time ago had the nice title “Things we do not understand.” That is exactly what this is about. We expect a cooperation to support us — not always and not without limit, but as a basic option — even in things that it does not understand. Without that we couldn’t have any relationship; without that, no group, no company, no society can be creative and open. Without that nothing new can emerge and no cooperation will be able to transform itself.

There are many ways that enabling can be practiced. Market women in Indonesia pay the small change of their sales into a common till that

they draw lots for at the end of the day. Each of them wouldn't know what to do with the small amount she pays in, but as a collective capital that all women place at the disposal of one of them, however, one can do something with it. Who drew the right lot drops out for the next rounds until every woman has had her turn. We, too, know many forms of enabling, personally and socially, and if they are better than drawing lots we should consider them.

Enabling is partly a compensation for what we lose if we do without dominantly shaped relationships. By enabling, we place ourselves and our cooperative activity really at the disposal of others — not because we have to but because we can. Not as forced cooperation but as free mutuality. Sometimes this is a close shave. Turning enabling into inequality is one of the risks that we take for free cooperation.

Disloyalty to What Exists

Free cooperation knows loyalty to people but not to structures — and not to cooperations, either. To treat a cooperation according to the principle of disloyalty means not to rule out the possibility of its failure and not to attach importance to its continued existence as such. We ask not only: How could things be regulated differently in this cooperation? but also: how would it be if this cooperation would end? Is it really better for me that it exists?

Only in this perspective can we gain an open view and an option of more radical changes in a cooperation. Good cooperations are continuously put on trial by its members, and are closed all the time on a trial basis in their members' imaginations, in order to find out if their momentum and their practical necessities are really necessary and if they are worth it. We gain a critique of property and disposal relations in the cooperation from this, too. If we get divorced and divide the fortune among us, would that really be worse for us? If we would, in a highly-developed industrial country, wind down the productive structures and sell them it would earn all citizens a relatively comfortable income for the rest of their lifetime. Do the productive structures ensure that as they are, too? To everybody? If, in an mostly agrarian country, we would divide all land into subsistence units, it would allow all citi-

zens a survival without misery, at least in many cases. Does the actual use of land achieve the same?

Disloyalty to what exists also means that we cannot maintain a co-operation against the will of its members. Even if we have achieved structures that realize a substantial degree of free cooperation we cannot ensure that these structures may not be given up again. We cannot prevent that. Not everything is lost in that case. We've changed ourselves through it; and the social has a memory of experiments.

3. UNFOLDING SOCIAL CAPACITIES: SUBJECTIVE APPROPRIATION

"How many men live here?" Tino asked.

"Five," said Lilith. "Only five men."

Tino shook his head. "No wonder that you didn't build anything."

"We build ourselves," Wray replied. "We build a new way of living here. You don't know anything about us. Why don't you ask questions instead of talking rubbish?"

— Octavia Butler, "Adulthood Rites"
(*Xenogenesis* II, Part One: "Lo," Chapter 5)

Our dominant historiography writes the history of technological, not of social, capacities. We build row houses, nuclear plants and Mars probes, but with regard to our social capacities we practically sleep on bare ground. This is not due to some alleged "lagging" of our social capacities behind the technological ones, as is often said, so that the social always has to be "adjusted" to the technological achievements afterwards. It is due to the systematic oppression of social capacities, or rather of the possibilities to gain them and pass them on autonomously.

Domination requires breaking-in, a continuous de-learning of any social capacities that might work as tools of resistance or self-organization.

What follows here is not a list of capacities you could teach or deliberately bring people up to have. It hints at certain typical problems that

are known from actual experiments in free cooperation, and to individual preconditions that are important in dealing with those problems. It is about “subjective appropriation” in that sense: not of the marvellous technological possibilities or of the historical stage in the development of the productive forces, but of experiences that are had wherever attempts at free cooperation are practically tested.

Self-Reflection

Free cooperation requires a certain degree of self-reflection, of enlightenment about ourselves and especially about what “is not our fault”: historically produced and passed-on differences, privileges, sensitivities, specific abilities and specific blindnesses, fears and desires. Otherwise we won’t get along with each other. For this we have to reject all concepts that draw an abstract “ideal human subject,” compared to which all concrete differences are “contaminations” to be erased. The greatest problem is not how we are but that we do not realize that we, too, are somehow not the norm, not normal, only one draft among many.⁶²

Self-reflection is the precondition of recognition. But self-reflection emerges mainly from concrete conflicts about recognition. Its yardstick is not to become “better” oneself but to stand less in the way of others (and of oneself). This is what makes all attempts to train men in “female skills” (“soft skills”) fatal as it advances patriarchy even more. This is why New Age and African drumming are not the main ways to work on our historical deformations. There is no alternative to confrontations with people — collectively and in abstract ways, but primarily individually and in concrete ways.

A politics of unfolding social capacities consists here mainly in demanding self-reflection from each other. It consists, further, in protecting, supporting and creating spaces where conflicts about recognition can be executed on the most free and equal basis possible. Only third does it consist in the individual work of dealing with it — in what Spivak calls “unlearning our privileges as our loss.”⁶³

Collective Leadership

Every cooperation needs a certain quantity of leadership. If we have

thrashed out our differences, interests, and conceptualizations, it has to go on somehow, too. A politics of negotiating that does not want to orient objectifiable criteria or ideals of efficiency needs creative solutions, especially to bring different ideas and intentions together. Somebody has to suggest something that may be suitable to this cooperation in this situation; something that possibly can be agreed on. Leadership means to articulate anticipations of a collective orientation.

Structures of dominance emerge if the same people are always articulating these anticipations. Ideally, leadership is collectively distributed in a cooperation: everybody does it sometimes. If a cooperation limits itself to abolishing the dominant leadership of single actors without developing more collective leadership at the same time, it will fail. Either simply nothing will happen anymore because the positions of the single actors can no longer be brought together, or the cooperation falls apart. This must not be the worst case: the principle of disloyalty supports an unemotional consideration of this option. If the members want to keep up the cooperation, however, they have to develop leadership. To deny this problem means only that leadership emerges behind everybody's back, informally and basically unnoticed, which is no improvement.

This cannot, however, be a justification of structures of dominance. A politics that wants to develop collective leadership has to actually hold back dominant leadership in order to open spaces where collective leadership can gain a foothold. It has to accept that this may involve setbacks in "efficiency." It has to be ready to experiment, to take time and to pay something for it, too. It has to investigate which circumstances in the cooperation hinder the leadership of others. And it has to get it straight in its mind that a transformation of structures and of the distribution of leadership will lead to a transformation of the orientation and criteria of the cooperation, too. If the cooperation does not change through collective leadership, regarding its rules and aims, then this collective leadership is very likely to be only a pretense.

Consciousness

All emancipation movements do consciousness politics. The most in-depth remarks about this issue can be found in the black liberation

movement that coined the term.

Forced cooperation traumatizes. The perception of being socially weaker leads to the interpretation of being worth less. Domination pummels elements of self-hatred, self-doubt, and self-denial into the oppressed. Whoever moves in forced cooperations has to accept inferiority in his or her own agency. The solidarity of the privileged with themselves extends to the defense of those norms. Compared to those, the nonprivileged have their “failure” proved daily. Material insecurity, latent and open danger, the experience of not being defended, all leads to dissolving of solidarities, powerlessness, the feeling of being half-human. Consciousness politics is a correction of values and the building of experiences and structures that fight the inner erosion caused by power. It is cultural and political agitation, promotion of self-confidence, and the organizing of community-oriented structures.

For a politics of unfolding social capacities it is noteworthy that beneath and among the (irreplaceable) consciousness politics of actual emancipation movements, there is a completely unmet, real need for an intermediating and generalizing form of consciousness politics. More simply put, the abolition of formal inequality and the simultaneous arrogance of power lead to a situation where elements of the traumatization described can be found in *everyone*. Even the privileged know that they are worth something only as long as they keep “performing.” *All* are given the impression that they don’t matter as people at all, that society owes them nothing. On a certain level the society of winners creates a feeling of defeat in *everybody* because there’s always someone better, bigger, richer. “This sense of defeat is basically what we are fighting against... people must develop a hope, people must develop some form of security to be together to look at their problems, and people must in this way build up their humanity. This is the point about conscientization and Black Consciousness.”⁶⁴

The power and wealth of forced cooperations suggest that we judge our experiments in free cooperation as nonsense, powerless, and again and again simply poor. We feel inclined to treat them as preliminary, incomplete, and therefore with little care — as if the dominant logic of forced cooperation is eternal, perfect, and undeserving of our attention

in any way. Free cooperation therefore requires that the members support themselves mutually in developing an appropriate self-confidence. There won't be anyone else to do it.

We live and cooperate mammalian nests from which we ogle at the enormous, heavily-armed palaces of dinosaurs. We build ourselves. We often experience as defiant what in reality is the beauty of the new. We have to get it straight in our minds again and again that the giants on the opposite side, in spite of their huge measurements and highly specific skills, basically can't count to three. We couldn't stand our ground in open battle. But that's not the way we shall win anyway.

Agency

Forced cooperation produces typical fantasies of powerlessness and megalomania: If we were unbelievably powerful, we could change anything; since we are not, however, we do nothing of the sort. We get used to suppressing problems and not shaping our environment. We expect that someone tells us what to do and that we can complain if things don't work. We even expect that if someone leads us to a corner, hands us a paintbrush and says "Just do it!" we should call this civil society and participation.

Free cooperation, on the contrary, depends on the individual's capacity for active agency. In a cooperation of free and equals there's no one behind us any more. Active agency seeks its field and object itself; it defines its aims autonomously. It is self-instruction.

In a political perspective we are always tempted to build hierarchies. For a politics of free cooperation, however, active agency is a criterion itself. It does not send the various activities through a filter of "important" and "unimportant." The individuals may quarrel about what they deem important and not important, and they always have to bring this to balance. But in a political movement the social activity of the various actors must not be a field for recruiting unpaid "governance" work.

Independence

Cooperation has its own gravity. Since we are strongly designed for cooperation, each cooperation has a high degree of binding force.

Forced cooperation has it; but free cooperation has it as well. In the “Xenogenesis” trilogy Olivia Butler found memorable images for this.⁶⁶ We build ourselves in relation to people we cooperate with, approaching and dissociating; without cooperation we literally fall apart, lose any shape. To leave cooperations is *physically* hard. At the same time, no cooperation we’re in is completely freely chosen. We choose from a necessarily limited supply, and often just stumble into them. That’s why in some sense we quarrel with *every* cooperation because we know about its force, against which we have to prove our independence always anew. Even if we do not tear the bonds, every now and then we have to stretch them close to the point of snapping. Otherwise we lose the pledge of our freedom and equality: to be capable of *leaving*. We lose our influence on the rules.

Free cooperation therefore has to accept and empower individual and collective independence on cooperations. We basically need all that bothers: withdrawals, pauses for reflection, reconsiderations, conflicts for conflict’s sake, confrontations that serve only to test how far we can take them; how far we can go away from the cooperations that we live in and know. No other point makes it that clear that sheer efficiency and rationality would undermine the conditions of our freedom and equality. We really have to understand this. And a politics of free cooperation requires the always renewed experience that the rules, as good as they may be, are not sacred. “Some of them can be bent. Others can be broken.”⁶⁷ In the end this is the meaning of all politics: breaking the rules.

4. ACTIVE CRITIQUE OF DEMOCRACY: EMANCIPATORY DEMOCRATIZATION

We must not be blinded by the myth of democracy, but to understand democracy as a system of regulations that pursues the disciplining of conflicts of interest within the patriarchal-capitalist society.

— Claudia Bernhard, *A Critique of Historical Democracy*⁶⁸

Since the end of the Cold War we experience a world in election-frenzy.

The problems of the world are said to be solved by establishing representative structures of political power all over the world, modeled after Western Europe or the US. The idea of democracy and democratization is mainly reduced to that.

Not that elections are necessarily a bad thing. It's more like cough syrup. It's good for coughing, it's no good for athlete's foot, and that it stifles coughing is sometimes good and sometimes bad.

In the context of neo-colonialist politics it is quite clear that the demand for elections is a welcome means to get rid of nasty negotiations: Let's just build another party. Elections have the disadvantage of being an extremely rudimentary way of negotiating. On the one hand they allow only package decisions in the way of "If you don't like this, go join them!" On the other hand they exactly presuppose the existence of fixed regulation systems. On the submerged six-sevenths of the iceberg we have no influence.

As we know from the '70s, you've got to be cautious about the idea of democratization. To make more and more inner spheres of society subject to the principles of elections, representation and democratic decision-making may well mean that the social depth and range of domination increases, while our possibilities to withdraw and to negotiate decrease. Majority decisions do not themselves guarantee freedom and equality.

Structures of elected representation should by no means be accepted as a reason to give up our possibilities of free cooperation, including the option of separation. Elections say nothing about the legitimacy of political violence. Violence is legitimate to defend oneself against forced cooperation, i.e., if you get neither negotiation nor a fair leave. It can not be justified as pushing through "justice" for all, but only as regaining control over one's own share in the cooperation, or as supporting others who can declare their aims but cannot push them through because they're subject to superior power.

So we must not get carried away. We have to shake off the stupor of "democracy," one way or another. Where the alternative to elections is the autocracy of individuals or traditional dynasties, elections are to be preferred. Elections, however, are not the ideal of free negotiation and

cooperation. Elections may restrict power but they may also increase it, and the fact that they can restrict power may be used for or against free cooperation. This can be said for non-hierarchical movements as well, which, from the perspective of Free Cooperation, have no inherent value. The theory of free cooperation is no speculation that would favor certain fixed models of collective decision-making or “prescribe” them as utopian. It takes an agnostic stand on these models; the model doesn’t say anything about its concrete effects on freedom and equality. Instead, free cooperation articulates a politics that can be applied to various models and stands cross-model — a politics to counter the historical tendencies of democracy (and “democratization”) towards domination, and to empower free and equal influence on the rules, whatever those rules may be. This politics stretches to all spaces and forms of cooperation, from flat-share to global politics.

Egalitarian Corporatism

A politics of free cooperation strengthens forms of corporatism if they are egalitarian. It makes sense for a politics of negotiating that this negotiating takes place between “functional” collectives, because no one can sufficiently recognize or represent “from outside” the specific interests and needs of producers and consumers, white collars and blue collars, big companies and small initiatives, etc. The same is true for identity-oriented collectives, the “classical” and “new” structures of self-representation that emerge from structures of social oppression (e.g., structures of self-representation of women, wage workers, non-whites, post-colonial nations, and also of “illegals,” children, disabled persons etc.). And it is true in all these cases for the “opposite” side as well.

Roundtables are okay even if in certain traditional left quarters this may seem blasphemous. They are okay under certain preconditions. They really have to have a say in something; they have to be given actual decisive powers. They have to be egalitarian in a double sense: that the vote of all members of the table counts alike and that all who are substantially concerned by its decisions have to be represented at the table. In addition, the consequences of non-agreement have to be sub-

stantially similar for all members. It makes a difference if wage negotiations are done on the basis of a principal inflationary adjustment (or a principal relation of profits and wages) or not; if the route for a new road is built through the nature reserve if the members of the roundtable disagree about the details, or if it can not be built in this case. And finally the form of the roundtable must not prescribe a distinct interpretation of the problem at stake to its members, neither individually nor collectively, as binding. It must be possible for the members to advocate their own interpretation, and it must be possible for the roundtable to get to another interpretation of the problem than was initially conceived.

Such structures and preconditions imply a lot of problems, but these are harmless compared to the problem of how a government or a party should achieve “justice” for all by representing “all.” These are structures that may be a bit “dirty” in the perspective of the critique of domination because they may bring oppressors and oppressed together at a table. They don’t change the necessity of winding down means of domination or of creating basic social conditions of a “similar and bearable price.” But they offer spaces of self-articulation to its members and spaces for concrete solutions in the sense of realistic cooperation. They are the main instruments of taking social decisions out of state control.

The critique of roundtables being “ignorant of domination” is right, but often itself ignores the fact that the influence of the less-privileged on superior “democratic” decision-making processes is lower than their influence at roundtables would be, and that structures of corporate decision-making exist anyway — only that they’re not open and egalitarian. There is therefore no objection to transferring large parts of what today is social “redistribution” and state “steering” to structures of egalitarian corporatism. It would certainly be no disadvantage to those living on social security if the design of these benefits were subject to roundtables instead of being subject to governmental god-like decision. For a lot of social sectors, from education and social services to economic policy, experience has shown that the majority of those involved have basically no vote within today’s regulation systems. De-nation-

alization as a positive aim does not mean economizing and slimming down but re-locating decisions to egalitarian-corporative authorities. In a society that already has effected a far-reaching dismantling of disposability, “abolition of the state” cannot be conceived other than as maximum transfer of social decisions to egalitarian-corporative (and autonomous-decentralized) structures.

Autonomous Decentralization

Today’s debate on globalization has confronted the left with the nation-state paradox: it suggests a claim of strengthening national authority and control, the nation-state itself is traditionally analyzed as a means of domination. This paradox only dissolves if we negate it in a comprehensive perspective of autonomous decentralization.

The nation-state’s character of domination, and the domination implicit in the erosion of the nation-state by unbounded globalization, are both based on the same principle: the larger a cooperation, the more difficult it is for us as individuals to influence its rules. Our weight decreases. This is not true, however, of all actors and likewise not of all rules.

We may clarify this by a “statistic” consideration of revolutionary processes. To change a given society in a revolutionary way, the individuals have to break the dominant rules, in words and actions, and they have to expect disadvantages and repression for it, and that their situation will get worse. Only in the case of successful revolution would their situation (still taking an ideal case study) get better. Individuals or a small number of people cannot effect this change, only a great number of people can. Since the dominant rules are those of domination, the individuals cannot communicate or coordinate themselves without disadvantage and repression; they have no other means of communication than their actions. If some visibly break the rules in words and actions, others may decide to join in. If there are many who join in, the probability of success increases, and the risk of participating decreases; if there are only very few, success is unlikely, and the risk is very high. This has to be taken into consideration also by those who share the revolutionaries’ aims, because an attempted overthrow that

is joined in by many and only just fails will spoil the possibility of success for a long time.

As there is no way of coordination for all, there will always only be a small number of people who revolt. Interpreted strictly statistically, revolutions are therefore impossible because of the size of social cooperation. Even if 90% of the population would wish a downfall of the regime, and only 40% would be powerful enough to effect it, they would never overcome the starting point of the uprising when “joining in” would be an unreasonably great risk.

As we all know, revolutions take place nevertheless. This is possible because society is not an accumulation of monadic individuals but a network of cooperations that themselves form larger cooperations. Already few large cooperations may be enough to come close to the “sufficient” 40%; already a number of small cooperations may be enough to influence one of “their” large cooperations; already a few individuals may be enough to bring some small cooperations to participate and tip the balance. The process is faster and progresses in “steps.” It is only because we know that and take it into account that we may make a decision at the starting point and overcome the “statistic impossibility” of revolution.⁶⁹

Changes in a given society are thus more possible if the disadvantages of breaking the rules are bearable for individuals and groups; if this society is internally well-structured, containing many different cooperations of different sizes and mutually intertwined; if these cooperations are capable of communicating well internally and mutually. Only this can compensate for the “shrinking” of the individual in relation to large super-cooperations.

Not all, however, shrink likewise. Since capital (in the comprehensive sense) is not spilled out in society like sand but builds accumulations and structures, individuals and groups that already work with big accumulations may actually trigger basic changes — because already a small number of them is enough to counter the threat, and because they may use this capital to influence the criteria of rationality for the decisions of everyone else. This is why skilled workers and soldiers play a key role in every historical revolution; this is why CEOs, managers,

generals and governments can stage a “coup” much more easily, and continuously do it, completely legally.

Large cooperations are not necessarily a bad thing, but they are dangerous to the degree that they “level” society, i.e., as they kill cooperations and subdivisions and individualize society, thus making the individuals “shrink.” That’s the problem with the nation-state, and that’s the problem with what today is called globalization. We can only afford large cooperations if there is a differentiated system of sub-units vested with a high degree of autonomy.

Basically the argument is quite simple: As individuals (or as small groups) we can only keep up relationships to a large cooperation as free-and-equals if there is a system of in-between-cooperations that we have more influence on, and that relative to the big unit, fulfill the conditions of free cooperation which we cannot fulfill: to challenge all rules; to be able to *leave* and to restrict and to influence by that; to make the cooperation fail at a similar and bearable *price*. From this can be derived the rest, while you may argue about the details: states, areas and communities whose ground and nature cannot be sold at will; specific restrictions and controls for all actors that momentarily work with big “accumulations of capital”; special emphasis on the “withdrawability” of authority that was transferred “up” from “below”; and a lot of money and time that has to be spent on every form of “internal stratification” that you can get.

Socialist-inspired systems found it principally difficult to accept such “in-between cooperations.” They were prone to a politics of “levelling,” of dissolving social levels of decision, of structures and authorities that stand between state and individual. This is not only a typical case of false worshipping of “efficiency” but also a misunderstanding of the meaning of “revolution,” which is individuals taking over as many decisions as possible with their various forms of cooperation, in order to no longer surrender to outside determination by a central politics. In that sense, revolutionary politics is always practical anti-politics, too, and the utopia of free and equal self-determination is always concrete anti-utopia, too.

Affirmative Action

If a cooperation has reached the point where it acknowledges a group being historically and actually disadvantaged, it is not enough to make do with “democratic” responses — the abolition of formal discrimination, ostensibly equal access to processes of decision-making, not even introduction of materially equal opportunities (which never happens anyway).⁷⁰ Domination does have an effect; the privileged have acquired a rich, complex system of advantages with which they can win every “formally equal” game. To really shift weights it takes no less than poetic injustice, and for a long time.⁷¹

Affirmative action means measures designed to specifically prefer members of socially disadvantaged groups. Affirmative action has been a comparatively well-developed field of politics in the US, first for black people, later for women, too, and increasingly for other groups. Programs of affirmative action play an important role in today’s South Africa, too. In Europe, things are looking rather poor. Affirmative action contains instruments such as quota regulations for employment or for the composition of bodies as well as specific training offers. It is not necessarily state politics, but takes place in various cooperations — in companies, groups and structures of everyday life, from the well-known “quoted speakers’ list” and special rights in organizations and institutions up to various concrete prerogatives that are understood as deliberate compensations for acknowledged disadvantages.

Affirmative action, however, only works if it is not limited to “make-up” instruments like quota and training programs but supports and pushes a critique of the dominant norms, too. It is *biased* in content, too. It ain’t “just”; it is measured against the aim to give a real advantage to formerly disadvantaged groups in order to compensate for their being down in power.

Affirmative action is an application of the principle that the rules can be changed. It can be exercised and pushed through at all levels of the social, in every form of cooperation. From a free cooperation perspective, it must be examined whether a superior cooperation (in this case, nation society) can make prescriptions to subordinate cooperations of how they have to be made up. This has to be approved for re-

spective laws regarding the public sector and large cooperations. Since society provides the relevant social capital to large cooperations, it may attach to it the condition that all social groups are given equal access and representation in their decision-making structures.

In a free cooperation perspective this applies not only to big companies but to big social organizations and representative political bodies, i.e., parliaments, governments, ministries, state bureaucracy and big structures of social decision and disposal, like the media or the educational system.

Political Correctness

What affirmative action is for the social dimension of means of domination (discrimination), political correctness is for the institutional dimension (control of the public). Political correctness, initially a combat term of the American political right, today means a politics of examining words, writings and visual representation for discriminating content and expressions, and working towards non-discriminating forms. The incrimination and sanctioning of distinct expressions (“fighting words”) is heavily controversial (although fines for insulting an official, for example, are usually much higher and much more polished). However, this forms only the most superficial part of political correctness. In a broader sense it is the claim to break existing structures of dominance on the level of symbolical order, of representation, and to “quote” this representation regarding its content — that is, to let those who were traditionally excluded by the ruling order of dominance have their say and their symbolic representation.

Free cooperation certainly does not legitimize a prescriptive politics that would dictate distinct language codes to everybody. But it does legitimize, as is the case with affirmative action, certain *conditions of administering social capital*. Here, too, the priority is not the negative aspect, i.e. “speech control,” but a positive aspect: the obligation to attach special, disproportionate importance to the content-related representation of disadvantaged groups. This may easily be demanded from the media, scientific institutions, etc., from a certain size upwards. Political correctness in this sense does not prescribe new norms for the content;

it only opens up a field of critique of the norms that prevailed so far.

Independent Basic Income

It is quite funny that members of parliament lay claim to keep up the independence of their opinion and their safety from blackmailing by taking comparatively high salaries — whereas most members of parliament do not deem it necessary to ensure that kind of independence and non-blackmailability to the sovereign, i.e., the people. What applies to members of parliament should apply to us, too. Only the guarantee of an independent, qualitatively sufficient basic income creates the condition that individuals do not have to sell themselves at any price. It ensures their political freedom; because political freedom above all means not having to enter forced cooperations of any kind. Where this is not possible by way of direct monetary benefits (and in the high-industrialized countries of the North this is quite possible) other forms can be considered — assignment of land, or access to social capital that may be used for structures of self-organization and self-sufficiency. A politics of free cooperation, it should be noted again here, does not limit itself to desirable state activities. People and collectives all over the world exercise a politics of independent basic income, continuously looking for means of participation in the huge accumulations heaped-up mountains of social capital without fulfilling the prescribed conditions of forced cooperation. Again, the democratic pathos of fighting corruption, patronage and fraudulent use of services is usually a right-wing political program directed straight against these mass politics of “creative anticipation of independent basic income.”

“It means to mistake the whole social system if it has become fashionable lately to blame people who get ‘false’ or fraudulent pensions. The real problem is that if you don’t own anything you have to pretend to be blind in order to get a benefit.”⁷²

5. GETTING ORGANIZED

If we consider the possibility that all women live in a lesbian continuum — from being a baby nursed at her mother's breast up to being a grown woman having orgasmic feelings while feeding her own child and maybe remembering the milk smell of her mother by the smell of her own milk; or from two women like Virginia Woolf's Chloe and Olivia sharing a laboratory up to the old woman of 90 years who dies being cared and touched by women — if we consider this possibility we may see, too, how we ourselves continuously move in and out of this continuum, no matter if we call ourselves lesbians or not.

— Adrienne Rich,
“Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence”⁷³

It is Gayatri Spivak's sentence that “There are no rules but the old rules.”⁷⁴ We find rules everywhere. We do not know exactly how necessary or arbitrary they are in each case but they are there. We don't know any other rules than the ones that already exist. The new ones we don't know, or only in first signs, in experiments, not from comprehensive practical tests. Since we depend on cooperation, we depend on cooperation having rules. This gives the existing rules, the rules that rule, an enormous advantage. That we may make certain choices and decisions within the framework of these rules is marginal compared to the fact that we inherit a complete world full of existing rules.

From this dependence we cannot free ourselves alone — not mentally, not practically, not in conflict with the power of the “old rules.” To become free and equal we need a politics that deals with collective rebuilding of rules, with collective re-inventing of the world as we know it.⁷⁵ This aspect is called “getting organized” here.

Getting organized means practicing a politics which, through constant exchange, discussion, and proximity, pursues a greater similarity of ideological positions and strategic aims. Getting organized is not “formal organization.” It is a politics that aims at a unification of forces within the project of applying another logic of the social to most fields

of cooperation; a logic that you agree on in slow beginnings, on a trial basis, testing, in the process of getting organized, without giving up one's own specific approach. What components must there be for such a politics? What is important about it today?

This is the same as asking "Who will push all this through?" — the question that usually follows any remarks on political utopia. The processes of liberation are as complicated and multi-layered as those of domination. We can no longer imagine a historically privileged subject today which would effect the change of society — no class determined by function, ideology, or identity. We can no longer imagine a privileged space nor a privileged form of this conflict. And we can no longer imagine this process being dominated by formal political organizations. What is at stake here is a whole bundle of processes, a complex process in which organizations and social movements, everyday life arrangements and cultural movements, social experiments, cultural imagination and political fights play their role and cannot be mutually subjugated.⁷⁶

There is no lack of instruments and techniques for influence the rules. There is no lack of potential and already-active subjects. The question of whether we can be successful shifts to the question of what we possibly have in common.

There has been extensive argument here that there is an emerging commonality, that components of a similarity of views exist, and that they may be described — testing, as a kind of proposal — by the theory and practice of free cooperation. In this chapter certain elements are described that are important, since we have to mutually support ourselves in pushing through such a logic. The idea of the continuum, as introduced by Adrienne Rich in the passage cited above, is clarifying here. A continuum has no top nor bottom. The most various social spheres of action are connected in it according to the principle of self-similarity; there is no hierarchy of the different politics of emancipation and free cooperation. A continuum shows zones of high and low condensation, but it has no clear limits.

We should imagine the politics of free cooperation as a continuum as well, a continuum that we move in and out of, that we sometimes

don't even recognize, but that we already partly inhabit. Getting organized means transforming a potential commonality into a deliberate connection, to see oneself as part of a strategic continuum. The forms of this connection may be tighter or looser but it is more than just a network, because it is an *oriented* commonality. It has a basis. It has an entry ticket consisting at least in the belief — however expressed or articulated — that domination exists and that emancipation isn't something ridiculous. "Emancipation today is, again, an immeasurable question, and I have to say that I have no tolerance for those who — deconstructivists or not — behave ironically towards this great discourse of emancipation."⁷⁷

Solidarity

A politics of getting organized requires solidarity, namely a kind of solidarity that is non-tactical but strategic. Solidarity means mutual support in the attempt to influence the rules and fight back against forced cooperation. Solidarity can compensate for the disadvantage that we face as individuals — or as a single group, movement, cooperation — in confrontation with more powerful ones that use means of domination. Solidarity helps make the price of non-cooperation and of influence more similar and bearable where the confrontation is taking place. Only along this line can solidarity be mobilized. Somehow we don't really see why we should go out in the street to support "2.5% more for printing industry workers" as we don't happen to be printers, but it is obvious to us that our solidarity is demanded if those concerned are denied or restricted their possibility of free and equal negotiation.

The kind of solidarity that is demanded here is non-tactical. Its measure is not if we like the respective aims of others or not. Its measure is if they are denied a free negotiation. It is strategic, however, as far as it does not support other collectives whose aims openly contradict the social logic of emancipation or free cooperation. We do not support a liberation movement, oppressed as it may be, that would build an oppressive regime itself. We do not back a musician's claim for freedom from his company if he produces sexist or racist video clips. That's asking too much. Solidarity is no one-way, morally coercible activity. It is

subject to negotiations itself — not on a tactical but definitely on a strategic basis.

Coalition

Getting organized is done in coalitions. It requires interpretation of political cooperation — in whatever form — as cooperation between groups that cannot be brought down to a common ideological, practical or organizational denominator.

Every party, every organization, every social movement, every musical style is a coalition; this is its capital that is not to be gambled with. Understanding getting organized as a process of coalitions requires a practice of recognition that implies mutual critique and mutual respect. The coalition character is more valuable than efficiency, size, momentary influence, or tactical scope because well-functioning coalitions — and only coalitions that are constantly questioned are well-functioning — are spaces where the work of translation between different languages, tendencies, traditions, and experiences is done. Without such a work of translation, a new logic of the social can never be pushed through. That is why “mixed” and cross-section cooperations are especially important for processes of post-modern organizing.

Coalitions are highly sensitive, strategically extremely valuable cooperations. They are the heart of the matter. A politics that departs from the initial basis of a coalition can't be right.

Loyalty

Loyalty means maintaining processes of recognition and self-reflection even when relations of power and external circumstances have changed — be it between persons or among groups. Getting organized can only be successful if it overcomes the ‘cycles of ignorance.’ Cooperations are learning organizations: if there is pressure (by women, by migrants, by individuals, by movements...), they will change. But they are also soft organizations, and if the pressure decreases, they will change back again. The same is true for more personal cooperations. This tendency, however, has to be overcome. Change has to be real. It may have been triggered by pressure, but it has to be transformed in understand-

ing, and from then on, this understanding needs to be defended and developed by all members of the cooperation. This is loyalty between the members of a cooperation: a common unwillingness to “forget” already-achieved stages of recognition and self-reflection. People bound together by loyalty will not betray these achievements in recognition.

“Mixed” and cross-scene cooperations have a tendency to quickly reject achieved feminist, anti-racist or anti-authoritarian standards again as soon as a changed political climate suggests it. This was evident in the 20th century in almost all liberation movements after they consolidated their power; in our days it shows in the tendencies to get back to “hard-core issues” when dealing with neoliberal restructuring programs.

The same processes happen between individuals in cooperations as well. Here again the matter is not only political organizations and social movements but cultural movements and groups of any kind. A politics that only reflects the social strength and weakness of partial movements, themes, and positions is the opposite of getting organized as it is understood here.

Critical Articulation

As solidarity is the organized answer to direct violence, coalition the organized answer to structural violence, and loyalty the organized answer to discrimination, critical articulation is the organized answer to control of the public. Just as other components require breaking with any absolute primacy of one’s “own cooperation,” with pure political efficiency and with any homogeneity of interests, critical articulation requires breaking with any uniformity, internal and external.

Post-modern getting organized cannot change the rules through direct control or with its own power. It is essentially “interventionist,” i.e., it intervenes in social conflicts, provokes them, stimulates them, gives possible interpretations and solutions.⁷⁸

In a free cooperation perspective it can neither represent nor steer the actual social cooperation in all its details. It does not push through solutions but corrects and compensates the price at which single actors may act and negotiate. According to the complexity of domina-

tion and the gravity of the existing rules, one of the key elements of getting organized is demonstrating alternative views in theory and practice and making them conceivable. The gravity of the rules reduces the individuals to silence. Their own dissatisfaction deems them irrational, false, flawed. Their silence, towards others as towards themselves, buys the individuals some calm but doesn't help them. "My silence did not protect me. Your silence will not protect you."⁷⁹ Politically, getting organized starts and ends with finding words for what is difficult to talk about.⁸⁰ Here again we meet Kafka and the desire for the word that serves as an axe for the frozen conditions in us and around us.⁸¹

Critical articulation only becomes possible if politically getting organized opens a space for saying more than that which already has enough gravity. It has to be conceived as a catalyst for something new, for what it still doesn't know itself; as a shelter for other interpretations, as humus for alternative experiments and for new rules. A space of protection even against the politics itself and the gravity of its own rules.

Individuation

"One of the criteria we examined the correctness of our politics with was the criterion of personal gain. We controlled collectively if the individuals weren't sacrificed to this politics."⁸² Post-modern getting organized is not about final truth and safe knowledge by revelation. It has to deal with the fact that it may be wrong. Its capital are real people and the actual gain that people extract from being part of it and acting accordingly. This gain, of course, cannot be measured by the criteria of the dominant rules and dominant "rationality," but nor can it be suspended by talking about "future gains" and "the good cause." There's no place for a politics of sacrifice.⁸³

Individuation means that we cannot schematize this individual gain and that we don't have to. There are legitimate forms of politics of interest but political getting organized is something else: an affirmative relationship to another logic of the social, that of free cooperation. We are more than certain interests; we are prototypes in a field of contradictions. These concrete prototypes are what utopias are built of. That's

why there are no abstract subjects. That's why we cannot be freed "past ourselves."

A politics of individuation means that you don't burn out people. It means that you're conscious that political getting organized always happens between people: it transforms the logic of how we — across all frictions and divisions — treat each other.

We lose a certain false security of alleged calculability by this but we win a certain calm from it. It is a larger picture that counts, and if structures and projects break down, there are still the people left who may try again and better. Post-modern getting organized is not a politics for gamblers, no politics of "coup."⁸⁴ It is about livable styles of politics that people may get old and happy with and, at least some of them, even nice.

All this characterizes a certain degree of ripeness in the processes of getting organized. The break with an absolute primacy of one's "own cooperation," with political efficiency, homogeneity, "uniformity" and "integration," the unfolding of solidarity, coalition, loyalty, critical articulation and individuation, all this changes cooperations, societies, individuals, relationships. Getting organized opens up a new, unknown social space; a space where the future may find room, always anew.

THE CLOCK OF LUND

For long enough, you've been figures in a clockwork that you didn't build. Stop it.

You live in a world where there is no elevated point from which you could see any better than through your eyes. You are the only ones: there will be no one else coming to care for you. You're as good as anybody. So you're as good as anybody to influence the rules.

Stop relying on what will make you neither free nor equal. Be discontented with yourself and with others. Get rid of respect. Get down to the rules.

Disarm: yourselves and others. Negotiate: respect yourselves and others as people who negotiate. Learn what is necessary to make suggestions. Realize that you have privileges and accept that there are necessary compensations. Get organized. Wherever you are, whatever you do, whatever it means: get organized!

If a cooperation is not to your liking, negotiate. If the negotiation does not lead to a result that satisfies you, quit. If you cannot quit, split up as far as it is possible. If the result does not satisfy you, negotiate again. If they don't let you negotiate, put up pressure: restrict your cooperative activity, or give conditions for it. If they force you, use violence. Use as little and as reversible violence as possible, but as much as is needed. Remember that violence may mean very different things, and that its only purpose is to counter the force by which they give you neither negotiation nor a fair leave.

Respect no ownership, no control, no rules just because they exist. Do not demand this from others, though. Respect the fact that there will always be a given structure, but not the would-be right that is associated with it.

Organize all of your relationships — all private, political, social relationships, be it to individuals, to groups, to society — according to the idea of a relationship between people who consider themselves free and equal. People who are able to quit; who negotiate; who deny, cancel, take back, restrict, give conditions. Who do not always have to explain this. People who actually do it, and do it again.

Learn to appreciate this although it is not comfortable. It's the gate to the world, to a world that is more than you. Change ownership, control, and rules in a way that the price to quit or restrict the cooperation is similar and bearable for all members. Do not expect this to happen overnight. Do not wait for it to happen any time. Do not let them fob you off with promises that it will happen anyway.

Get organized. Put up pressure. And, again and again: negotiate.

That's all there is.

Do not believe anybody who tries to talk you into rules that he says will make this superfluous.

Remove everything that separates you from the possibility of living like that. Do not do it blindly. But do it thoroughly. Do not do it alone. If you do it alone, be careful.

Be radical: Do not leave out any of your relationships. Do not get frustrated. Go the whole nine yards.

Be the last. Don't bow.

THANKS

To Claude, to whom I owe the bigger half of all my writing, although she likes at best a third of it; and who more or less tolerates me when writing although she never needs more than 5,000 words herself.

To Renée and Alex, for object lessons in free cooperation.

To Heike Müller and Nina Albrecht at the Uni kindergarten, without whom I probably couldn't have finished.

To those who were the first to enable discussions and readings for me about free cooperation, above all to the *Friends of the Maquis*. And to the Rosa Luxemburg Foundation which, as a friendly gesture to all authors, took Rousseau's *second* treatise as an example — the one that did not “win.”

NOTE TO THE ENGLISH EDITION

It's six years now since I wrote the last pages of this essay, at a Turkish café on a very early morning at Berlin, where we had attended a conference and my family threw me out of the hotel room for my notorious snoring. I still remember the feeling; it felt as if I had just said everything.

New ideas are always in desperate need of friends, and free cooperation was lucky to find some. Geert Lovink and Trebor Scholz made unswerving efforts to introduce the essay and the theory of free cooperation to an international public, especially by inviting me to the glamorous “networks, arts & collaboration” conference in 2004 at Buffalo that made a lot of references to free cooperation. Jörg “Windy” Windszus with whom I share a long history of projects and collaborations showed me how interested B-movie monsters might be in free cooperation. Tony Conrad and Stephanie Rothenburg at Buffalo became friends not only to me, but to free cooperation, and from the bewildering collaboration between them, Windy and I brought forth the beautiful video “On Rules and Monsters — An Introduction to Free Cooperation.” Thanks and shouts, too, to Suse Lang, Dorothee Gestrinch, Paul Visco & Elmwood Strip flat, Tim Schomacher, Dirk Wahlers & Cattle who helped make the Buffalo trip a joy and a success.

On Geert's insistence I did a first translation of the essay myself.

Since then, the English version has been haunted by the ghosts of German grammar and perspective. Uche Nduka, poet and friend, was the first ghostbuster to go in and kill the most obvious mistakes. But the one who really claimed the haunted house to become an American property was Ben Meyers. He spent weeks and months there, learning its inner architecture with all hidden tunnels and traps, chasing German ghosts wherever he could find them, caring for amendments and explanations to make the text fully understandable for an American public. So if the essay still cannot deny its accent in thinking but has lost a lot of its accent in language, this is due to Ben and the fact that he fell in love for this project.

Jim Fleming, finally, made this possible by opening the gates of the strange land of Autonomedia to this publication. Which, I think, will behave fine there.

ENDNOTES

- 1 | Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *Treatise on the Origin and the Foundations of Inequality Among Men*, 1755, end of Part One.
- 2 | Thierry Foucher, “Vom Prinzchen, das immer Nein sagt,” in *Hoppla — Das Kindermagazin zum Mitmachen, Mitlachen, Mitlernen*. Weltbild Verlag, Augsburg, Nr. 115 – 4/1999, p. 42–45. I changed the animal species. In Foucher’s story they are three apes. Apes give the whole thing a racist touch (and the illustrations clearly indicate an African context: in Africa, they still have to learn the most basic things, it says) and, in the context of this introduction, would sound like cheap polemics. I prefer bears.
- 3 | Greg Dulli from The Afghan Whigs, in his deconstruction of the male individual, analyzes this as patriarchal fear: “You’ve got indecision / and indecision / is my enemy.” The Afghan Whigs, *Gentlemen*, title track, 1993.
- 4 | This essay was written as a contribution to a competition set up by the Rosa Luxemburg Foundation, Berlin, in 2000 on the question “Under which conditions can social equality and political freedom be compatible?” To my own astonishment, it won the competition.
- 5 | An expression for doing white magic and black magic, used in William Gibson, *Biochips*, 1986, Chapter 13, “With Both Hands.”
- 6 | Albert Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*, 1942, Part I, Chapter “Philosophical Suicide,” paragraphs “The turn to mystique” and “Kierkegaard’s jump.”
- 7 | Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, 1762, Book II, Chapter 5, “On the right about life and death.”
- 8 | Georg Büchner, *Danton’s Death*, 1835, I,1 (Camille).
- 9 | There is Mr. Rhineheart, and there is the question that drives us, the one about the matrix.
- 10 | Tucholsky writes about the many ways to kill a person: to take his money, to throw him out of his flat, etc.
- 11 | I’ve often been asked which image of man this implies. I can only emphasize that it is neither pessimistic nor optimistic, neither deterministic nor voluntaristic. We are not doomed to domination, but we are structurally very open for it. We may decide against it, collectively and personally, which is what a politics of free cooperation is all about; but quite usually, in the long run, we use virtually all we have to get domination. In my opinion, this is what is pointed out by poets like Octavia Butler (in *Xenogenesis*), as well as by anthropologists like Christopher Boehm (in *Hierarchy in the Forest*). You could call it “methodological pessimism” when it comes to domination. We

may be converted, but we cannot be trusted; we cannot be forced to do free cooperation, but we have to stay checked not to get rid of it. (You may like to compare my entry on “Hierarchy/Anti-Hierarchy” in the *Historical-Critical Dictionary of Marxism*, Vol. 5., Hamburg 2004.)

12 | Themba Sono, interview, in *Spiegel* 33/2000.

13 | On the concept of equality in American tradition see David Brion Davis, *Revolutions: Reflections on American Equality and Foreign Liberation*, Harvard 1990, Chapter I.

14 | Marx, *Zur Kritik der Hegelschen Rechtsphilosophie*, MEW 1, p. 385.

15 | Boris Vian, *Le Bâtisseurs d'Empire ou Le Schmürz* (*The Founders of the Empire or The Schmürz*), 1959. The *schmürz* is a being the other persons do not take any notice of but keep beating at random all the time, a doormat for the others. It is not allowed to speak nor does it intervene in the plot in any way.

16 | Engels, *Anti-Dühring*, MEW 20, p. 106.

17 | Marx, *Kapital*, Vol. 3, MEW 25, p. 868. Engels always tends to be more “German” in his emphasis on, even joy of necessity, whereas Marx usually gives it a more anarchist turn. He often underlines that communism is not about making work “fair” but to destroy it, to practically destroy the very notion of work as “working for” (cf. his *Kritik des Gothaer Programms*). But he, too, is kept within the boundaries of 19th century thought if he conceives this as the (technologically mediated) abolition of work, as he is kept within the boundaries of patriarchal ideology when he separates freedom from the precondition that somebody — and not a machine — is actually “working for,” is doing individual, collective or social reproduction. In his fundamental distrust of the great industry as a possible place for freedom he often sounds a bit like Lou Reed singing *Heroin*: “... away from the big cities, where a man can not be free.”

18 | In the late German Democratic Republic (GDR) there were attempts for a theoretical foundation of thought pluralism, organizational pluralism and institutional pluralistic democracy in Marxism, therefore to lay out an actual Marxist theory of conflict, and to envision reforms of the real-existing socialist state from it. The “change,” the end of the GDR, left these reflections without a chance of practical realization. Their influence on Western Marxism seems to be quite small today. The acceptance of the prevailing system of institutional representative democracy is still either based on anticommunism, i.e. on the experience of concentration of state power in really-existing socialism, or on Gramsci’s concept of a “Western way to socialism” combined with a notion of “civil society” adapted to the political mainstream. This sounds more modern and far-reaching, but in fact it is much more backward-minded. Within this

concept, “civil society” and pluralistic democracy easily appear as the global judges of right or wrong that are entitled to violently enforce this. Reformist Marxism in the late GDR, on the contrary, tended to a notion of social contradictions that could not be judged objectively because there was no “higher” standpoint from which such objectivity would be possible. The difference in politics showed in the contrary positions about NATO’s war of aggression against Yugoslavia and in the different standpoints about the neoliberal top-down social reforms.

19 | Article 2. For a more detailed interpretation of the Declaration see Walter Markov and Albert Soboul, 1789: *Die Große Revolution der Franzosen*, Berlin, 2nd edition 1980, p. 139 ff. Actually the Declaration tries to define a freedom that does not harm the prevailing social order. The right of property, in articles 2 and 17, is sanctioned as “unlimitationable,” “unviolable” and “holy,” the concrete liberties get concretely restricted as well. Markov and Soboul give the nice quotation by Loustalot in “Revolutions of Paris,” a magazine edited by Prudhomme, nr. 8: “We advanced fast from slavery to freedom, we shall advance even faster from freedom to slavery.”

20 | “There is nothing unjust about the great advantages of the few, if thereby things improve for the disadvantaged, too.” This principle, combined with a formal equality of basic rights and duties, “might be a fair basis for the more gifted or socially privileged — which both can not be seen as their merit — to count on the willing cooperation of the others, if a functionary solution is a necessary condition for the welfare of all.” John Rawls, *A Theory of Justice*.

Rawls’ quest for “the principles that free and equal persons under fair conditions would accept” is something completely different from Rousseau’s question in *Social Contract*, how people under the conditions of their socializing could stay as free and equal as before. The concept of “fairness” has three main restrictions of freedom and equality: whether society is “fair” is subject to objective examination, it can be “recognized”; the members of a cooperation are not free to quit, to limit their cooperative activity, or to negotiate anew about it; a politics to identify and contain means of domination is not seen as necessary because there is no domination in Rawls’ theory.

These three restrictions are typical for most of the contemporary political theories that talk about social “fairness” instead of equality. All three are rejected by the theory of free cooperation.

21 | Cf. Marx, *Kritik des Gothaer Programms*, MEW 19, p. 21.

22 | The coincidence of freedom and equality (in a radical sense) is actually part of the tradition of both terms. “For the French in 1789 freedom and equality were inseparably connected, really two words meaning the same. If they had to choose, equality would be the most important for them, and when the peasants (who were by far the majority) cheered freedom, they thought of the abolition of the landowner’s power who now should be a plain citizen.”

Georges Lefebvre, 1789. *The Year of Revolution*, Munich 1989, p. 195.

23 | Tracy Chapman, “Fast Car,” on the album “Tracy Chapman,” 1988.

24 | Freedom and equality in cooperation is not the same as what is often described as “having a choice.” It is not the point that we may have biographical choices in a social supermarket of possibilities — e.g., between career woman and mother. This neoliberal “freedom of choice” is nothing but a “pluralistic-prescriptive” politics: we may choose between two life models, but we do not have influence on the rules. We “buy” a ready-made package that we have to accept just as it is.

25 | Libreria delle donne di Milano, *Non credere di avere dei diritti*, Turin 1987. For the development of this approach in Italian feminism see also: Rosalba Spagnoletti (ed.), *I movimenti femministi in Italia*, Roma 1971; B. Frabotta (ed.), *La politica del femminismo*, Roma 1976; *Lotta continua*, *Il 2.congresso*, Roma 1976.

26 | Contemporary Western philosophy is mainly occupied with the problem of how you can state objective claims of validity in spite of the critique of Western conceptions of rationality and of Western universalism — this is how the power of the existing rules can be defended not only by weapons, but by arguments, too. To achieve this, many such theories use sleight of hand like “necessary preconditions,” “implicit approval,” “logically inherent consequences,” etc., to find a universalistic meta-rationality whose claims and impositions cannot be rejected by single actors. If you are against it, you only contradict yourself and may be legitimately and violently corrected. This is how Habermas defended the US aggression that was called the Second Gulf War.

27 | Phil Alden Robinson, *Sneakers*, USA 1991.

28 | “The two rapes during the Brixton Riots in 1985 underline this point. In the women’s magazine *Monochrome* a woman reported how she was treated as spoils of war and that she felt more safe fighting the cops than afterwards in the police-free area. Bad thing for a liberated area ... The question what we really gonna do if the cops have fucked off was almost totally ignored by the street revolutionaries so far.” Anonymous, “What do we do when the cops fuck off?” in *Class War*, London 1991.

29 | Redaktion alaska, 150° west, 60° north. “Taking a stand beyond New Internationalism,” in *Alaska 223*, Bremen 1998.

30 | The scene appears only in David Fincher’s movie. It is not contained in the novel by Chuck Palahniuk that the script was based on.

31 | Maivân Clech Lâm calls the belief that names and symbolic gestures might be more important than the real practice behind it, the “magical” practices of White feminism. M.C.Lâm, “Feeling Foreign in Feminism,” in *Signs*,

Vol. 19, no. 4, Summer 1994, p. 879 ff.

32 | I know that this is one of the passages that may really make you sick because it talks so disgustingly remotely about the fights and emotions of real social emancipation. It may be added that of course it is the original achievement of real emancipation movements and of real people (and not of a generalizing theory) that we can talk about such strange (and often necessary) phases.

33 | This was Gero von Randow's argument against the theory of free cooperation in his review of my *Aliens* book: "Aren't these normative criteria again, and who's setting the norm then?" G. v. Randow, "Neues von links," in *Zeit* no.1, 12/29/1999.

34 | In mathematics this insight is mainly associated with Gödel's works. In postmodern philosophy it is pointed out that theory thus immediately becomes a question of power relations. "Knowledge and power are two sides of the same question: Who decides what is knowledge and who knows what is to be decided? In the age of informational science, the question of knowledge more than ever is the question of government." Jean-François Lyotard, *La Condition Postmodern*, Paris 1979, Chapter 2: "Legitimation" (last sentence).

35 | Foucault's concept of discourse emphasizes that there is no strict separation between theory and practice, concept and action, philosophy and everyday life. On our way from bed to coffee machine we pass various conceptualizations regarding workfare society, body-management, pleasure principle vs. delayed satisfaction of needs, use of machines — including the simple assumption that the coffee is still standing where we left it yesterday evening.

36 | This is to say that the very meaning of "reality" is that our conceptions are constantly subject to contradictions and change. The idea of an "outside" is a metaphoric expression of this experience.

37 | Thomas S. Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, Chicago 1962.

38 | Also the dominant theories and conceptualizations of experience are nothing more than translation and coalition. The frequent popularist appeals "not to be deceived" disguise exactly that. If we are in complete congruence with the dominant conceptualizations we get the impression that we would see things "as they are" — which is the ultimate ideology.

39 | Gayatri Spivak et al., "The Post-modern Condition: The End of Politics?" in Spivak, *The Post-Colonial Critic*, New York 1990, p. 17 ff.

40 | This is Ernesto Laclau's argument in *Beyond Emancipation*: That theories of emancipation are paradoxical does not mean they couldn't change practice ("Beyond Emancipation," in Laclau, *Emancipation(s)*, London 1996, p. 1 ff.). In Marxist tradition, that "the teacher has to be taught" is a well-known para-

dox, cf. Marx, *Theses on Feuerbach*.

41 | Anne Huffschnid, "Die Zapatistinnen — wer sie sind und wofür sie kämpfen," in Andreas Simmen (ed.), *Mexico. Aufstand in Chiapas*, Berlin 1994, p. 118; Guiomar Rovira, "Indigene Frauen und die EZLN," in Hanna Mittelstädt and Lutz Schulenburg, *Der Wind der Veränderung*, Hamburg 1997. See also the Revolutionary Women's Law, published by the EZLN in its magazine "The revolutionary alarm clock," December 1993, together with the EZLN's other Revolutionary Laws. Like most other revolts, the experience of Chiapas shows that taking up revolution or not is a very serious question from a women's perspective. Anne Huffschnid also cites the lawyer Martha Figuero from the San Cristóbal Women's Centre, who reports the typical increase of rapes since the beginning of the revolt.

42 | The concept of the avant-garde doesn't have especially good press today. But this is thoroughly unsatisfactory. It is correct to distance oneself from all positions that award organizations a privileged cognition in contrast to "the masses." But there is definitely a need for people and cooperations to push through another logic of the social and to develop it further; a need for people and cooperations that experiment with ever-new forms that are not part of common heritage. A need for an avant-garde, in the sense of what Mamphele Ramphele says about gender relations:

Successful transformation of gender relationships will need more than just a theoretical understanding of the problem. It requires courage and the determination to take risks, because there is no possibility of growth without pain. Both men and women will have to confront their own fears of exchanging the known for the unknown, and put tradition at risk before a new pattern of gender relations can emerge. (M. Ramphele, "The Dynamics of Gender Within Black Consciousness Organisations. A Personal View," in Barney Pityana et al., *Bounds of Possibility. The Legacy of Steve Biko and Black Consciousness*, Cape Town 1991, p. 227.)

This is exactly the stale after-taste of ritualized anti-avant-gardism: that it is really a cover for insecurity and immobility, that it only rationalizes a lack of courage and of determination to take the risks needed, if we want to be "more equal than others."

43 | On the contrary, game theory is very instructive about the relationships between cooperation, strategies and change of social environments. The relative success of cooperative strategies like "tit for tat" in computer simulations of social cooperation is known since Robert Axelrod, *The Evolution of Cooperation*, New York 1994. More recent research has also included the feature of leaving a cooperation (which comes close to a free cooperation approach) and investigates long-term evolution of cooperative environments and its depend-

ency on the initial mixture of given cooperative strategies (which takes up in a way the issue of left politics, i.e., to influence the social environment as a precondition of free strategic choice; demonstrates the relative power of master-slave couples when introduced into the social environment; and very recently tends to emphasize the issue of “recognition” between different actors). Jean-Paul Delahaye and Philippe Mathieu, “Altruismus mit Kündigungsmöglichkeit,” in *Spektrum der Wissenschaft* 2/1998, p. 8 ff.; see also the site <http://www.lifl.fr/IPD/ipd.html.en>. It should not be forgotten that there is always a difference between this kind of research and a free cooperation approach in society, namely, the point that according to free cooperation theory there are no generally valid norms of efficiency, success and “rational choice.” However, you will find many correspondences between advanced research into game theory or the itinerate prisoner’s dilemma and the considerations in Part Three of this essay.

44 | It is an expression of today’s derogation of humans and of the social that stock-markets may be “sensitive” while humans have to be “able to cope with pressure”; that everybody is told to stay away from the terribly “complex” economic circuits while humans are expected to bear permanent intervention in the name of flexibility.

45 | Roger Burbach, Orlando Núñez and Boris Kagarlitsky, *Globalization and its Discontents. The Rise of Postmodern Socialisms*, London 1997. Laclau and Mouffe use the term “post-marxist,” in the double sense of “beyond Marxism” and “further development of Marxism.” Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe, *Hegemony and Socialist Strategy: Towards a Radical Democratic Politics*, 2nd ed. London 1996.

46 | Spivak, “The Post-Modern Condition.”

47 | The debate on “defensive defense” (the structural transformation of military defense systems that leaves them well-suited for actual defense but ill-equipped for aggression) emerged in the times of the Cold War, and has disappeared almost without a trace after the rise of the “new world order.” But it has not lost its relevance to the present. And it’s really interesting to discuss, for example, organizational structures in terms of a board’s “structural inability for aggression” against member minorities.

48 | For a coma patient we try to reconstruct the decisions he/she would have taken; this is an extreme situation. In a lot of situations where people are not sufficiently articulated for their environment we can fall back on collective articulations that at any rate are better than our own guessing. There are little children that we cannot dispute with as we like, but there are bigger children, too, that can make us realize where we’re wrong with our rationality. There is the movement of disabled people which we should consult before deciding over the head of someone whose articulation we do not understand sufficient-

ly. It's collective articulation that is pushed aside when the cheap argument is started "who knows what they want, anyway" — women, Chinese, aliens...

49 | If we end a love relationship we don't need to make any offers unless we have children, because to them there is no similar and bearable alternative to us for a long time. ("So don't forget, folks / That's what you get, folks / From makin' whoopee.")

50 | This is always the vital difference — between laws on how large the toilet has to be in a firm and institutionalized forms of workers' control: direct influence of the workers on the rules and processes inside the company. Between payment for housework and economic security for women leaving the place of their housework behind.

51 | Not every cooperation has a budget; but everything having a budget is definitely a cooperation.

52 | In Germany, you get a three-month freeze of unemployment benefit if you quit instead of being fired.

53 | Squatting of land is therefore the complement of the struggles for a qualitative sufficient basic income in industrialized countries. It is often said for developing countries that existence-securing attribution of land for all is not possible because it would leave no space for bigger projects and prevent development. At the same time it is said that those "bigger projects" are not able to finance a general existence-security by tax or duty. Taken together, this means that what is defended here as "development" is just increase of capital by impoverishment of the people — which is often exactly what happens. The chapter here takes industrialized countries in democratic capitalism as a starting point, but you can take other starting points as well. In really-existing socialism, the idea of the company as free cooperation would aim at an interpretation of the state's role as a silent partner, giving a contribution but not dictating the rules. In agriculture-dominated systems it would aim at a kind of agrarian reform that creates neither the complete division of land nor the implementation of hierarchical, efficiency-oriented collective combines but install collectively owned farms whose members would be free to decide how to use them and how to structure themselves.

54 | The MAI (Multilateral Agreement on Investment), whose draft was revealed by the social movements in 1997/1998 and was taken back after a global wave of protests against it, was precisely designed to deprive the countries targeted for foreign investment of every possibility of negotiation and agency. See Maria Mies and Claudia von Werlhof (eds.), *Lizenz zum Plündern*, Hamburg 1998.

55 | A beautiful definition of the difference between formal and precarious work, by Solomon Quayle, a Berlin taxi driver: "When I came to Germany,

I first had only jobs where I had to ask for permission if I wanted to pee.”
Spiegel, 10/2000, p. 47.

56 | Richard Douthwaite, *Short Circuit. Strengthening Local Economies for Security in an Unstable World*, Dublin 1996.

57 | Kafka portrays the modern age as a social world where there is no negotiating. This makes up the horror that we feel in the world he describes. The postmodern critique, on the other hand, makes negotiating the central practice. It is the “positive” consequence of the “negative” denial of claims of absolute validity. If we have something to negotiate, then at least we have some ground to stand. That’s why prisoners say that their personal situation changed sustainably after their first hunger strike, that it kept them literally from going mad. The modern “no negotiations!” reverberates up to the politics of “fortezza” that the NATO governments prescribed mutually for themselves in the conflict with political terrorism in the 1970s.

58 | cf. Gustavo Esteva, “Development,” in Wolfgang Sachs (ed), *The Development Dictionary. A Guide to Knowledge as Power*, London 1992, chapter “The Rule of Scarcity.”

59 | cf. Gérald Berthoult, “Market,” in Wolfgang Sachs, *The Development Dictionary*; Karl Polanyi, *The Great Transformation*, London 1944.

60 | bell hooks, “Postmodern Blackness,” in bell hooks, *Yearning*, Boston 1990.

61 | “The acknowledgment of differences among and between diasporic subjects cannot take place according to a binary division between me and not-me. In my view, you do not have to go there.” Kobena Mercer, “Decolonisation and Disappointment. Reading Fanon’s Sexual Politics,” in Alan Reed (ed.), *The Fact of Blackness. Frantz Fanon and Visual Representation*, London and Seattle 1996, p. 122.

62 | This is what Spivak drives at, saying, “Try to behave as if you are part of the margin,” (and adding: “In the language of commercials, one would say: Try it, you might like it.”) Spivak, “The Post-Modern Condition,” p. 30.

63 | Gayatri Spivak, “Criticism, Feminism and the Institution,” in *The Post-Colonial Critic*, p. 9. To unlearn our privileges and to recognize them as deficits means first to realize that we have privileges, i.e. that we actually profit from the oppression and exclusion of others; second, to understand how these privileges subjectively hinder and stultify us in our understanding of the world and our cooperation with others; third, that we try to clear away, together with others, the respective structure of privilege in social reality. If we skip one of these elements it all goes wrong.

64 | Steve Biko, “What is Black Consciousness?” in *I Write What I Like*,

Oxford 1987, p. 99 f.

65 | “Self-instruction” (“autoincarico”) is reported to be a creative practice of Italian workmen. It means looking out for objects in need of repair, repair them on one’s initiative and then charge it to the owner’s account. The last, however, can be rectified by the theory of free cooperation only with some reservations. Werner Raith, “Handwerkers Gewinnsteigerung,” *taz* Nr. 4116, 9/20/1993.

66 | I strongly recommend reading the whole trilogy: in my perspective it deals with a lot of issues that this essay is about.

67 | Andy and Larry Wachowski, “The Matrix.”

68 | Claudia Bernhard, “Zur Kritik der historischen Demokratie,” in Schwertfisch (ed.), *Zeitgeist mit Gräten. Politische Perspektiven zwischen Ökologie und Autonomie*, Bremen 1997, p. 222.

69 | Natalie S. Glance and Bernardo A. Huberman: “Das Schmarotzer-Dilemma,” in *Spektrum der Wissenschaft* 5/1994, p. 36 ff.

70 | The idea of “equal opportunities” tries to preserve the dominant rules and the world they created by making “exceptions” — the game is supposed to stay the same, only that all pieces now start from the same field. However, since some of the pieces designed and shaped the game, its rules fit well for these pieces and not so well for other pieces. In the end, the same pieces win as it always has been. In practice, a politics of equal opportunities does not even try to make all pieces start from the same field (which would mean, after all, that every generation starts with a completely leveled structure of income, property and disposal) but makes do with pushing some of the pieces in the back a little bit nearer to the pieces that start in front.

71 | Poetic injustice is not only a symbolic or pedagogic action, as Cheryl Bernard suggests, taking up the absolute ban of speech for men at the first “Women’s Rights Convention” at Salem in 1850 as an example: “Much of the strategy of oppositional movements seems to have this aim: to give the superiors the experience of oppression, of generalization, of prejudice, of violence that hits the individual not as a person but as a member of a category that is decreed from outside — and with experience empathy, critical faculties, insight.” (Cheryl Bernard, *Die geschlossene Gesellschaft und ihre Rebellen. Die internationale Frauenbewegung und die Schwarze Bewegung in den USA*, Frankfurt/Main 1981, p. 190.) It is not about acts of pedagogy, it’s about quite material aspects of self-defense. Members of a privileged group are like oil: a drop of it can ruin a whole hall’s debate.

72 | Ludovica Scarpa, “Long Live State Bankruptcy. Long Live Italy!” in *Ästhetik und Kommunikation*, nr. 93, October 1996, p. 45.

73 | Adrienne Rich, "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence," in *Signs*, Vol. 4, Summer 1980.

74 | Gayatri Spivak, "The Post-Modern Condition," p. 22. Spivak writes that she would cite Derrida, but I don't know what she is referring to.

75 | Zapatismo says "It is not necessary to conquer the world; it's enough that we re-invent it."

76 | The "economy" is not left aside here. But calling some conflicts "economic" falsely suggests all other conflicts are non-economic. According to the understanding of economy that is used here, conflicts about rules are always economic conflicts as well because they include conflict about the distribution and disposal of social or cooperative capital.

77 | Jacques Derrida, "Remarks on Deconstruction and Pragmatism," in Chantal Mouffe (ed.), *Deconstruction und Pragmatism*, London 1996.

78 | It is noteworthy that the term "intervention" has become popular as "critical intervention" (which, in art, science and movement politics often relates to what is intended in this chapter, and replaced terms like "action") and "military intervention" (which is quite the opposite of what is intended here, and replaced terms like "war," "defense," or "liberation"). This hints at some real connection and to the fact that neoliberalism, too, deals with the problem that dominant politics cannot represent everything and steer everything in detail.

Times have changed; the powers that be are unchallengeable in bombing but fail when they try to really occupy a country; they are very good with invisible hands (politically, economically, culturally) but have to accept that they can not really "grasp" things themselves in any case. But this should remind us that we have to be critical about our own critical interventions, to closely examine where they may contain elements of violence, dominance and ignorance, and to be open for critique from the ones concerned.

79 | Audre Lorde, "The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action," in *Sister Outsider. Essays and Speeches*, Freedom 1984, p. 41.

80 | This is why we should be suspicious about any quick dismissal of the complicated as nonsense. It is easy to talk straight if you talk in accordance with the dominant rules and enjoy their privileges. But if we want to articulate critique and emancipatory claims we have to take some time and go to the trouble of mutual listening and trying to understand.

81 | Marx uses the metaphor that you have to play their own music to bring them to dance, but this lacks a bit of the existential dimension of the individuals that are bound in silence. We have to imagine the whole process today as daring, as difficult and happening on a trial basis, as something you cannot objectively derive.

82 | Libreria delle donne di Milano, *Non credere di avere dei diritti*, Turin 1987, p. 141.

83 | This is the solution, too, to this well-known paradox: if there can be a motivation to support a cause that attacks and abolishes our own privileges (e.g., as males, whites, heteros or heteras, privileges according to our country of birth, our income or property etc.). There is a personal gain for us, but this gain is not “rational” according to the dominant rules and dominant “rationality” (if it were, there would be something wrong). So the key question that has to be scrutinized and controlled with constant suspicion is not if such a motivation can be possible, but if the personal gain that is achieved here is the right kind of gain, and not one of modern exploitation.

84 | This should not give the impression of looking down on actual emancipation processes. There are reasons for immediate action, active self-defense, eruptive processes and uncompromising personal stands. Usually there is no “calm” way to break and challenge the rules. But getting organized politically, as it is understood here, goes beyond that and signifies a simultaneous other dimension without which it can’t be done.

THE SEMIOTICS OF CONFERENCING

EXPERIMENT, PLAY, REFLECT

Geert Lovink & Trebor Scholz

PREFACE

This book resulted out of the Free Cooperation conference. We decided to include the following piece on methods of event organizing. The text also offers a background of the event itself. We wrote it as a reflection about the Free Cooperation conference for the Austrian art magazine *Springerin*¹. People love conferences. They can't get enough of all the offline events on offer. Like festivals, conferences are venues where you can meet future collaborators, debate ideas and artworks, party intensely, get inspired, provoked, learn, and make new friends. Occasionally you can carry on the dialogue in the sauna. At conferences there is an opportunity for people who can't meet otherwise, to spend a few days together away from their obligations, focusing in on ideas. These venues are sold as places where we linger between intellectual experiences and blissful moments of regeneration of our bat-

teries. Today, the event industry is an integral part of the shopping-driven locative spectacle. These professional assemblies are useful to stay tuned-in to the up-to-the-minute buzzwords, concepts and software of the creative worker. This is especially true in the face of the increasing pressure on the “precariarized” tech laborer. Conferences have all the social ingredients to be exciting. But most events make participants sit through conventional and unreflected formats. In this essay we ask why this is the case. We propose alternative models to disrupt and invigorate the discursive, social machine. Beyond good or evil, conferences are here to stay, so they better be good.

CRITIQUE OF PANELISM

For a moment let's not focus on what people love. We were always looking for conferences that are liberated from keynote speeches and panels. It's a big relief to be faced with presenters who argue freely. It is reassuring if speakers are brief and leave ample time for questions from the audience. Such presenters will focus on the points raised by the chair of a session. Event formats and the vocabulary that we use lock us not only into structures but also impact the way we develop content. In the age of the Internet 'rhetoric', we can feel free to move on, away from reading a 'paper.' Many distributed and collaborative forms of discourse production, discussion and dispute are available to us. The ritualized academic structure of panels and the non-communicative form of the keynote speaker feed into the celebrity system reinforcing hegemonic paradigms that get in the way of hearing genuine dialogue and diverse, emerging voices. Some will read this criticism as an attack on the university community as a whole. We disagree. Academics are not a species in danger of extinction and it is time to get out of the defensive mode. Panelism is part of the dark side of 'academism.' It needs to be addressed precisely because it is spilling over to other contexts such as the arts, culture, new media and even activism.

Many conferences turn into somewhat tragic events in which artists have to participate in scientific formats in order to contribute. In part this is an effect of the forced 'edufication' of the arts, particularly in the

United States, but increasingly also in countries such as Australia, Canada and the United Kingdom. Within the American university, obsessed with ‘excellence’ language and research formats in the arts are modeled increasingly after the business logic of the sciences.² People who decide about grants in turn are looking at the military-industrial complex that supports academe to an ever-growing extent. The possibility of failure, even in the sciences becomes almost impossible due to an all-powerful result imperative. Instead of addressing this topic directly, a culture of academic simulation is being introduced in which a wide range, from designers, programmers and activists to media artists are persuaded to respond to a ‘call for papers.’ They motivate each other to submit a ‘proposal for a panel.’ They even have to buy into the dirty business of (blind) peer reviewing, and enforced, overly lengthy citations. All this with the mere result of getting something ‘published’ on a website or in a deadwood journal with a prohibitive subscription price.

Increasingly, dull science formats are imposed on the arts. Mind you, these are mostly unnecessary, ‘alien’ formats that no one would come up with on their own. There is by no means a widespread or even ‘natural’ desire amongst artists to sit on panels or write ‘papers.’ In fact, these formats are disdained. But they’re hard to resist nonetheless. We do not suggest that artists cannot speak for themselves. We do not argue that cultural producers should not be involved in practices embracing theory and production, or arts and sciences. But we do question the forced adaptation of scientific formats. We argue that it is high time to bring these issues to public awareness. We need to openly talk about it! Let’s label the occurring tendencies properly: paperism and panelism!

What’s so bad about three or four people, each sitting on their cyber islands, introduced by an ill-informed chair of the session sitting almost out of sight of the muted audience? Does it matter that the panelists do not know each other and have not seen let alone read each other’s ‘papers’? Should we be concerned that there was hardly time for questions? Hell, yes! Who cares? Exactly. We do. We, the audience, are those who care. We have to say no to the supermarket mentality in which both “patrons” and presenters are merely shopping around, not showing up on panels, are clearly programmed in the wrong section of

the program or have no ability, or even wish, to address the handful of people in the hall in a clear manner.

The source of 'panelism' is the conference organizers! It is not the speakers, let alone the audience that should be blamed. Panelism expresses laziness and a lack of creative thinking about suitable formats for (discursive) scenarios. Panelism is often an indication that too many people have been involved in the decision-making process. The panel structure is the flipside of justified attempts to be more inclusive and have as many speakers as possible. But that doesn't always result in interesting events. The best conferences are being produced by a small team of both researchers and producers that closely collaborate. Events curated by one individual, such as *Ars Electronica*, have the tendency to become narrow and repetitive and develop an informal circuit of guessing and gossiping around the intentions of this one person, much like *Documenta* and the tired Biennial system with its small group of circulating curators.

The worst panels are those at which speakers really have no clue why they are in the same session. Or ask yourself if you ever witnessed this situation: a competitive, slightly discombobulated atmosphere arises when the first speaker goes over her time limit. Then the second presenter does the same, leaving no time for the last one. A variation of this plot would be the case in which the last speaker 'eats up' all the remaining time for questions. Another prevailing pattern is the fact that the last speaker gets most of the questions as the audience has forgotten what the previous panelists had to say. A good moderator can only partially solve these problems. The all-too-human qualities of certain subjects is not the key issue here. We denounce the gaping uninvolved and vague approach of most organizers. The targeted key issues for debate are repeatedly no more than a haze of question marks! The audience in response develops a vague, derive-like 'surfing' attitude towards such a capricious 'collage' of knowledge. This mechanism was well-described by Marshall McLuhan. There is no compelling reason for panel members to limit the discussion to their round of experts. The audience is surely made up of some people with considerable, relevant expertise. Why care if you do not have the slightest idea why you are in

same session? Do you have a jacuzzi in your hotel room? Usually the panelists have been introduced minutes before they start and can barely remember each other's name. And while all this happens the audience sits as a silent block in the dark. Their faces are illuminated by the screens of their laptops or PDAs. They may check email, live blog, or follow the virtual wandering of the speaker. Their cellphones harness moments of boredom.

Did we miss something? Perhaps it's just us. Maybe only the events that we attended had nothing at stake. It could be that there is a universal human right to present one's paper in public. Conceivably it is a good thing that academics are forced to present their work in publicly. Who knows. Patient event-goers revealed to us that science should be seen as a bazaar full of mediocre but necessary products. It's democracy, brother! You have to dig deep to find the precious gems. Noise to signal ratios are varying greatly. Mostly you are jetlagged anyway, and filtering becomes inevitable. Accentuated "keynote" speeches do not make up for the tragedy of panelism. They are part of the same problem. They try to compensate for the middle-of-the-road methodology that creates artificial eminence. Reputation is nothing innate—it has to be built. The keynote system is an ideal vehicle to do so.

THE SEARCH FOR ALTERNATIVES

Before we slide into that rigorous, engrossing negativism, let's focus on alternatives. The Free Cooperation conference³ took place on a campus of the State University of New York, Buffalo, late April 2004. The topic of the event was the art of (online) collaboration. From cell phones to email, multiplayer online games, mailing lists, weblogs⁴, and wikis⁵ our everyday lives are increasingly enmeshed with technology. This at least is true for societies benefiting from the globalization of the information order. The necessity to examine what happens when we collaborate in these technological channels through which we communicate will soon become more apparent. How can we find independence and more autonomy in a context of networked social machines?

We invited the Bremen-based media critic Christoph Spehr. He

coined the term “Free Cooperation” in his essay “Gleicher als andere” (More Equal Than the Other). Spehr’s writings had not yet been translated into English and this event was an opportunity to introduce his ideas into anglophone media discourses. Spehr uses references to 1960s Sci-Fi movies to think about contemporary cooperation insisting on the option of refusal, independence, negotiation and re-negotiation with alien corporate or state monsters. Focusing on these ideas of equality and freedom the conference asked how they can be made useful for self-organized networks.

We modeled the conference scenario after the dramaturgic structure of a Brechtian play. The somewhat staged environments of the event were rather theatrical. We tried to crush all hopes for panelism junkies. New structures had to emerge. Our mantra “no lectures, no panels” took a long time to sink in and some people just did not get it. While we put up these fences the event had to still be open and inviting. At present there is no lack of alternative event formats. It is pure nonsense to state that only keynotes plus panels can make up a good conference. All it takes is the willingness to experiment, undaunted by the prospect of failure!

At Free Cooperation, in a talk show-style session participants impersonated sci-fi filmmakers, scientists, and “flexible personalities.” They were accompanied by musical intermezzos on Tony Conrad’s “phonarmonica.”⁶ Remote guests commented on the debate via Internet Relay Chat. In the event flow we included an intimate talkathon (four hours, one room, two speakers, eight people in the audience at a time), a few dialogues, performances, a conference radio, a video conference in tandem with remote desktop, a game about games, streamed net radio discussions, brainstorming sessions, film screenings, a small exhibition, several workshops, a turntablist collaboration, and one monologue. There were no keynote speakers and, obviously, no panels, which worked well in particular because the topic was collaboration. We explicitly asked participants not to deliver long lectures, aiming at a more dialogical format. This approach irked some of the participants who usually walk on red carpets. But it was perfect for those who were willing to mindfully contribute to the entirety of the event. They briefly pre-

sented a summation of their thoughts and were then open enough to engage in debate.

There were no top-down auditoriums at Free Cooperation. Venues for the event were organized with seating in circular shapes. Large gatherings like this are good opportunities for students and locals to build their own networks. Relationships that they build here may become fruitful for them in the future. Here you meet other students, artist friends or cultural critics. These human encounters may in the end turn out to be more formative than regimented coursework.

On the outset of the organization of an event the question of duration needs to be asked. Is this a half-day, one day, two day or week-long event? Could it be better realized as networked program, for example, on the AccessGrid⁷ or in iChat. Don't underestimate the amount of work that the endeavor will take. You will need help. In our case, we met several times at media festivals to talk in person. For the seven months during which we actively organized Free Cooperation, Trebor was on location in Buffalo and Geert contributed from Australia. Many of the daily decisions were made through email. A group of graduate students at the Department of Media Study volunteered. It's pertinent to be very clear about the pay-off for all involved—the host institution, volunteers, participants and organizers. For us, this event-based cultural practice was rewarding as it gave the opportunity to spotlight the critical topic of online collaboration, play with event formats, to create discourse and resources pertaining to the issue.

How can you avoid overloading individuals with work and maintain a sense of more-or-less Free Cooperation in a context of next-to-no funding for culture in the United States? In the enthusiasm of organizing one can get carried away and might make promises that will cause disappointments later.

Event planning needs to start early. Discussions and fund raising should start at least one year before a large-scale event. We began by carefully deciding on a date, cross-checking with university calendars and public holidays. Often in US academia the planning time for big conferences takes up to two years. The problem with organizing a new media event in this manner is that the topics may not be as current by

the time the event takes place. When deciding on a city for the event location does not always matter. People are willing to travel to off-the-map places to have captivating discussions. At the crux of the success of an event, however, is that all parts of the conference take place in one location! This is not always possible. But organizers should be aware that splitting event venues gets disorienting, especially for jet-lagged international participants. They will find it tiring to take costly taxis to get around. It will wear them out to figure out where all these venues are and when things start. In addition, frequently sessions take place at the same time, which makes it impossible to be present at every session one is interested in.

Arriving at events with hundreds or even thousands of speakers, it is challenging to connect with those attendees with whom one wanted to talk for a long time. Name tags are half-concealed by bags or coats making for a strange detective game. A free/open source application could serve to connect people. Photos could be put up. Essays could be pre-published. People would recognize each other and more connections would be made.

When organizing the Free Cooperation conference we were overwhelmed by the large numbers of proposals that we received in response to our call. We read the submissions, deciding based on their relevance to what we set out to organize. Like Phil Agre, media critic at The University of California Los Angeles, who remarks this in a text about the organization of conferences⁸, we were uncomfortable selecting on the basis of already established reputations in the field or an old boys network because this simply re-inscribes the circulation of a virtual class. The same voices are heard over and over again. We decided based on proposals that led us to program undergraduate students next to established media artists and theorists. We also chose participants whom we got to know on the preparatory mailing list. The main question was if the proposed presentation would fit into the thematic framework of the conference. We emphasized that we looked for reflections on collaboration rather than mere demos of projects.

Our advice: be careful when you consider whom you will invite. Ideally meet with each potential presenter. Which format would fit

their personality best? Is it the more intimate setting of a workshop or the rather polemic format of the roundtable? Try to imagine the best number of people for each workshop or session. This is a difficult task when you don't know how many people will attend the overall event. In the current political climate in the United States it causes an immense amount of paperwork to invite international speakers. We decided to pay mainly for participants who were not employed in American academia.

The chart of the dramaturgical flow of the conference followed the structure of Brechtian plays. Intensive energy (talk show, debate-intensive sessions) was planned for the first day, and then again towards the end of the second. When setting up a mailing list try to have full control over it. Also secure the list archive. Don't use list services offered by commercial enterprises as this has the potential for disaster (i.e. unbearable amounts of advertisement are suddenly added to posts). Shortly after we initiated the mailing list we announced that we'll close it down a month or two after the event not intending to run this as a mailing list beyond the event. Seven months prior to Free Cooperation the mailing list became a useful tool to enter into debate. People briefly introduced themselves, posted texts, pointed to collaboration theory, and collective art projects. Short posts containing one argument seemed to work best to start up discussion.

Results are pivotal for events. What do you want the participants to take away from the event? Positive networking and the exchange of ideas always take place but what can you do to go beyond that? For the Free Cooperation conference we edited a theory newspaper, simply designed, that was launched on the first night of the event. We printed a large number of copies (8000), some of which participants took home with them and the rest was distributed locally and throughout new media institutions. We created a DVD that besides short video impressions of the conference sessions also included interviews with conference participants, and a video by Christoph Spehr and Jörg Windszus. The conference website, created with the helpful free software package Open Conference Systems (OCS)⁹ simplified some of the registration issues but was also limiting as too many non-customizable features were

based on the needs of traditional academic conferences. The conference Wiki became a rich repository for ideas, and a growing archive about (online) collaboration. Out of the conference emerged the Institute for Distributed Creativity¹⁰ and the Institute for Network Cultures¹¹.

How many times have we tried to replace proprietary software such as “Powerpoint” or “Keynote” but had to surrender as packages such as OpenOffice¹² did not have the necessary features or were not reliable enough? We can’t wait for stable open source tools for presentation.

Event facilitators often start with three or four topics. Then they think of participants. They make sure that they are good speakers with engaging presentations. They also consider geographical diversity (local vs. inter/national) to avoid isolating the event from its surroundings. Nobody wants an alien starship to land in one’s community. In this balancing act between ideas, equal representation of gender, minorities and available finances, the focus on a few specific topics easily gets lost and events become unfocused. The challenge is to avoid the tokenism of the multicultural spectacle while still achieving the much-needed representation! Globalization has yet to arrive at many cultural/new media arts events. One of the ways to speed up diversity is to question dominant organization formats and to introduce basic forms of reciprocity and dialogue.

ENDNOTES:

1 | Trebor Scholz & Geert Lovink, *Kleines Konferenz-ABC*, Springerin, Band X Heft 4, Winter 2004, pp. 56-59.

2 | Readings, B. (1999). *The University in Ruins*. 4th ed. United States: Harvard University Press.

3 | The “networks, art, and collaboration” conference, a.k.a. Free Cooperation, took place in April 2004 at the Department of Media Study, The State University of New York at Buffalo. The conference was organized by Trebor Scholz (New York/Buffalo) and Geert Lovink (Amsterdam), assisted (in more or less Free Cooperation) by Dorothee Gestrich (now Banff Centre) and Orkan Telhan (Ankara/ Buffalo), Tom Leonhardt (Toronto/ Buffalo) and Arzu Telhan (Ankara/ Buffalo). URL: <http://freecooperation.org>.

4 | “A weblog, or simply a blog, is a web application which contains periodic, reverse chronologically ordered posts on a common webpage. Such a web site would typically be accessible to any Internet user. Part of the reason ‘blog’ was coined and commonly accepted into use is the fact that in saying ‘blog,’ confusion with server log is avoided.” URL: <http://wikipedia.org>.

5 | “A Wiki or wiki (pronounced ‘wicky’ or ‘weekly’ or ‘viki’) is a website (or other hypertext document collection) that allows any user to add content, as on an Internet forum, but also allows that content to be edited by any other user.” URL: <http://wikipedia.org>.

6 | Tony Conrad’s Phonarmonica is an update of Benjamin Franklin glass armonica—an instrument that spun glass bowls and was played with finger tips. Conrad’s DJ version uses a power drill to spin a stack of 78 RPM records at increasing velocity while they are played by a manual contact with a pair of phonograph tone arms.

7 | The Access Grid™ is an ensemble of resources including multimedia large-format displays, presentation and interactive environments, and interfaces to support group-to-group interactions across the Grid. URL: <http://www.accessgrid.org/>

8 | Phil Agre, “Notes on organizing conferences” (1996). Available at http://www.eff.org/Activism/conf_organizing_notes_agre.article

9 | Open Conference Systems (OCS) is a free Web publishing tool that will create a complete Web presence for your scholarly conference. <http://www.pkp.ubc.ca/ocs/>.

10 | The research of the Institute for Distributed Creativity (iDC) focuses on cooperation studies in art, technology, and theory. The iDC, founded by Trebor Scholz in May 2004, is an international network that combines advanced creative production, research, events, and documentation. URL: <http://distributedcreativity.org>.

11 | Founded mid-2004 by Geert Lovink, this research institute, based at Polytechnic/University of Amsterdam (UvA/HvA), will look into the (internal) dynamics of online networks by organizing lectures, conferences, research programs and, most of all, both offline and online collaborations. URL: <http://networkcultures.org>.

12 | OpenOffice's mission is to create, as a community, the leading international office suite that will run on all major platforms and provide access to all functionality and data through open-component based APIs and an XML-based file format. URL: <http://OpenOffice.org>

FREE COOPERATION CONFERENCE PROGRAM

Trebor Scholz (*Department of Media Study,
The State University of New York at Buffalo*)
&
Geert Lovink (*University of Amsterdam*)

invite you to: networks, art, & collaboration
a two-day Brechtian play at the Department
of Media Study, The State University of New
York at Buffalo

APRIL 24 - 25, 2004

<http://freecooperation.org>

In a high-energy context this conference will bring together artists, designers, musicians, activists, art historians and engineers in formats such as workshops, open mic, parties, performances, interviews, and brain storming sessions — all aiming at ongoing collaborations, genuine dialogue, and the exchange of knowledge. The aim of the conference is to get a deeper understanding of the dynamics of collaboration, models of critical web-based art, and the role media technologies play in the making of social networks. Laugh, learn, argue, dance, discuss, eat, celebrate dissent, make new friends, and meet future collaborators. A Free Cooperation theory paper will be launched during the conference.

THURSDAY APRIL 23

Prologue: Ignite the Flames of Collaboration

Event with Jenny Perlin (Sarah Lawrence College), Laura McGough (Washington, DC), Trebor Scholz, and Christoph Spehr (Bremen) as part of Shifting Margins

FRIDAY APRIL 23

House Warming with Launch of Free Cooperation Publication.
This will be an opportunity to introduce yourself.

Followed by a screening of: "On Rules and Monsters. An introduction into free cooperation." Video by Christoph Spehr and Jörg Windszu

SATURDAY APRIL 24

<Warning: Sessions could end later, or earlier, than announced in the program depending on the debate.>

<start here> Hello World

Uday P. Sukhatme, Dean of the College of Arts and Sciences, Geert Lovink & Trebor Scholz

<try 1> The role of the network in the collaboration of women media practitioners.

This session will discuss collaborations without goal and the exclusivity of the women-only approach.

FACES (Vali Djordjevic; Berlin, Germany)

Gender Changer Academy (Kristina Clair; Philadelphia, Amsterdam)

GuerillaGirlsBroadband

J3 (Jane Crayton, Jessica Leber, Jennifer Peterson – University of Colorado at Boulder)

<try 2> Institutionalized: Hierarchies and Leveling the Ivory Tower

Participant-Centered Collaborations in Cross-Cultural, Educational and Community Contexts. Mental contagion, DIY and agitational collage collide in a workshop test driving experimental models of collaboration for the classroom and beyond. Engaging process through action,

tactics such as serial surrealism and water witching will be encouraged. Questioning the buzz surrounding the word “collaboration,” the session aims to facilitate a collective experience to further develop and discuss strategies for inclusive agendas. Krispy Kreme doughnuts and Kool-Aid will be served.

Jon Rubin (SUNY Purchase) <http://rachel.ns.purchase.edu/~jrubin/>

Stephanie Rothenberg (SUNY Buffalo)

Andrea Polli (Hunter College) <http://andreapolli.com>

<try 3> Open Content Initiatives, Reusability, Archives, & Shared Authority

By making our creative works available for reuse, we open our works to improvement, elaboration, and re-articulation by others. What role does attribution play in the creation of such reusable projects?

Benjamin Mako Hill (Free/Open Source Software developer, Seattle)

Blips Team (blips.tk) blips.tk is a collaborative online open history project that seeks to archive and reflect critically on “creative dark matter.” (blips is Brian Holmes, Tom Leonhardt, Trebor Scholz, Gregory Sholette, Orkan Telhan)

Alan Moore (art historian, creator of “collectivities” site, NYC) working on the history of art collectives in NYC since the 1970s

Laura McGough (Washington, DC) Collaborative archives: state of archives in the US based on her work as a program specialist at the National Endowment Arts Council, examination and re-examination of structuring and distributing data

<try 4> Tactical Media from the Masses

Can tactical media be used as an instrument of education? How can a means of media empowerment for minorities (or silent majorities), for those who cannot express their own voice, become a form of practical and critical pedagogy?

Ricardo Rosas (Brazilian Tactical Media Lab)

Kate Crawford (University of Sydney)

<try 5> Self-Organized Educational Attempts, Free Universities, “Anti-Universities

Moderator: Trebor Scholz

Dr. Alan O'Connor, Free Anarchist University Toronto

Stefan Roemer (New Media Department, Akademie der Bildenden Künste, Munich)

Katherine Carl, Srdjan Normal (School of Missing Studies, NYC) The knowledge that slips through traditional and singular disciplines seems to flow freely in an

unbound space and networks, however it takes a collaborative and experimental practice to excavate it, sort of scout for it, rather than wait for it.

Saul Albert, janitorial duties, University of Openess: "No tuition fees! No objectivity! No success!"

Martin Lucas (Hunter College, Manhattan Neighborhood Network, Paper Tiger TV)

Ricardo Rosas (Brazilian Tactical Media Lab)

also starring Janis Demkiw, "Free Documents"

<try 6> The Art of Cooperation

How do collaborations survive? Would you consider the Borg from Star Trek a collective or a hive mind? What sort of art would they create? How is this analogous to exquisite corpse groups online such as SITO.org?

We should admit that artists frequently have egos the size of Nebraska, and perhaps Antarctica. How can mutual respect be cultivated and maintained in collaborations? What are the causes of stresses and breakups, what can be done to mitigate them? Are collaborations that have obvious disparities in legitimacy to labor ethical? What is the nature of collaboration, (taken in its etymological sense of 'co-labor') vis-à-vis the current culture?

Is expression in mediated spaces becoming more collaborative in nature through shared spaces like iChat, gaming and MMORPGs?

What is the role of the centralized institution in presenting collaborative working light of issues such as the fetish of the unique, the cult of personality? What then can be said of the nature of projects that emerge from collaborations? How can the discontinuities between the ideal and the practical in terms of collaborative projects be reconciled best? One of the most ironic metaphors for some of the effective critical collaborative units is probably a cultural analogue to asymmetrical warfare, often across disciplinary and cultural lines. What impact has the role of tactical media had on the collaborative continuum? Why are the Rolling Stones are Still on Tour? Are new media, networks, & mobile/locative devices (cell phones, RFID, etc) creating a culture where collaboration is more akin to an a priori social structure?

4 hour Talkathon between Patrick Lichty (Intelligent Agent, ®™Mark, YesMen) and Nathan Martin (Carnegie Mellon University, Carbon Defense League): 1 Room, 2 speakers, 8 spectators at a time

<try 7> Geert Lovink in dialogue with Christoph Spehr

<try 8> Vis-à-vis

We need your mug for the collaborative video portrait. Come, be captured, and enter the database of video face loops for your 2 minutes of shared fame. This ever-changing collective video montage portrait of all participants is constructed in real time using Jitter. The project, Vis-à-vis, was developed in collaboration by the Soft Cinema seminar in the Department of Modern Culture and Media at Brown University in 2003. Running the piece will be S.C. veterans Michelle Higa, Thomas Owen and Rachel Stevens.

<try 9> Groove Listening

A workshop with Kurt Weibers (www.globalpointstrategies.com)

Nicolas Bourriaud's "relational aesthetics" filtered through Kurt Weibers' career as an organizational behaviorist, brand designer and motivational speaker. Weibers interviewed hundreds of workers, at corporations around the world, and finding, in the gaps of what they are saying, a collaborative identity, a pattern of transmission, a temporal formalism, a relational aesthetic.

<try 10> The Bonnie Parker Junior Show

Featuring the Top Ten Signs that you understood free cooperation theory. The BPJS is UB's most famous talk show. Tonight's show is especially dedicated to contemporary ideas around free cooperation. Meet the Free Cooperation Survivors!

Host: Stephanie Rothenberg as Bonnie Parker Junior

Guests: Brian Holmes as utopian

Christoph Spehr as the sci-fi filmmaker

Critical Art Ensemble as scientists

Tony Conrad as Paul Schaefer on the phonarmonica

Call-ins from:

Sara Diamond (The Banff Centre)

Page Sarlin (School of the Art Institute of Chicago)

Trevor Paglen (UC Berkley) Lucia Sommer (University of Rochester)

Also starring:

Jörg Windszus aka Windy (Bremen)

Uche Nduka (poet and activist, Nigeria/Germany)

Suse Lang (DASH, co-organizers of NEURO conference, Munich)

<try 11> Groups and Spaces

What are most effective uses of the Internet as organizational tool? Where are the limits of disembodied communication? What were beautiful moments of consensus?

Access Community Space Buffalo (Loren Sonnenberg)

16Beaver Group (Ayreen Anastas, Rene Gabri; NYC)

FACES

Gregory Sholette (PAD/D, REPOhistory)

Wolfgang Staehle (The Thing, NYC)

<try 12> Social Network Architectures

What kinds of tools can we design or use to facilitate collaboration? How can tools like mailing lists, web servers, blogs, voice over ip, SILC, and wikis generate knowledge? What is missing in these tools? How does the creative process mirror the network? How do we design these tools to go beyond chatter?

Moderated by Alexander Halavais (www.alex.halavais.net/ SUNY at Buffalo)

Eric Goldhagen (Open Flows, Interactivist, ABC NoRio) and Amanda Hickman (www.lincproject.org)

John Duda (Johns Hopkins University) Duda presents a look at using RSS to automate collaborative content sharing for activist media, in particular the indymedia network.

<dance> Turntablist Collaboration @ Soundlab

This piece, as database cinema focuses on digital ethnography of San Diego to border regions around the world. Using custom patches max msp jitter this performance revolves around narratives of politically charged footage with sound introduced into the dance floor environment of Soundlab.

Tim Jaeger & Jorge Nava (University of California San Diego)

New York-based electronica duo Los Nukiis will explore the sonic trans-border landscape with their own blend of downtempo electro-cumbia.

SUNDAY APRIL 25

<Disclaimer: conference activities may include, but are not limited to nudity>

<swimming> Swimming, Sauna, Steam Room (bring swim suit and cap)

<probe 1> Collaborative Authorship, Collective Writing, E-Poetics

Digital writing is wide-open in just about any way you want. Writing transforms digital media, and is transformed by them. Everything's up for grabs, including reader, writer, code, text, reception, author, and authority. Anyone can play.

Sandy Baldwin (West Virginia University)

Simon Biggs (Sheffield Hallam University/ University of Cambridge, UK)

Maria Damon (University of Minnesota)

Loss Pequeño Glazier (SUNY at Buffalo)

Alan Sondheim (Brooklyn)

<probe 2> Open Source / Free Software Sampling for Situations of Learning

Demo session of open source software for PC and MAC for situations of learning, moderated by Paul Vanouse. The goal of this session is to demo open source/free software and create an open access archive of ready to use software (Cygwin, GNU software for Windows, Blender, Gimp, OpenOffice, bit torrent, ontomatic, del.icio.us, last.fm)

with Patrick Lichty, Shawn Rider, Nathan Martin, Chris Coleman, Tom Leonhardt, Saul Albert, Benjamin Mako Hill, Mike Bouquard, Don Jacobs (CATE), Sher Doruff (Waag Society, Amsterdam), Alan Sondheim (Brooklyn)

<probe 3> Critical collaborative artistic practices in the networks

Horit Herman Peled (Oranim College; Tel Aviv, Israel) collaboration—a problematic concept (The Checkpoint Watch case)

Anna Harding (Chair, Creative Curating program at Goldsmiths College, London, UK)

Marie-Christiane Mathieu (Montreal) Monument du vide (www.ontogenetic.org)

web stream: Jon Ippolito (Associate Curator of Media Arts at the Guggenheim Museum / Joline Blais (Professor of New Media at the University of Maine)

demo: Pool A project of the University of Maine's Still Water program, The Pool

is a collaborative online environment for creating art, code, and texts. In place of the single-artist, single-artwork paradigm favored by the overwhelming majority of documentation systems, The Pool stimulates and documents collaboration in a variety of forms, including multi-author, asynchronous, and cross-medium projects. We are training revolutionaries—not by indoctrinating them with dogma but by exposing them to a process in which sharing is the norm rather than hoarding.

Barbara Lattanzi (www.wildernesspuppets.net) The interrupting annotator: Demo of New Genre Software work-in-progress Streaming video online

Michael Frisch (SUNY at Buffalo) Activating the database: “Telling Lives” public self-activated oral history recording

<probe 4> PdPal Walkabouts

PdPAL encourage collaborative storytelling. We provide a tool and set of inspirations that groups of map maker/storytellers deploy. Each group member is assigned to lead a task for the group—guide, observer, recorder. The collaboration of guiding, seeing, and recording challenge in the most basic way our assumptions about how we navigate, perceive, and name the world around us. The goal of this workshop is to develop graphic as well as technical strategies for creating effective maps for the next iteration of PDPal which will utilize cell phones.

<probe 5> KEYWORKX: global network streaming practices

Bring your laptops and drop by for a demonstration of a multi-user, multi-channel, multi-media collaborative platform for distributed performances and intervention.

Arjen Keesmaat and Sher Doruff (remote from Probe 2), Waag Society, Amsterdam

<probe 6> Experiments in Radio Topographies

by neuroTransmitter and Ricardo Miranda Zuniga

In 1932, Bertolt Brecht claimed that the “radio is one-sided when it should be two-. It is purely an apparatus for distribution, for mere sharing out. So here is a positive suggestion: Change the apparatus over from distribution to communication. The radio would be the finest possible communication apparatus in public life, a vast network of pipes.” Unfortunately, over the seventy-four years since Brecht’s treatise little has changed in radio usage, quite the opposite, the radio waves have been hijacked by corporate entities, largely with the aid of the Federal Communications Commission (FCC), a governmental group once intended to protect independent radio programming.

However, the history of radio is global, diverse and contentious. Radio presents a history of corporate power, civil intervention, revolutionary resistance, community advocacy. It is these various histories that will be addressed by the participants of “Experiments in Radio Topographies,” in which participants will be asked to investigate and then discuss these histories in a dispersed format, rather than a centralized panel and audience discussion. The panel action will be transmitted live on the free103point9 net radio station: <http://www.screwmusicforever.com/free103/freemenu.html>

<probe 7> Dreaming in the Hammock of Resistance: The Imaginaries of Free Cooperation

Dialogue: a collaborative presentation by Brian Holmes and Trebor Scholz

<probe 8> Technical Run Through: Data-Programming for Community
Holly Johnson & Paul Visco

Do you know how to write html but now want to learn how to use open source tools for databases (php, mysql) for your collaborative projects? Holly Johnson will address the creation of data models in the use of data-base driven tools for collaboration. How do you streamline data for collaboration? Paul Visco will demonstrate the use of these tools in his online local community initiative elmwoodstrip.com

This introduction will be followed by a basic two-hour workshop: creating forms that speak to databases. Holly and Paul will answer particularly technical questions about structuring databases in this context.

<probe 9> VENDETTA THE ACADEMIC SUPERMODEL PART II

Performance by Katrien Jacobs (Emerson College), Eugene Tan (Emerson College) and Maurice Methot (Emerson College).

FREE COOP, the performance bodies of whirling academia, entered a twilight of Knowledge. Their voices were meeting and getting louder and louder. FULL NUDITY organized a session to suggest a whole new beginning for the COOP. She was met with applause and many eloquent questions. VENDETTA, the always well prepared and well dressed academic, bristled with fury. Come and witness the beauty of stripping of VENDETTA, THE ACADEMIC SUPERMODEL.

(Full nudity happening, mild participation encouraged, just bring pens

and pencils)

<probe 10> Expression of Women Through Pixels

J3 Jane Crayton, Jessica Leber, Jennifer Peterson (University of Colorado at Boulder)

*** Keywordx Jam**

Keywordx Jam is a virtual collaborative web-based art presentation.

<probe 11> The Elastic Test Project (workshop)

Rozalinda Borcila (Cluj-Napoca, Romania) with Sarah Lewison (UCSD)

The Elastic Test Project is an ongoing series of performances developed collaboratively as interventions into the normative cultural definitions of ‘citizen’ and ‘foreigner,’ by critically re-interpreting immigration and naturalization in various locations.

This is a hands-on workshop and brainstorming session. We will put into motion some of the collaborative methods used in our practice so far, and collectively initiate new interventions.”

**<probe 12> Collaborations between Artists and Scientists
Interdisciplinarity and Collaboration**

What does it mean to successfully collaborate in an art/sci context (ie., experimental bio-info-edu-tainment)?

Critical Art Ensemble

Paul Vanouse (SUNY At Buffalo)

Claire Pentecost (School of the Art Institute of Chicago)

<probe 13> Who says artists can’t organize?

Sarah Lewison (UCSD) serves gin rickeys to lubricate a discussion on collaborative economies and networks of aging artist retirement homes.

Simon Sheikh (Nordic Institute For Contemporary Art; Helsinki, Finland) Who is afraid of artists? Sheikh will talk about the foundation of an artist’s union (UKK) in Denmark.

Georg Schoelhammer (editor, Springerin Magazine for Contemporary Art, Vienna (Austria)/magnet magazine network)

<probe 14> Game On Games

Play the conference-wide, conference-long ‘Game on Games’ in the gaps between sessions; seek out the ‘Game on Games’ and make it your

weekend obsession; then gather to hear the outcome of collaborative artistic meta-play at this culminating discussion.

McKenzie Wark (The New School)

Susan Laxton (Columbia University)

Rachel Stevens (Brown University)

<probe 15> DreamYourCooperation: The ABC's of Collaboration.

Collaborate or Die? Robinson Crusoe, the Lonely Island, the beauty of consensus, new emergent identities, mutual benefit, peer pleasure, variable durations, scale. What about individual gain?

Setting: a room full of people are given questions: What are flexible if/else statements or flow charts of collaboration? What are key points of collaboration? Focus versus specificity in the creation of collaboration, how to involve people, scale in collaboration, working conditions, division of labor, credit economy

Within two hours a 15-minute video piece is created by all participants in the workshop. Alternatively groups could create drawings, flow charts or puppet plays. These results are given to the conference organizers for addition to DVD or archive.

Mike Steventon, former chairman of the board, Interaccess, Toronto and DespiteTV (London, UK), SENSBUS collaborative installation using micro processors, coordinator/ co-creator of Art Interface Device (AID), an open source collaborative tool for artists.

Kate Crawford (University of Sydney)

<probe 16> Collaborative Story-Telling Workshop

Jessica Hammer (game developer, NYC) and Elizabeth Knipe:

Creation and reflection about the writing of a story guided by several different sets of rules of distribution of authority.

One of the central challenges of interactive storytelling is the question of authority. How do the participants decide what kind of story is being told? How do they develop plot and character without creating conflict among themselves? How are those conflicts, when they do arise, resolved? A collaborative story has to walk a fine line between the Scylla of lack of focus and the Charybdis of too central and oppressive an authority structure, and it's by no means an easy task.

This workshop will explore different strategies of handling shared authority in a hands-on environment. The group will tell several dif-

ferent collaboratively created stories, each using different rules for the division of authority. After each brief story, we will reflect on and discuss the experience of working with that set of rules. We will also consider the experience as part of a more general approach to interactive narrative, including a discussion of extant forms of collaboration that rely on similar techniques. Finally, we will experiment with inventing our own rules and methods for sharing authority in the group, and see whether we can come up with an approach that will address some of the difficulties we've discovered.

<probe 17> Collaborative project under construction

Carbon Defense League (Pittsburgh)

END THE BOREDOM! DEVIANCE IN ART.

MapHub

<forum>

moderated: Geert Lovink / Trebor Scholz All participants attend, sessions report, summary

<movie>

Screening followed by discussion of works by Termite TV at Squeaky Wheel collective working philosophy, self- and group promotion, sustainability, consensus and aesthetic integrity.

The five members/directors Termite TV Collective (www.termite.org) was founded in 1991. How is the working styles and evolving collaborative philosophy reflected in the changing aesthetic of the collective's video work?

MONDAY APRIL 26

EPILOGUE

Post-conference Event

THE THING 601 West 26th Street New York, New York 10001

DESCRIPTION OF GROUPS / BIOGRAPHIES OF PARTICIPANTS

(as received at time of printing)

Saul Albert (saoul@thepts.net) is a researcher and janitor at the University of Openess (uo.thepts.net), he works with many groups including: The People Speak (thepts.net), Twentieth Century (twentiethcentury.com), Dorkbot (dorkbot.org/dorkbotlon-don) and the Cube (cubecinema.com).

Josephine Anstey (jranstey@buffalo.edu) is a Virtual Reality artist, with a background in video art and prose fiction. Her main research focus is creating interactive VR drama. Her VR work includes PAAPAB, The Thing Growing, and The Multi Mega Book in the CAVE. These works have shown at festivals and museums in the US, Europe and Japan. She is an assistant professor at the Department of Media Study, University at Buffalo.

Sandy Baldwin (charles.baldwin@mail.wvu.edu) directs the Center for Literary Computing at West Virginia University. Some topics of his recent publications includes: digital literature, code poetics, the nemotechnics of user interfaces, nanotechnology, crash test dummies, Paul Virilio, Arakawa and Gins. He creates and performs his own work, and with the improvisational collaborative Purkinge (aka 9 Way Mind) and the Atlanta Poets Group.

16 Beaver Group (www.16beavergroup.org) is located in downtown Manhattan and has established itself as a place for artists, activists, curators, critics and others who are interested in initiating and maintaining an ongoing space and time for the practice and discussion of contemporary art, theory, and politics. The topics discussed come directly out of the interests or projects of the participants.

Joline Blais (jblais@maine.edu) Fiction writer Joline Blais is Asst. Prof. of New Media at UMaine and co-founder of Still Water for network art and culture. She previously directed Digital Media Studies at NY Polytechnic University and launched media studies in SCPS at NYU. Blais' research and creative work explores new narrative forms, and includes forthcoming *_The Edge of Art_*, and *_Sorties_*, a recently completed novel.

Blips.tk (info@blips.tk) Blips are temporary departures from familiar experience. Based on the concept that the majority of cultural activity in our post-industrial society remains invisible to the institutions and discourses -critics, art historians, collectors, dealers, museums, curators and arts administrators- who manage and interpret contemporary culture, blips.tk is a collaborative online project that seeks to archive and reflect critically on this "creative dark matter." This open history project contains a database of multimedia submissions, selected essays that reflect on issues raised by this content, as well as a web log for critical debate. We encourage individuals and organizations to submit artwork, ideas, documents, and information of a wide variety that belongs to this shadow realm of creativity. The domain is registered on the island of Tokelau, 480 km north of Western Samoa. (blips is Brian Holmes, Tom Leonhardt, Trebor Scholz, Gregory Sholette, Orkan Telhan)

Tony Conrad (conrad@buffalo.edu) teaches video at UB. He was associated with the founding of both "minimal" music and "underground" cinema. His film "The Flicker" is a key "structural" film. He performs his music, primarily for amplified violin, in the US and internationally. His video work has been shown internationally. In the early 1990s he worked with several collectives in Buffalo producing work for public access cable television.

Wendy Hui Kyong Chun (Wendy_Hui_Kyong_Chun@brown.edu) teaches digital

media theory at Brown University. She is currently completing *_Control and Freedom_* (forthcoming MIT 2005), co-editing *_New Media, Old Media_* (forthcoming Routledge 2004), and starting a new project on the history of code. She has been a fellow at the Radcliffe Institute for Advanced Study and currently holds a Wriston Fellowship from Brown.

Kate Crawford (kate.crawford@arts.usyd.edu.au) Lecturer in Media at the University of Sydney, musician in the bands B(if)tek and Clone, member of the Australian collective of electronic artists Clan Analogue, co-founder of the international awards for tactical media and electronic excellence, the WINK Awards. Currently researching intellectual property and music, and writing a book on new media for Palgrave UK. www.biftek.com.

Critical Art Ensemble (CriticalArt@cs.com) is a collective of four tactical media practitioners of various specializations including computer graphics and web design, wetware, film/video, photography, text art, book art, and performance. Formed in 1987, CAE's focus has been on the exploration of the intersections between art, critical theory, technology, and political activism.

Valie Djordjevic (valid@faces-l.net) lives in Berlin where she is active on the fringes of art and media. She is a member of mikro e.V. <www.mikro.org>, a Berlin based association examining the facets of media culture and list coordinator for the FACES mailing list <faces-l.net>. She works in different contexts — writing, lectures, organizing events - on the topics of gender, networking, information and art.

Michael Frisch (mfrisch@buffalo.edu) Professor, History & American Studies, UB; Principal, Randforce Associates—developing digital indexing for audio/video oral history documentation, and related applications; Author: *A Shared Authority*, *Essays on the Craft and Meaning of Oral and Public History*; and *Portraits in Steel* (with photographer Milton Rogovin)—photo portraits/oral histories of Buffalo steelworkers, before and after deindustrialization (Oral History Association Book Prize, 1993-95) ; President, American Studies Association (2000-2001).

Sher Doruff (sher@waag.org) is currently creative director of the Sensing Presence department of the Waag Society/for old and new media in Amsterdam, and a core member of the development team of KeyWorx. She is also a digital artist and doctoral student with the London Institute/CSM researching collaborative performance methods. She also heads the Augmented Performance Practice module of the Dance Unlimited MA program in the Netherlands.

John Duda (john@manifestor.org) Besides his current position as a PhD candidate in the Humanities Center at Johns Hopkins University (where he is researching the historical and epistemological issues posed by the problematic intersections of the scientific and the political), John Duda has collaborated actively on the electronic underpinnings of the global social revolution. During a three year stint in Amsterdam, he was a part of the ASCII (<http://scii.nl>) computer collective and helped run its squatted free-internet/free-software cafe. He has been a contributor to various indymedia technical efforts since 2000, most recently helping to develop the open source Mir software (mir.indymedia.org) and implementing the FTAA IMC web site (ftaaimc.org). He is the maintainer of the techcoop.info project, which offers a database of noncapitalist technology initiatives.

FACES The mailing list, exists since 1997 and provides a no-nonsense network for

women working with media and culture. The list cultivates a hands-on approach to working together and is more interested in providing a practice of sharing than a discourse. Since its existence, FACES has nurtured numerous projects that later became known in their own right.

free103point9 (<http://www.free103point9.org>) is a nonprofit media arts organization focused on establishing and cultivating the genre Transmission Arts by promoting artists who explore ideas around transmission as a medium for creative expression including investigations in AM and FM radio, Citizen's Band, walkie-talkie, generative sound, and other broad and microcasting technologies. Founded in 1997 free103's mobile operations made airtime available to community voices, local bands, and most significantly to a group of under-served artists shaping conceptual works specifically for radio transmission.

Rene Gabri (renegabri@16beavergroup.org), Iranian-Armenian, born in Tehran, moved to Athens, then Los Angeles, now based in New York. His solo projects, are largely based around the mediums of film, video, audio and text. He has been exploring a broad range of topics including cities, memory, confession, popular culture, television, music and issues related to in-between-ness and drifting in general. In addition, to his solo projects, he has been involved with and initiated a broad range of collaborative situations and frameworks. At the conclusion of the Whitney Museum's Independent Study Program in 1999, Rene co-initiated 16Beaver (16beavergroup.org). Since that time he has been active in maintaining an ongoing platform and space for independent critical, cultural, political inquiry and friendship. His projects with Ayreen Anastas have evolved a great deal through their work at 16Beaver.

Gender Changer Academy (GCA) (teachers@genderchangers.org) is a free ICT platform for and by women worldwide. We organize non-profit courses, workshops and carnivals in DIY computer hardware and free software, and cooperate with organizations like ASCII, ChicasLinux, MAMA, Zene na Delu, SARAI, and NSM. Further GCA productions are t-shirts, bags, jewelry, stickers, posters, blankets and other haptic perceptions of female computing environments. URL: <http://genderchangers.org/>

Maria Damon (damon001@umn.edu) teaches poetry and poetics/cultural studies at university of minnesota. She is the author of *The Dark End of the Street: Margins in American Vanguard Poetry*, and co-author (with Miekal And) of *Literature Nation* and *Erosion*, and (with Betsy Franco) of *The Secret Life of Words*.

Eric Goldhagen (eric@openflows.org) is a technology worker with a background in journalism and print production. He is a Senior Partner at Openflows Networks Ltd.; founder of the InterActivist Network project of ABC No Rio; member of the Autonomedia publishing collective; coordinator of a free public access computer center at ABC No Rio and occasionally does production work for the radical comic *World War 3 Illustrated*.

Jessica Hammer (hammer@kleene-star.net) is a consultant, game designer and writer whose core interests are collaborative and interactive narrative, especially as they relate to games and other structured means of storytelling. She has taught for NYU, consulted for clients including Nokia and the BBC, and has lectured internationally on her theories of interactive narrative. She also runs an experimental storytelling

group in New York City.

Anna Harding (anna@modrex.com) is a curator and writer living in London, Programme Director of the MA Creative Curating at Goldsmiths College 1995-2003, and edited the book *Curating: The Contemporary Art Museum and Beyond* (1997). Recent projects include *Interference: Public Sound* (<http://www.interference.org.uk>) in 2003 and *Potential: Angoing Archive* 2002. I am currently working on a book about collaborations between artists and young people.

Michelle Higa (higa@slanted.org) is a Providence based artist interested in interactive video installation. Her collaborations in the immersive virtual reality Cave were shown in the Boston Cyberarts Festival. She is currently serving as an Editor in Chief for CHAISE, a DVD magazine featuring emerging artists, and completing her honors thesis in Art: Semiotics at Brown University. <http://www.slanted.org>

Jon Ippolito (jippolito@maine.edu) One of many footsoldiers in the battle between network and hierarchic culture, Jon Ippolito is an artist, Guggenheim curator, and co-founder of the Still Water program for network art and culture at the University of Maine. His current projects—including the Variable Media Network, the Open Art Network, and a forthcoming book entitled *The Edge of Art*—aim to expand the art world beyond its traditional preoccupations.

Katrien Jacobs (Katrien_Jacobs@emerson.edu) is assistant professor in new media at Emerson College. She wrote a Ph.D. dissertation on dismemberment mythologies in 60s/70s body art and theory. She has published several articles on sexuality, pornography and new media art in journals such as *Wide Angle* and *Cultural Studies*. She has lectured widely on pornography in Europe, Australia, Asia and the USA. An Emerson College Faculty Advancement Grant and residency at arts center KC nOna (Belgium) have enabled her in recent years to develop work as web-based entity 'libidot.' (<http://www.libidot.org>). Libidot and dr.Jacobs will soon become the main characters in her forthcoming book *Banned From Apple Paradise*.

Timothy Jaeger (timjaeger@thing.net) produces live media events, video installations, and social networks. His work has been shown in venues such as the Electronic Orphanage (L.A.), The Thing (NYC), Open Air Radio (Barcelona), Galerie Hubert Winter (Vienna), and WKCR (NYC). Currently he is an MFA candidate / Graduate Researcher at CRCA / UCSD, where he studies and works with Jordan Crandall, Lev Manovich, and Barbara Kruger.

Holly Johnson (haj2@buffalo.edu) is a graduate student and adjunct instructor at UB, as well as an online journalist and web designer. She was active with the Philadelphia Independent Media Center during the Republican National Convention and beyond. She conducts research on the portrayal of Afghan women by Western media.

Caroline Koebel's (cgkoebel@acsu.buffalo.edu) interdisciplinary practice often confronts the problematics of female being-in-the-world and the expression of subjectivities at odds with commercial culture. She has a serious commitment to DIY ethos, a fruit in part of her teenage days as a punk in Columbus, Ohio. Her works have been shown across the USA, as well as in Brazil, Ireland, Cuba, Thailand, and elsewhere. Her writings on art and contemporary culture have appeared in *Art Papers*, *Brooklyn Rail*, *Dialogue*, and *Wide Angle*. She teaches in the Department of Media Study at the University at Buffalo.

Barbara Lattanzi (threads@wildernesspuppets.net) produces screen-based media including software for video improvisation. Lattanzi knows Buffalo (locale of Free Cooperation events) to have a complex history as site of lively and admirably contentious cultures of cooperation, through her involvement (1980s and 90s) with Buffalo art organizations and activist media groups. Now teaching at Smith College, Massachusetts, Lattanzi's URL is www.wildernesspuppets.net.

Martin Lucas (mlucas@igc.org) is a media activist and videomaker with a 20-year background in documentary and media art. An early member of the Paper Tiger Television Collective, Martin has worked and taught in many alternative media contexts. Martin currently teaches in the Film and Media Studies Dept. at Hunter College, CUNY, and is Director of Technology at Manhattan Neighborhood Network.

Susan Laxton (sjl16@columbia.edu) is a doctoral candidate in Columbia University's Department of Art History and Archaeology, happy to be defending her dissertation, "Paris as Gameboard: Ludic Strategies in Surrealism," in two weeks. Most recently she has published in the journals *_Postmodern Culture_* and *_Papers of Surrealism_*, and has curated an exhibition on Man Ray's Atget collection at the Wallach Gallery in New York.

Tom Leonhardt (tl22@buffalo.edu) is a long-time member of the Toronto electronic arts community. He uses programming and other media to create interactive installations both virtual and real. Leonhardt is interested in the politics of surveillance, memory, media archives, and the dynamic of anarchic social spaces.

Sarah Lewison (socialsculpture@yahoo.com) Since the 70s heyday of food coops, I've been interested in sharing as form. How hokey. Research areas: Property as privacy. Sustainability pedagogy: as material life, time, invention, economics, politics. Vernacular technologies and distributive research. Amateur sociology, new agey and media therapies. The respective scales of socially exchanged substances: land, water, bacteria, neurosis, towels, money, viruses and food.

Patrick Lichty (voyd@voyd.com) is an artist, editor, curator and activist of over 15 years. He is Editor-In-Chief of Intelligent Agent Magazine, and part of the Yes Men.

Geert Lovink (geert@xs4all.nl) is a media theorist and Internet critic, based in Amsterdam. He is the founder of numerous Internet projects such as the Nettime and Fibreculture mailing lists. He is the co-organizer of conferences like Next Five Minutes and TulipomaniaDotcom (Amsterdam), Dark Markets (Vienna) and Crisis Media (Delhi). The MIT Press recently published his writing on critical Internet culture *Dark Fiber* and *Uncanny Networks*, a collection of his interviews. In October 2003 *V2_Publishing* brought out his latest study on Internet culture *My First Recession*. audanum.net/geert

Nathan Martin (nathan@hactivist.com) is a new media artist, collective experimenter, technologist, designer, writer, and programmer currently living in Pittsburgh, PA as a Research Fellow at Carnegie Mellon University, s STUDIO for Creative Inquiry. Nathan is a founding member of the media arts collective Carbon Defense League (CDL). Nathan is currently working on the CDL project MapHub and writing a book called *Parasites, Splinters, and Thieves* as part of a residency he was awarded for the year 2004 at the STUDIO for Creative Inquiry.

Marie-Christiane Mathieu (creature@videotron.ca) new medias artist, has complet-

ed a PhD on a network collaborative project entitle “Monument du vide” for which she has developed a creative process based on theatrical approaches. Mathieu has analyzed, during this project, multiple communication layers from which she is now proposing the concept of the “aître.” She is currently working on the development of virtual alcoves.

Maurice Methot (maurice_methot@emerson.edu) Assistant Professor in Visual and Media Arts at Emerson College. Sound artist.

Jorge Nava (genava@ucsd.edu) Born in the midst of the cultural crossroads that is the Mexican-U.S. border, Jorge Nava uses digital media to explore and participate in the linguistic, aesthetic, social, and other collisions of art and culture in the shifting context of the New World. He is an MFA candidate at UCSD where he works with Ruben Ortiz-Torres, Natalie Jeremijenko, and Barbara Kruger.

neuroTransmitter (nT), founded in 2001, is a radio collaborative utilizing analog communication technologies. Working specifically with radio machinations, neuroTransmitter propels signals through urban membranes and cellular formations. To complement their fixed and mobile frequency performances, nT creates radio-sonic installations, produces music, and converts utilitarian objects into radio transmission and receiving devices. neuroTransmitter has created visual works, performed, and broadcasted live on local bandwidths in public spaces and galleries throughout New York City; Columbus, Ohio; Helsinki, Finland; Aarhus, Denmark; and Madrid, Spain.

Alan O'Connor (asloconnor@sympatico.ca) was one of the founders of the Toronto Infoshop Whos Emma in the 1990s and also one of the founding members of the Toronto Free School. In 2003 he was involved in setting up the very successful Anarchist Free University in Toronto. The Free University offers ten-week academic courses on subjects from Radical Theories of Sexuality, Collaborative Art, the Situationist International, and the history of 1968. The Anarchist University believes that “We are all students, we are all teachers.” All courses are free. For more details see: <http://www.AnarchistU.org>

Dave Pape (dave.pape@acm.org) is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Media Study of the University at Buffalo, working in digital media: computer graphics and virtual reality. He received a PhD in Computer Science from the University of Illinois at Chicago, at the Electronic Visualization Laboratory.

Scott Paterson (PdPal) (somebody@sgp-7.net) is an architect, artist and interaction designer in New York City. He studied architecture at the University of Minnesota CALA and Columbia University GSAP. He is on the faculty of Parsons School of Design where he teaches Interface Design, Multimedia and Thesis Studios in the MFA in Design and Technology Program.

PdPal (somebody@sgp-7.net), a public art project currently for PDA's and the web, is a storytelling mapping application that transforms your everyday activities and urban experiences into a dynamic city that you write. PDPal Walkabout is a workshop to develop psychogeographic-inspired mapping missions, conduct a walkabout, record it using a pictogrammic shorthand and ultimately to help us determine best methods for making our upcoming PDA to cell phone transition.

Horit Herman Peled (horithp@yahoo.com) (<http://www.horit.com/machsomwatch>).

htm) is a collaborative personal piece, between a human/political engagement and an artistic pursuit. This project, like other projects in my work, seeks to interrogate the meaning of art production, distribution and consumption. Through a concrete, local intervention it endeavors to undermine the artistic domain of producing exclusive exchange value and venture into the domain of inclusive use value art production.

Loss Pequeño Glazier (glazier@buffalo.edu) is a digital poet, professor of Media Study, a Poetics Program Core Faculty member, and director of the Electronic Poetry Center (<http://epc.buffalo.edu>) at SUNY Buffalo. His books include *Anatman*, *Pumpkin Seed*, *Algorithm* (Salt Publishing, 2003) and *Digital Poetics: The Making of E-Poetries* (Univ. of Alabama Press, 2002). He director of the E-Poetry digital poetry festivals and his work has been shown at the Kulturforum, Berlin, the Guggenheim, New York, and elsewhere. His work is available at his EPC author page (<http://epc.buffalo.edu/authors/glazier>).

Thomas Owen (towen@tomowenmusic.com) is currently finishing graduate work at Brown University in the Computer Music and Multimedia Department. He holds a Bachelor's Degree in Music Synthesis from Berklee College of Music. His installation/performance work using interactive music and video has been shown in conferences at Brown, Dartmouth, Princeton, Berkley and the New School. (Here at SUNY Buffalo he'll present an installation in collaboration with Rachel Stevens)

Orkan Telhan is currently an MFA candidate at the program of Media Study at University at Buffalo. Telhan is a designer worked in print and digital media in Turkey, Belgium and US in collaboration with artists, choreographers, musicians and architects. His current focus is on real-time, interactive computer graphics programming with an emphasis on immersive virtual reality environments and machine vision. He holds an MFA from Bilkent University/Turkey with a concentration on critical media theories. Telhan is part of the blips.tk team.

Jenny Perlin (nilrep@access4less.net) studied film and cultural studies at Brown University, completed her MFA in Film at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, and postgraduate studies at the Whitney Independent Study Program, New York City. Perlin's films and drawings work with and against the documentary tradition, incorporating innovative stylistic techniques to emphasize issues of truth, misunderstanding, and personal history. She has recently completed *View from Elsewhere*, a look at conditions of political asylum seekers in Switzerland, and *Perseverance & How to Develop It*, a film about the cultural and social histories of self-help in the United States. Her films have won awards at numerous festivals, and have been exhibited in galleries and museums both in the US and abroad.

Andrea Polli (apolli@hunter.cuny.edu) is a digital media artist living in New York City. She is currently an Associate Professor of Film and Media at Hunter College. Polli's work addresses issues related to science and technology in contemporary society. Her projects often bring together artists and scientists from various disciplines. She has exhibited, performed, and lectured nationally and internationally.

Shawn Rider (shawnr@wdog.com) is a writer and media artist with specialties in interactive literature, cyberculture, net.art, and videogames. He is currently pursuing an MFA in the Department of Media Study, SUNY at Buffalo. He most often works collaboratively with photographer and critic, Sarah Wichlacz. His website

can be found at <http://www.wdog.com/rider>

Stefan Römer (stefanroe@web.de) Living in Cologne and Munich he is working as an artist and author in the fields of Conceptual Art, Critique of the Public Sphere, Image- and Textrelations, New Media and Interculturaltheory; publications in newspapers, magazines and books. Received the Prize for Art Critics from the Arbeitskreis deutscher Kunstvereine in 2000. Assistant at the Academy for Arts and New Media in Cologne (1999-2002); now Professor for New Media at the Academy of Arts in Munich (since 2003).

Ricardo Rosas (ricardorosas@uol.com.br) is a writer, translator, activist and electronic musician. He's the senior editor of Rizoma (www.rizoma.net), a Brazilian site dedicated to activist art, tactical media and counter-cultural issues. He was one of the organizers of the Brazilian Tactical Media Laboratory, Midia Tatica Brasil (www.midiatatica.org). He currently lives in Sao Paulo.

Stephanie Rothenberg (info@pan-o-matic.com) uses performance, installation and digital media to create solicitous interactions that question the boundaries and social constructs of manufactured desires. Reflecting on her past life as a dot-comer and her new life in the institution, Stephanie is interested in expanding the vocabulary of communication design through collaborative activities with students and communities at large. She has lectured and exhibited nationally and internationally. She is Assistant Professor in the Communication Design Program in the Department of Art at SUNY Buffalo.

Jon Rubin (floater@rcn.com) is an Associate Professor of Film and New Media at SUNY/Purchase, where for the past two years he has taught the Cross-Cultural Video Project - collaboratively linking his American students with students in Minsk, Belarus. He is also the Director of The Floating Cinema, a choreographic waterfront projection work, which is tentatively scheduled to appear in Holland, Berlin and NYC in 2004.

Georg Schöllhammer (office@springerin.at) is editor in chief of springerin Hefte für Gegenwartskunst and currently works on a publication program for documenta 12.

Trebor Scholz (treborscholz@earthlink.net) is an East Berlin-born media artist and critic who divides his time between Buffalo and Brooklyn. He links his political investments and artistic sensitivities with his commitment to emerging networked media. Occasionally he focuses on an event-oriented practice. Scholz exhibits and lectures widely nationally and internationally. He is assistant professor in the Department of Media Study, SUNY at Buffalo. <http://molodiez.org/bio.php>

School of Missing Studies (SMS) (kat@igc.org) provides a flexible educational platform and a network for international study and exchange on cultural issues related to the urban environment in cities marked by or currently undergoing political, social, and cultural transition. SMS will provide productive research and project opportunities for young professionals in architecture and art who are dealing with what is "missing" in their studies with regard to processes of local urban change. Participants in SMS will explore the smooth area among established disciplines such as architecture, art, sociology and cultural studies to bring to light the missing phenomena of urban transition in Belgrade, Munich, Rotterdam and Zurich.

Eva Sjuve (eva@moomonkey.com), media artist, has been exhibiting in Europe,

Asia, USA, South America and Australia. She started out building a local radio network in the early 80's and then moved on to Cable TV in 1985 to make interactive shows. She is now curating exhibits and developing work for public space integrating wifi, mobile phone, Internet.

Christoph Spehr (yetipress@aol.com), born 1963. Works for the >alaska: magazine on internationalism< (Bremen), as a freelancer for the (PDS-related) Rosa-Luxemburg-Foundation (Berlin), and as an office help for the Uni-kindergarden Bremen. Since 2000, organizing the yearly conference >Out of this world! Science-Fiction, politics, utopia<. Books: >The eco-trap. Sustainable development and crisis< (Vienna 1996), >Aliens are amongst us! Domination and liberation in the democratic age< (Munic 1999), >More equal than others. A foundation of free cooperation< (Berlin 2003; Rosa-Luxemburg-Prize 2001). Videos (with Jörg Windszus a.o.): >Time is on my side<, >Go on, you free pigs<, >The p-files< a.o. Entries on >counter-public< and >hierarchy< in the HKWM (historical-critical dictionary of Marxism). Lives in Bremen with the German feminist theorist Claude Bernhard and our 2 children.

Gregory Sholette (gsholette@artic.edu) is a NYC based artist, writer, activist and founding member of Political Art Documentation and Distribution and REPOhistory. He is currently editing the book *Collectivism After Modernism* with UC Davis art historian Blake Stimson for University of Minnesota Press.

Alan Sondheim (sondheim@panix.com) I was ripped out of the world. Inverse: I made a mess with the 'results.' <http://www.asondheim.org/>. I can't add to the texts there. What does anguish 'mean' in the face of Empire? I will not be a collaborator. Sometimes the we works in unison. I kept an image of Bikini Atoll in the midst of an explosion. I bear witness to nothing.

Loren Sonnenberg (pineconegrenadier@hotmail.com) Media and community activist currently residing in Buffalo, New York. Most notable as catalyst and board member of the Access Community Center (<http://www.accesscommunity.net>), a local youth oriented, alternative community center run through collaborative program planning and consensus based decision making. Currently graduating from the University at Buffalo's program in Media Studies and continuing on for graduate work here.

Rachel Stevens (Rachel_Stevens@brown.edu) is an interdisciplinary artist based in New York City. Her projects explore the intersection of art, technology, media and materiality. Currently she is Visiting Assistant Professor in the Department of Modern Culture and Media at Brown University and has also taught at RISD and the New School. In 2001-2002 she was Associate Curator at Creative Time in NYC.

Termite TV Collective (info@termite.org) Dorothea Braemer, Meg Knowles, Mike Kuetemeyer, Carl Lee, Anula Shetty. Founded in 1992, Termite TV is a not-for-profit video collective with members based in Philadelphia, PA and Buffalo, NY. Termite TV produces alternative programming for television, the web and screening, performance and installation venues. The mission of Termite TV is to create multi-faceted and multi-voiced works which address issues of cultural, political, and aesthetic concern." A peculiar fact about termite-tapeworm-fungus-moss art is that it moves always forward, eating its own boundaries, and likely as not, leaves nothing in its path but evidence of eager, industrious, unkempt activities" —manny

farber www.termite.org

Paul Vanouse has been working in emerging media since 1990. Interdisciplinarity and impassioned amateurism guide his art practice. His electronic cinema, performances and interactive situations have been exhibited in 18 countries and widely across the US. Vanouse is an Assistant Professor of Art at the University at Buffalo. His most recent solo work “The Relative Velocity Inscription Device” is a live scientific experiment in which he literally races skin color genes from his Jamaican-American family against one another.

Paul Visco (paul@elmwoodstrip.com) is a UB MFA student, data artist, and adjunct instructor at Canisius College. Paul’s most recent work, elmwoodstrip.com, focuses on the de-globalization of the web and is an initiative using open source languages and databases to enhance local community by allowing local people with little or no computer background to express themselves using a click-publish format.

Kurt Weibers’s (kurt@globalpointstrategies.com) experience includes working directly with top CEO’s in fortune 500 companies as well as hundreds of entrepreneurs in the biotech, defense, IT, global manufacturing and sports industries; Kurt’s speeches and seminars are grounded in 10 years of traveling the world, interviewing workers and collaborating with managers.

Ricardo Miranda Zuñiga (ricardo@ambriente.com) grew up between Nicaragua and San Francisco. Tied to a multi-disciplinary education, his bicultural background has led to work based on a twofold principle: approach communication as a creative process; and investigate how economic realities formulate not only the world we live in, but more importantly, the lives we lead. Ricardo’s portfolio is available at: <http://www.ambriente.com/>

CONFERENCE CREDITS

concept and production:

Geert Lovink (Amsterdam), Trebor Scholz (Brooklyn/Buffalo)

assistant producer: Dorothee Gestrich (Stuttgart)

editors of conference publication: Geert Lovink, Trebor Scholz

conference material design: Orkan Telhan

t-shirt, program, map design: Arzu Ozkal Telhan

dvd: Shawn Rider

wiki: Tom Leonhardt CATE Facilitation: Lesley Cephas

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AUTHORS BIOGRAPHIES

Howard Rheingold is an internationally acclaimed writer on the social implications of technology. His 1985 book *Tools for Thought* is an early history of the personal computer. In *Virtual Reality* (1990) he chronicled the scene around this topic. In 1985 Howard logged on to *The Well*, which resulted in his *Virtual Communities* (1993). He was editor of *The Whole Earth Review* and editor in chief of *The Millennium Whole Earth Catalog*. In 1994 he became Executive Editor of *HotWired*, but resigned shortly thereafter. He commented that he “wanted something more like a jam session than a magazine.” In 1996 he founded “Electric Minds,” a collection of communities and dialogue, and an early victim to the logic of venture capital. In 2002, Rheingold published *Smart Mobs*, exploring the potential for technology to augment collective intelligence. Shortly thereafter, Rheingold launched an effort to develop a broad-based literacy of cooperation.

Brian Holmes is an art and cultural critic, activist and translator, living in Paris, interested primarily in the intersections of artistic and political practice. He holds a doctorate in Romance Languages and Literatures from the University of California at Berkeley. He was the English editor of publications for Docu-

menta X, Kassel, Germany, 1997, was a member of the graphic arts group Ne pas plier from 1999 to 2001, and has recently worked with the French conceptual art group Bureau d'études. He is a frequent contributor to the international mailinglist Nettime, a member of the editorial committee of the art magazine "Springerin" and the political-economy journal "Multitudes", a regular contributor to the magazine Parachute, and a founder of the new journal "Autonomie Artistique". He is currently preparing a book in French, entitled "La personnalité flexible: Pour une nouvelle critique de la culture."

Geert Lovink, media theorist, net critic and author of *Dark Fiber*, *Uncanny Networks* and *My First Recession*. He is a member of the Adilkno collective (Cracking the Movement, The Media Archive) and co-founder of Internet projects such as The Digital City, Nettime, Fibre-culture and Incommunicado. He is founder and director of the Institute of Network Cultures (www.networkcultures.org), professor at Interactive Media (Hogeschool van Amsterdam) and associate professor at the Media & Culture department, University of Amsterdam. His web archive: www.laudanum.net/geert.

Christoph Spehr, political theorist, editor, author of *The Aliens Are Amongst Us* and *The Eco-Trap*. He works for the Rosa-Luxemburg-Foundation at Berlin (the political foundation of the German Left Party), for the internationalist magazine *alaska* and as a free lecturer and author. His collaborative video work with Jörg Windszus includes *Go On You Free Pigs*, *Time Is On My Side*, *The P-Files*, and others. He is organizer of the conference/festival series *Out of this world - Science-Fiction, Politics, Utopia* and contributes to the HKWM project (Historical-Critical Dictionary of Marxism).

Trebor Scholz works both collaboratively and individually as an artist, writer, activist, and organizer. In 2004 Scholz founded the Institute for Distributed Creativity (iDC), a research network that concentrates on cooperation studies www.distributedcreativity.org. In 2005

the Institute organized “Share, Share Widely,” the first large North American conference about media art education at the CUNY Graduate Center <www.newmediaeducation.org>. In April 2004, together with Geert Lovink, he organized the conference Free Cooperation on the art of (online) collaboration, held at SUNY Buffalo <www.freecooperation.org>. He currently is professor and researcher in the Department of Media Study at the State University of New York at Buffalo. www.collectivate.net